

Tadabbur of the Quran through the Lens of Key Terms

By

Dr. Mamdouh M. Salama

Life Fellow of the Americal Society
of Mechanical Engineers (ASME)

Researcher and Scholar

Dr. Ismail I. Al-Shirbini

Director General of Educational
Technical Affairs, Al-Azhar
University

Forward

**Prof. Dr. Muhammad
Abdul Rahim Al-Bayoumi**

Former Dean, Faculty of Usul al-
Din, Al-Azhar University

Former Secretary-General,
Supreme Council for Islamic
Affairs

Review and Preface

**Prof. Dr. Muhammad
Mahmoud Al-Jubbah**

Assistant Professor of Linguistics,
Faculty of Islamic and Arabic
Studies – Al-Azhar University
Member, Al-Azhar International
Center for Electronic Fatwa

In the Name of Allah,
the Rahman, the Most Merciful

Tadabbur of the Qur'an through the Lens of Key Terms

Scholarly reviewed by professors of Al-Azhar University

Empowering every Muslim to engage directly with the Qur'an
through authentic Tadabbur.

By combining spiritual reflection with intellectual inquiry, this
book provides a practical methodology for understanding Allah's
guidance and building a deeper, lifelong relationship with His
Book.

Contents

FOREWORD	6
PREFACE	18
INTRODUCTION	23
Part One: Foundations of Tadabbur	29
Chapter 1. Tadabbur is a Divine Command	29
Chapter 2: Causes of Religious Corruption	34
Chapter 3: The Qur'an is Made Easy	59
Chapter 4: The Muhkamat and the Mutashabihat	63
Part Two: The Quranic Method of Tadabbur	74
Chapter 1: Conditions of Tadabbur	75
Chapter 2: The Tools of Tadabbur	81
Chapter 3: Types of Tadabbur	85
Chapter 4. Determining Meanings of Qur'anic Key Terms	92
PART 3: The Quranic Meaning of Key Terms	95
1. The Awliya of Allah (أولياء الله)	95
2. Taqwa (تقوى) and Mutaqun (متقون)	100
3. Iman (Faith) and the Mu'minun (Believers)	125
4. The Righteous Slaves of Al-Rahman (عباد الرحمن)	136
5. Worship (Ibadah) and the Worshippers	146
6. The Meaning of Al-Rahman (الرحمان)	162
7. Haneef (حنيف)	178
8. Knowledge (Ilm), Assumption (Zann), and Doubt (Shakk)	186
9. Guidance (Hidayah) and Misguidance (Dalal)	194
10. Love, Fear, Reverential Awe and Hope	202
Part 4: Poems	212
A Believer's Covenant	212
Those Who Turned from the Straight Path	215
Bibliography	216
A Note on Methodology	216
Primary Sources	217
About the Authors	219

FOREWORD

Prof. Dr. Muhammad Abdul Rahim Al-Bayoumi

Former Dean, Faculty of Usul al-Din, Al-Azhar University

Former Secretary-General, Supreme Council for Islamic Affairs

(The original version of this forward that was handwritten by Dr. Muhammad Abdul Rahim Al-Bayoumi is included in the Arabic edition of this book. For this English edition, it has been translated and stylistically edited to preserve the author's intended meaning while reflecting the conventions of contemporary English academic writing).

The Horizon of Tadabbur and the Dimensions of Revelation: A Contemplative Reading in the Light of Revelation and the Guidance of Intellect

In the Name of Allah, Al-Rahman, the Most Merciful

Every meaningful journey begins with a first step, and the journey toward Allah begins when the human heart encounters the light of His revelation. Throughout history, the Noble Qur'an has illuminated minds, purified hearts, and guided humanity from the darkness of ignorance to the light of truth. It is not merely a sacred text to be recited, nor simply a book to be studied. It is Allah's final revelation to mankind, a living source of guidance that speaks to every generation, every society, and every sincere seeker of truth.

The Qur'an was revealed not merely to convey information, but to transform the human being. It addresses the intellect without

neglecting the heart, awakens the conscience without suppressing reason, and nurtures both spiritual and moral excellence. Through its guidance, humanity is invited to rise above the limitations of material existence and discover the higher purpose for which it was created.

Standing before the Qur'an, one soon realizes that its wisdom surpasses the limits of human thought. Its words are neither the product of philosophical speculation nor the reflections of human genius; they are the speech of the Creator, whose knowledge encompasses all things. Every verse carries guidance, every chapter reveals purpose, and every passage contributes to a coherent vision of life that enables human beings to understand themselves, their Creator, and their place within His creation.

For this reason, the Qur'an repeatedly calls its readers not merely to recite its verses but to reflect upon them. It is this profound reflection that the Qur'an describes as **tadabbur**.

Tadabbur is far more than careful reading or intellectual analysis. It is a comprehensive engagement with Divine revelation through which the believer seeks to understand Allah's message, internalize its guidance, and translate it into righteous action. The purpose of tadabbur is therefore not simply to increase knowledge, but to transform knowledge into faith, faith into character, and character into a life lived in accordance with the will of Allah.

In this sense, tadabbur is neither an exercise of the intellect alone nor an experience of the heart alone. Rather, it is the

harmonious interaction of mind, heart, and soul under the guidance of revelation. The intellect reflects, the heart responds, and the soul is transformed. True understanding is achieved only when these dimensions work together.

Accordingly, the knowledge produced through tadabbur differs fundamentally from knowledge pursued for its own sake. It is a living knowledge that shapes the individual from within. It does not separate understanding from moral responsibility, nor scholarship from spiritual growth. The Qur'an was never intended to remain an object of study alone; it was revealed to become the guiding force of human life.

This balanced understanding protects the believer from two opposite extremes. One reduces the Qur'an to an academic subject whose verses are analyzed solely through linguistic, historical, or philosophical methods while neglecting their transformative purpose. The other abandons disciplined scholarship altogether, relying only upon personal feelings and subjective impressions. The Qur'anic methodology rejects both approaches. It calls for a reflection in which sound reasoning operates under the guidance of revelation and sincere faith illuminates the intellect without replacing it.

The Qur'an itself emphasizes that this path has been made accessible to every sincere seeker. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلَقَدْ يَسَّرْنَا الْقُرْآنَ لِلذِّكْرِ فَهَلْ مِنْ مُدْرِكٍ﴾ [القمر: ١٧].

"And We have certainly made the Qur'an easy for remembrance. So, is there anyone who will take heed?" (Al-Qamar 54:17)

This remarkable declaration does not imply that the Qur'an is simplistic or that its meanings are exhausted by a single reading. Rather, it affirms that Allah has made His Book accessible while preserving the infinite depth of its guidance. Every believer can benefit from it according to his or her sincerity, knowledge, and capacity for reflection.

The ordinary believer finds comfort, guidance, and reassurance in its verses. The student of knowledge discovers principles that shape understanding and practice. The scholar uncovers ever-deeper linguistic, legal, theological, and civilizational insights. Across every generation, the Qur'an continues to reveal new dimensions of wisdom without ever departing from its original message.

The Divine facilitation mentioned in this verse manifests itself in two complementary ways.

First, the Qur'an has been made easy to remember. Its unique eloquence, rhythm, and structure enable millions of believers throughout the world to memorize it in its entirety. Its recitation touches the heart before it engages the intellect, producing a spiritual effect unmatched by any human speech.

Second, the Qur'an has been made easy to understand in its essential guidance. Its central teachings concerning faith, worship,

morality, justice, and human purpose are presented with remarkable clarity. Every sincere reader can comprehend the foundations of guidance, even while recognizing that deeper levels of understanding continue to unfold through lifelong study and reflection.

This Divine ease, however, should never be confused with the absence of discipline. The Qur'an invites every believer to reflect, but it also establishes principles that safeguard reflection from error. Genuine tadabbur requires humility before the text, respect for its language, and a willingness to allow the Qur'an itself to guide the reader's understanding.

For this reason, the journey of tadabbur is both an intellectual and a spiritual journey. It begins with reading, matures through reflection, and ultimately bears fruit in transformation. The believer who approaches the Qur'an with sincerity soon discovers that its guidance is not confined to the pages of a book; it becomes a living reality that shapes thought, character, and action.

The Divine invitation to reflect upon the Qur'an is both open and disciplined. Allah has made His Book accessible to every sincere believer, yet He has also established principles that safeguard its understanding. Tadabbur is therefore neither unrestricted personal opinion nor the exclusive domain of specialists. It is a journey open to every believer, provided it is undertaken with sincerity, humility, and respect for the methodology established by the Qur'an itself.

This balance becomes possible because the human being was created with complementary faculties that work together in receiving Divine guidance. The intellect seeks understanding, the heart responds with faith, and the soul is transformed through obedience. When these faculties function in harmony, the Qur'an becomes not merely an object of study but a living guide that shapes one's entire way of thinking and living.

Within this integrated understanding, tadabbur unfolds through two complementary dimensions that together form a complete methodology for engaging with Divine revelation.

The first dimension is **spiritual tadabbur**. Here the believer approaches the Qur'an not merely as a reader but as a servant standing before his Lord. The verses are no longer perceived as historical statements or abstract teachings; they become a living conversation between Allah and His servant.

As the believer reflects upon the Divine words with sincerity and humility, the heart begins to respond before the intellect has fully completed its analysis. Such reflection transforms the inner life. It softens hearts hardened by worldly distractions, awakens the conscience from heedlessness, and restores to the believer an awareness of Allah's continual presence.

In this way, tadabbur becomes an act of worship. Understanding is measured not only by intellectual comprehension but also by the extent to which the Qur'an reshapes one's character and draws the believer closer to Allah.

The second dimension is **intellectual tadabbur**. Allah repeatedly calls upon humanity to think, reason, observe, compare, and reflect. The Qur'an does not discourage intellectual inquiry; rather, it elevates it by directing reason toward the discovery of Divine wisdom.

This dimension of tadabbur employs the intellectual tools that Allah has bestowed upon humanity. It explores the meanings of words, examines the relationships between verses, studies the objectives of Divine legislation, and seeks to understand the coherence and unity of the Qur'anic message. It considers linguistic expression, historical context, legal principles, and the universal laws that govern both human nature and civilization.

Reason, however, never stands above revelation. It serves revelation. The intellect is not invited to judge the truth of Allah's words but to strive continually for a deeper understanding of their meanings and purposes. Sound reasoning therefore becomes an instrument through which the believer uncovers the harmony, precision, and wisdom embedded within the Divine discourse.

These two dimensions are not competing approaches. Each requires the other.

Spiritual reflection without sound methodology may become vulnerable to subjective impressions that cannot be verified by the Qur'an itself. Conversely, intellectual analysis without faith and spiritual humility risks reducing the Qur'an to an academic subject whose transformative power is lost.

The Qur'anic approach unites both. Faith inspires the search for understanding, while disciplined understanding deepens faith. The heart protects the intellect from arrogance, and the intellect protects the heart from illusion. Together they produce a believer whose understanding is both intellectually sound and spiritually alive.

This harmony reflects the Qur'an's own view of the human being. Man is neither a purely rational creature detached from spiritual longing nor a spiritual being unconcerned with disciplined thought. For this reason, genuine tadabbur is never satisfied with emotional inspiration alone, nor with intellectual mastery alone. Its true fruit is the transformation of the whole person.

Such transformation requires more than sincerity. It requires a sound methodology.

The first foundation is respect for the language of the Qur'an. Allah chose Arabic as the vehicle of His final revelation, and its meanings cannot be fully appreciated without attention to its vocabulary, rhetorical style, and modes of expression. Precision in language protects the reader from imposing meanings upon the text that it was never intended to convey.

Another essential principle is recognizing that **the Qur'an explains itself**. Its verses form a coherent and integrated whole. No passage should be interpreted in isolation from the rest of the Book. The clear and decisive verses (*muhkamat*) provide the foundation upon which the deeper understanding of the *mutashabihat* is built.

This internal coherence protects the interpreter from fragmentary readings and preserves the unity of the Qur'anic message.

Yet no methodology can compensate for a heart closed to guidance. The Qur'an repeatedly reminds us that arrogance, prejudice, injustice, and persistent sin veil the heart from recognizing the truth. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿سَأَصْرِفُ عَنْ آيَاتِيَ الَّذِينَ يَتَكَبَّرُونَ فِي الْأَرْضِ بِغَيْرِ الْحَقِّ﴾
[الأعراف: ١٤٦]

"I will turn away from My signs those who behave arrogantly upon the earth without right." (Al-A'raf 7:146).

For this reason, humility, sincerity, repentance, and moral integrity are not merely virtues of the believer; they are prerequisites for benefiting from the guidance of the Qur'an. Knowledge reaches its fullest fruit only when it is joined with purity of heart and sincerity of purpose.

When scholarship and spiritual refinement come together, tadabbur becomes what Allah intended it to be: a path that enlightens the mind, purifies the heart, and prepares the believer to fulfill his responsibility as Allah's servant and vicegerent upon the earth.

When individuals reform their beliefs, intentions, values, and conduct, societies gradually reflect those same qualities. Conversely, when corruption takes root within hearts, it inevitably appears in families, institutions, and nations. In this way, the

Qur'an teaches that the renewal of civilization is inseparable from the renewal of the human soul.

For this reason, tadabbur is far more than a method of interpreting Scripture. It is a comprehensive philosophy of learning, self-development, and civilizational renewal. It liberates the intellect from blind imitation without surrendering it to skepticism, and it anchors intellectual inquiry within the certainty of Divine revelation. It cultivates independent thinking while preserving complete fidelity to the guidance of Allah.

The Muslim Ummah stands today in urgent need of such a balanced methodology. Many contemporary challenges arise not from a lack of access to the Qur'an, but from a weakening of our relationship with it. Some approach the Qur'an primarily as a historical document or an academic discipline, while others read it devotionally without developing the disciplined reflection through which its guidance transforms thought and conduct. Genuine renewal requires both sincere faith and sound understanding.

Whenever disciplined scholarship is joined with humility, sincerity, and moral integrity, the treasures of the Qur'an continue to unfold. Its verses become more than objects of study; they become a source of wisdom that shapes character, guides decision-making, strengthens communities, and inspires humanity to pursue justice, mercy, and excellence. Through this living relationship with revelation, the believer discovers not only answers to individual questions but also a comprehensive vision of life rooted in the guidance of Allah.

It is within this vision that the present work has been written.

Its purpose is to present tadabbur as a practical Qur'anic methodology derived from the Qur'an itself, a methodology that integrates faith with reason, spirituality with disciplined scholarship, and reflection with righteous action. It emphasizes the Qur'an's own principles of interpretation, especially the relationship between the **muhkamat** and the **mutashabihat**, and demonstrates how the Qur'an explains itself through its own coherent and integrated message.

I extend my sincere gratitude to the two distinguished scholars whose efforts contributed to this work: Dr. Mamdouh Salama, Life Fellow of the American Society of Mechanical Engineers (ASME), researcher, Islamic lecturer, and author; and Dr. Ismail Elshirbini, Director General of Technical Educational Affairs at Al-Azhar. Their collaboration has been instrumental in shaping this project.

It is my hope that this work will benefit researchers, students of knowledge, educators, imams, and all believers who seek a deeper relationship with the Book of Allah. May it encourage its readers not merely to recite the Qur'an, but to reflect upon it with understanding, to live by its guidance with sincerity, and to allow its wisdom to shape their character, their communities, and their contribution to humanity.

The chapters that follow invite the reader on this journey of tadabbur. Their aim is not only to deepen the understanding of

Allah's Book, but also to cultivate hearts that live by its guidance, minds that reflect upon its wisdom, and lives transformed by its timeless message.

I ask Allah, the Most High, to accept this effort, to place it among the good deeds of its authors, to make it sincerely devoted to His pleasure, and to grant that every reader finds in it guidance, benefit, and a renewed appreciation for the inexhaustible treasures of His Noble Book.

Dr. Muhammad Abdul Rahim Al-Bayoumi

July 2026

PREFACE

Prof. Dr. Muhammad Mahmoud Al-Jubbah

*Assistant Professor of Linguistics, Faculty of Islamic and Arabic
Studies – Al-Azhar University*

Member, Al-Azhar International Center for Electronic Fatwa

Praise be to Allah, who made His Book a guidance for humanity and a healing for what is within the hearts. May peace and blessings be upon our master Muhammad, who was sent with the Qur'an as light, guidance, and mercy to all worlds, and upon his family, his Companions, and all who follow his path until the Day of Judgment.

To proceed:

Speaking about *tadabbur* of the Book of Allah, Exalted is He, is to speak about the very essence of the Qur'an's message and purpose. The Qur'an was not revealed merely to be recited by the tongue, but to be reflected upon, so that its guidance may be drawn out and its light may illuminate faith, refine conduct, and contribute to the reform of both the individual and society.

This is where the value of this book becomes clear. It addresses one of the most important educational and faith-related concerns of our time. It brings the meaning of *tadabbur* closer to the reader, removes misconceptions that have become attached to it, and presents it in an accessible and practical form, grounded in reverence for Revelation and in a direct connection between the Muslim and the Book of his Lord, while preserving the foundations

of sound understanding and the methodology of the people of knowledge.

The value of this book is not limited to its treatment of a noble Qur'anic subject. It is also evident in its method, which combines Islamic grounding, educational guidance, and practical application. It avoids academic complexity that may alienate general readers, while also avoiding a merely exhortative style that lacks scholarly grounding.

The book presents the concept of *tadabbur* within its proper framework. It distinguishes between *tadabbur* and *tafsir*, removes confusion surrounding the subject, and nurtures within the reader confidence in the possibility of benefiting directly from the Book of Allah according to recognized Islamic guidelines. This gives the work both scholarly and educational value, and makes it especially needed at a time when calls to return to the Qur'an are many, yet practical clarification of the path to reflecting upon it remains limited.

The importance of this book is further increased by the fact that its two authors did not intend it for one particular environment alone. Rather, they intended it as a scholarly and educational contribution that transcends geographical boundaries. This work was prepared while one of them resided in the United States of America, and the other maintained regular engagement with the United States and other Western countries. Both kept in mind the need of Muslims in those societies for a sound scholarly discourse that introduces them to the true meaning of *tadabbur* and brings

them closer to the Book of Allah upon the guidance of Ahl al-Sunnah wa al-Jama‘ah, far from both excess and negligence.

For this reason, this work was prepared in both Arabic and English, so that it might reach a broad segment of Muslims, especially the younger generation and the children of Muslim communities. Their need is great for such well-grounded works, which combine soundness of belief, clarity of expression, and excellence of presentation. Such works help strengthen their connection with the Noble Qur’an, reinforce their faith-based identity in environments where influences and challenges are many, and assist them in building a conscious relationship with the Book of Allah, a relationship that bears the fruit of correct understanding, righteous action, and steadfastness upon guidance.

In reviewing this book, there was sincerity of purpose in serving the Noble Qur’an, sound intention in bringing its meanings closer to readers, and a well-structured approach in presenting its themes. It also showed clear care for the educational and faith-related dimensions, and for linking the reader to the inward and outward actions that are the fruit of true *tadabbur*. The work is further distinguished by a style that is close to people’s understanding, combining simplicity of expression with depth of meaning. It addresses the reader in thoughtful language, free from artificiality and obscurity, making it beneficial for a wide range of readers and students of knowledge.

It was an honor to review this book and to contribute to preparing it in a scholarly and linguistic form befitting its subject

and its educational and academic value. Effort was exerted in correcting grammatical, morphological, linguistic, and spelling errors; in refining the language in accordance with the principles and rules of Arabic; in documenting quotations and information; in verifying texts; and in attending to punctuation and placing it in its proper locations. This was done in a manner that contributes to clarity of meaning, soundness of language, beauty of presentation, and preservation of the spirit of the text and the authors' style.

The review also included the scholarly dimension of the book. Prophetic hadiths and reports cited in it were verified and traced to their recognized original sources. Material for which no reliable source could be found was removed. Some expressions were reviewed and refined in a manner consistent with the belief and methodology of Ahl al-Sunnah wa al-Jama'ah. In addition, certain scholarly sections were completed by adding supporting incidents and reports, as well as explanatory paragraphs that clarify the intended meaning and complete the scholarly structure of the material presented. Throughout this process, care was taken to preserve the authors' style and original ideas, without intervention except to the extent required by sound expression, accuracy of transmission, precision of documentation, and consistency of scholarly methodology.

It is hoped that this book will find its proper place among works that contribute to reviving the connection of Muslims with the Book of their Lord, and that it will be a beneficial contribution to spreading the culture of sound *tadabbur*: one based on knowledge, regulated by the principles of the Shari'ah, and joining

understanding of the text with acting upon it.

Allah, Exalted is He, is asked to accept from its authors their effort, to make this work sincerely for His noble Face, to bless its impact, and to benefit its readers through it. He is also asked to grant all of us excellence in reflecting upon His Book, being guided by its guidance, and acting according to what it contains. Indeed, He is the Guardian of that and fully able to accomplish it.

Prof. Dr. Muhammad Mahmoud Al-Jubbah

July 2026

INTRODUCTION

Dr. Mamdouh M. Salama

Dr. Ismail I. Al-Shirbini

All praise is due to Allah, who revealed the Book to His servant and placed no crookedness in it. He made it a light, a guidance, and a mercy for the believers, filled with wisdom, admonition, and insight through which hearts are purified, minds are enlightened, and lives are transformed. Praise is due to Him for the blessing of the Noble Qur'an, and thanks are due to Him for the guidance He has granted His servants. We witness that there is no god but Allah alone, without partner, and that Muhammad صلى الله عليه وسلم is His servant and Messenger, who faithfully conveyed the Revelation and embodied its teachings in every aspect of his life. May Allah's peace and blessings be upon him, his family, his Companions, and all who follow his guidance until the Day of Judgment.

Every generation of Muslims is called to renew its relationship with the Qur'an. While the Qur'an itself has been perfectly preserved, engagement with it often requires renewal. Many Muslims recite its verses, memorize portions of it, and listen attentively to its recitation. Yet many remain uncertain about how to engage its guidance in a personal and transformative way, allowing it to shape faith, character, decisions, and daily life.

This book is an invitation to rediscover that living relationship through *tadabbur*, deep reflection upon the Qur'an as Allah intended. It is built upon a simple but essential conviction:

the Qur'an was not revealed merely to be recited, but to be understood, reflected upon, and lived. Allah reminds us repeatedly that He has made the Qur'an accessible for remembrance and reflection:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلَقَدْ يَسَّرْنَا الْقُرْآنَ لِلذِّكْرِ فَهَلْ مِنْ مُدْرِكٍ﴾ [القمر: ١٧].

"And We have certainly made the Qur'an easy for remembrance, so is there anyone who will take heed?" (Al-Qamar 54:17)

This divine invitation raises an important question: if the Qur'an has been made accessible, why do so many hesitate to engage with it directly?

For many, this hesitation arises from a sincere desire to avoid speaking about Allah without knowledge. Others feel that they lack the Arabic language, scholarly training, or familiarity with the Islamic sciences required for proper understanding. While this caution reflects reverence for the Qur'an, it has also led to a widespread misconception: that meaningful engagement with the Qur'an is reserved primarily for specialists. A central cause of this misunderstanding is the confusion between tafsir and tadabbur.

Tafsir is the scholarly discipline concerned with explaining the meanings intended by Allah, based on established principles of Qur'anic interpretation. It requires expertise in the Arabic language, the sciences of the Qur'an, the Sunnah, and the broader

tradition of Islamic scholarship. Tadabbur, however, is of a different nature.

It is the believer's personal engagement with the Qur'an, reading with attentiveness and reflection, and allowing its verses to illuminate belief, refine character, strengthen faith, and guide conduct. While sound tadabbur remains grounded in the principles established by the scholars and does not contradict authentic tafsir, it is not limited to scholars. Rather, it is a form of worship to which every believer is invited. This distinction is essential.

Not every Muslim is qualified to derive legal rulings or resolve theological questions. Yet every Muslim is invited to ask:

- What is Allah teaching through this verse?
- What quality is He calling me to develop?
- What action is He asking to be taken?
- How should this guidance shape my relationship with Him and with His creation?

These are the questions of tadabbur.

One of the greatest barriers between many Muslims and the Qur'an is not the complexity of the text itself, but the assumption that one must first attain a certain level of scholarship before benefiting directly from its guidance. The Qur'an presents a different reality.

This book seeks to remove that barrier. Its central message is simple: tadabbur is accessible to every sincere believer. By

“accessible,” this does not mean that every legal, linguistic, theological, or interpretive issue can be grasped without study. Islamic scholarship remains indispensable for preserving sound understanding. Rather, it means that the door to benefiting from the Qur’an, reflecting upon its guidance, allowing its message to reform the heart, and applying its teachings to life, is open to every believer who approaches it with sincerity, humility, and a willingness to listen.

The accessibility of tadabbur arises not from extraordinary intellectual ability, but from the mercy of Allah and the nature of the Qur’an itself. The Qur’an speaks to the heart as well as the mind. It awakens faith, stimulates reflection, nurtures wisdom, and directs the human being to the signs of Allah within the self and throughout creation. Reading the Qur’an without tadabbur resembles consuming nourishing food without digesting it: the nourishment is present, but its benefit remains unrealized.

This book is not a work of tafsir, nor is it an academic treatise on the sciences of Qur’anic interpretation. It is a practical guide designed to help every sincere reader develop a direct, meaningful, and disciplined relationship with the Book of Allah. It explores two complementary dimensions of tadabbur.

The first is spiritual tadabbur, the engagement of the heart. Here, the Qur’an becomes more than words to be recited; it becomes a source of supplication, sincere repentance, gratitude, hope, and inner transformation.

The second is intellectual tadabbur, the engagement of the mind. Here, the reader seeks to understand Qur'anic key concepts as the Qur'an itself defines them, allowing the Book to explain its own terms rather than relying primarily on assumptions formed outside its textual framework. By tracing key concepts across the Qur'an, a deeper appreciation emerges of the coherence and precision of Divine guidance.

Together, these two dimensions engage both heart and intellect, enabling the believer to experience the Qur'an as a comprehensive guide for faith, character, and life.

Throughout this book, readers will find practical methods, clear examples, and guided exercises that demonstrate how tadabbur can become a natural part of daily engagement with the Qur'an. No extraordinary ability is required, only sincerity, patience, thoughtful reflection, and a genuine desire to be guided by the words of Allah.

As this journey unfolds, the Qur'an gradually becomes more than a book to be read. It becomes a trusted companion, one that speaks to circumstances, answers questions, comforts the heart, challenges assumptions, and continually guides the believer toward the Creator.

The aim of this work is not only to explain tadabbur, but to help the reader experience it. Verses that once seemed familiar begin to reveal new depths of meaning, and the relationship with

the Qur'an becomes more personal, more thoughtful, and more transformative.

Let this journey begin with confidence in Allah's promise, not in human ability. Let Him be asked to open the treasures of His Book, to make the Qur'an the spring of hearts, the light of chests, the remover of worries, and the guide to all that pleases Him.

The first step on the path of tadabbur is therefore not the accumulation of knowledge, but sincerity of intention, presence of heart, and a willingness to listen attentively to the words of Allah.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿كِتَابٌ أَنْزَلْنَاهُ إِلَيْكَ مُبَارَكٌ لِيَدَّبَّرُوا آيَاتِهِ وَلِيَتَذَكَّرَ أُولُو الْأَلْبَابِ﴾ [ص: ٢٩]

"This is a blessed Book which We have revealed to you so that they may reflect upon its verses and that those of understanding may take heed." (Sad 38:29)

May Allah make us among those who reflect upon His Book, live by its guidance, and are transformed by its light. Amin.

The Authors

Dr. Mamdouh M. Salama

Dr. Ismail I Al-Shirbini

Part One: Foundations of Tadabbur

Chapter 1. Tadabbur is a Divine Command

Allah, Exalted is He, revealed the Noble Qur'an so that people may reflect upon its verses, understand its guidance, and act upon its commands. It was not revealed merely to beautify voices in recitation. Rather, Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿كَتَبْنَا أَنْزَلْنَاهُ إِلَيْكَ مُبَارَكٌ لِيَدَّبَّرُوا آيَاتِهِ وَلِيَتَذَكَّرَ أُولُوا الْأَلْبَابِ﴾
(ص: ٢٩)

“This is a blessed Book which We have revealed to you, so that they may reflect upon its verses and that those of understanding may take heed.” (Sad 38:29)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَفَلَا يَتَذَكَّرُونَ الْقُرْآنَ أَمْ عَلَى قُلُوبٍ أَقْفَالُهَا﴾ (محمد: ٢٤)

“Do they not then reflect upon the Qur'an, or are there locks upon their hearts?” (Muhammad 47:24)

These verses and others like them show that Tadabbur is not merely a recommended virtue. Rather, it is one of the essential purposes for which the Qur'an was revealed.

The scholars of Islam have likewise emphasized that Tadabbur is the living spirit of Qur'anic recitation and the fruit that the reader should seek. Thus, Tadabbur is the ideal way to transform Qur'anic recitation from a repeated habit into an act of worship that revives hearts, reforms souls, and guides human beings through the paths of life.

If a person sincerely seeks to know anything about the religion of Islam, there is no source more truthful, more reliable, or more authoritative than the Book of Allah. It is the foundation of all knowledge and the criterion by which every other source of knowledge is evaluated. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَنَزَّلْنَا عَلَيْكَ الْكِتَابَ تَبْيِينًا لِّكُلِّ شَيْءٍ وَهُدًى وَرَحْمَةً وَبُشْرَىٰ

لِّلْمُسْلِمِينَ﴾ (النحل: ٨٩)

"And We have sent down to you the Book as a clarification of all things, a guidance, a mercy, and glad tidings for the Muslims." (Al-Naḥl 16:89)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ هَٰذَا الْقُرْآنَ يَهْدِي لِلَّتِي هِيَ أَقْوَمُ﴾ (الإسراء : ٩)

"Indeed, this Qur'an guides to that which is most upright." (Al-Isra 17:9)

Reading the Noble Qur'an without reflection and

contemplation inevitably limits one's understanding and prevents a person from fully benefiting from its guidance. Just as no one can benefit from food without eating it, a Muslim cannot truly benefit from the Qur'an without engaging thoughtfully with its meanings. For this reason, Tadabbur is an act of worship that Allah has invited all people to practice. Through reflection, contemplation, and mindful consideration, the believer moves beyond mere recitation to a living interaction with the words of Allah.

There is no disagreement among Muslims that the primary sources of Islamic legislation and religious knowledge are, first and foremost, the Noble Qur'an, followed by the authentic Sunnah of the Prophet ﷺ, which explains and clarifies it. From these two primary sources emerge the recognized principles of Islamic scholarship and juristic reasoning that address new circumstances and changing realities.

The Qur'an therefore occupies the highest position in the hierarchy of knowledge. It is the ultimate reference by which beliefs are corrected, acts of worship are regulated, moral values are established, and human conduct is guided. Whenever differences arise, it is to the Qur'an that Muslims ultimately return, for it is the final criterion between truth and falsehood.

A Muslim should therefore strive to reflect upon the verses of the Qur'an according to his or her ability, allowing them to reveal their guidance, admonition, and direction. For this reason, the first responsibility of anyone seeking to understand the religion is to approach the Qur'an through conscious reading and sincere

Tadabbur. The reader should continually ask himself:

What does Allah want from me in this verse?

When this question accompanies every reading, the Qur'an is transformed from a book that is merely recited into a living guide that directs one's life. It ceases to be simply a text that is memorized and becomes a comprehensive methodology by which faith, character, and conduct are shaped.

Restoring the Qur'an to its rightful place as the primary source of knowledge and guidance is therefore not merely an academic undertaking. It is an educational, spiritual, and civilizational necessity. The reform of both the individual and the Ummah begins by restoring the Qur'an to the central position Allah intended for it.

For this reason, Tadabbur is a divine command. It is the means by which people return to the straight path, correct their method of receiving guidance, and learn to derive their religion first and foremost from divine revelation. Thereafter, everything else is understood in the light of that blessed revelation. As Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿لَقَدْ أَنْزَلْنَا آيَاتٍ مُبِينَاتٍ وَاللَّهُ يَهْدِي مَنْ يَشَاءُ إِلَى صِرَاطٍ مُسْتَقِيمٍ﴾

(النور: ٤٦)

"Indeed, We have sent down to you clear verses, and

Allah guides whom He wills to a straight path." (*Al-Nur 24:46*)

In this way, Tadabbur becomes a balanced journey, one that combines personal reflection upon Allah's Book with the guidance of sound scholarship, enabling the believer to draw continuously from the inexhaustible treasures of the Qur'an.

Chapter 2: Causes of Religious Corruption

The corruption that afflicted the divine revelations before Islam did not occur because the revelations themselves were deficient. Rather, it resulted from a gradual departure from the principles upon which Allah revealed them. Over time, false beliefs and misguided practices were introduced, obscuring the purity of divine guidance and distancing people from the message that Allah had revealed.

Among the most significant causes of this corruption were two fundamental deviations:

First: The belief that an intermediary is necessary between the servant and his Lord because Allah should be approached primarily through fear.

Second: The claim that the understanding and interpretation of divine revelation belong exclusively to a privileged class of religious authorities.

Islam came to abolish both of these deviations. It restored the direct relationship between the human being and his Creator, free from every form of priesthood or spiritual mediation, and it restored the Qur'an as guidance for all humanity. Every believer is invited to read it, reflect upon it, and benefit from its guidance while referring matters requiring specialized knowledge to qualified scholars.

The following sections examine these two causes of religious

corruption and demonstrate how the Qur'an safeguards the purity of revelation by preserving both the believer's direct relationship with Allah and his direct engagement with the divine message.

First: Rejecting the Belief That an Intermediary Is Necessary Between the Servant and His Lord

One of the most serious deviations that affected earlier religious communities was the belief that human beings could not approach Allah directly and therefore required intermediaries to convey their prayers, seek His pleasure, or obtain His forgiveness.

This misconception eventually led people to elevate certain individuals or objects to the status of intermediaries between themselves and Allah. Even the pagan Arabs of Makkah did not claim that their idols created the heavens and the earth or possessed independent divine power. Rather, they justified their worship by claiming that these idols merely brought them nearer to Allah.

Allah, the Exalted, records their claim:

قال تعالى: ﴿مَا نَعْبُدُهُمْ إِلَّا لِيُقَرِّبُونَا إِلَى اللَّهِ زُلْفَى﴾ (الزمر: ٣)

"We only worship them so that they may bring us nearer to Allah." (Al-Zumar 39:3)

Elsewhere, He says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَمْ اتَّخَذُوا مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ شُفَعَاءَ﴾ (الزمر: ٤٣)

"Or have they taken intercessors besides Allah?" (Al-Zumar 39:43)

And He says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَيَعْبُدُونَ مِن دُونِ اللَّهِ مَا لَا يَضُرُّهُمْ وَلَا يَنْفَعُهُمْ وَيَقُولُونَ هَؤُلَاءِ شُفَعَاؤُنَا عِنْدَ اللَّهِ﴾ (يونس: ١٨)

"They worship besides Allah that which neither harms them nor benefits them, and they say, 'These are our intercessors with Allah.'" (Yunus 10:18)

These verses expose the false foundation upon which the idea of spiritual intermediaries was built. What began as a claim of seeking nearness to Allah eventually became an act of worship directed to other than Him.

To eliminate this dangerous misconception completely, Allah revealed one of the most remarkable verses in the Qur'an concerning His closeness to His servants. Throughout the Qur'an, when people ask the Prophet ﷺ about matters of religion, Allah frequently instructs him to reply by saying, **"Say" (Qul)**. Yet when the question concerns Allah's nearness to His servants, the command **"Say"** is omitted altogether. Instead, Allah answers the question directly Himself:

﴿وَإِذَا سَأَلَكَ عِبَادِي عَنِّي فَإِنِّي قَرِيبٌ أُجِيبُ دَعْوَةَ الدَّاعِ إِذَا دَعَانِ فَلْيَسْتَجِيبُوا لِي وَلْيُؤْمِنُوا بِي لَعَلَّهُمْ يَرْشُدُونَ﴾ (البقرة: ١٨٦)

"And when My servants ask you concerning Me, indeed I am near. I answer the supplication of the supplicant whenever he calls upon Me. So let them respond to Me and believe in Me,

that they may be rightly guided." (Al-Baqarah 2:186)

The omission of the word "Say" is deeply significant. It emphasizes that no intermediary stands between Allah and His servants in matters of prayer, supplication, or seeking His guidance. Every believer may turn to Him directly, confident that He hears, knows, and responds according to His perfect wisdom.

The Believer's Relationship with Allah Is Founded upon Love, Hope, and Reverential Fear

The Qur'an rejects the notion that a believer's relationship with Allah should be founded upon fear alone. Fear, when isolated from hope and love, can lead to despair and distance a person from his Lord. Likewise, love without reverential fear may lead to complacency and false security, while hope without sincere effort may encourage negligence.

Instead, the Qur'an establishes a balanced relationship between the believer and his Creator, one founded upon love, hope, and reverential fear (khashyah). These three qualities complement one another and together produce a sincere, balanced, and enduring faith.

Allah describes His righteous servants by saying:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّهُمْ كَانُوا يُسْرِعُونَ فِي الْخَيْرَاتِ وَيَدْعُونَنَا رَغَبًا وَرَهَبًا وَكَانُوا لَنَا خَاشِعِينَ﴾ (الأنبياء: ٩٠)

"Indeed, they used to hasten to good deeds, and they

would call upon Us in hope and fear, and they were humbly submissive before Us." (Al-Anbiya 21:90)

Similarly, Allah reassures His servants that His mercy always remains open to those who sincerely repent:

قال تعالى: ﴿قُلْ يَاعِبَادِيَ الَّذِينَ أَسْرَفُوا عَلَىٰ أَنْفُسِهِمْ لَا تَقْنَطُوا مِن رَّحْمَةِ اللَّهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَغْفِرُ الذُّنُوبَ جَمِيعًا إِنَّهُ هُوَ الْغَفُورُ الرَّحِيمُ﴾ (الزمر: ٥٣)

"Say, 'O My servants who have transgressed against themselves, do not despair of the mercy of Allah. Indeed, Allah forgives all sins. He is truly the All-Forgiving, the Most Merciful.'" (Al-Zumar 39:53)

At the same time, the Qur'an teaches that true love for Allah is not merely an emotion, but a way of life reflected in faith, humility, obedience, and service. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا مَنْ يَرْتَدَّ مِنكُمْ عَن دِينِهِ ۖ فَسَوْفَ يَأْتِي اللَّهَ بِقَوْمٍ يُحِبُّهُمْ وَيُحِبُّونَهُ ۖ أَذِلَّةٌ عَلَى الْمُؤْمِنِينَ أَعِزَّةٌ عَلَى الْكَافِرِينَ يُجَاهِدُونَ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَلَا يَخَافُونَ لَوْمَةَ لَائِمٍ ۚ ذَٰلِكُمْ فَضْلُ اللَّهِ يُؤْتِيهِ مَن يَشَاءُ ۗ وَاللَّهُ وَاسِعٌ عَلِيمٌ﴾ (المائدة: ٥٤)

"O you who believe! Whoever among you turns back from his religion, Allah will bring forth a people whom He loves and who love Him, humble toward the believers, firm against the disbelievers, striving in the cause of Allah, and

fearing the blame of no critic. That is the bounty of Allah, which He grants to whom He wills. Allah is All-Encompassing, All-Knowing." (Al-Ma'idah 5:54)

Thus, the believer seeks Allah's love while fearing His displeasure and hoping continually for His mercy. This balanced relationship protects the heart from two dangerous extremes: despair, which results from excessive fear, and false security, which results from misplaced confidence.

The Qur'an therefore does not portray Allah merely as One to be feared. Rather, it introduces Him as the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate, the Oft-Forgiving, and the Most Loving, while reminding His servants that He is also Perfectly Just and fully aware of every deed. Through this balance, the believer develops a relationship with Allah that inspires obedience through love, restrains sin through reverential fear, and sustains perseverance through hope.

Those Whom Allah Loves

One of the remarkable features of the Qur'an is that Allah does not leave the characteristics of those whom He loves undefined. Instead, He clearly identifies the qualities that earn His love, enabling every believer to strive consciously toward them.

Among those whom Allah loves are:

- **Those who excel in doing good (al-muḥsinun).** (*Al-Baqarah*

2:195)

- **Those who constantly repent and purify themselves.** (*Al-Baqarah 2:222*)
- **Those who fulfill their promises and are mindful of Allah.** (*Al Imran 3:76*)
- **Those who are patient and steadfast.** (*Al Imran 3:146*)
- **Those who place their trust in Allah.** (*Al Imran 3:159*)
- **Those who act with justice.** (*Al-Maidah 5:42*)

These are not abstract ideals. They are practical qualities that every believer can cultivate through sincere faith and righteous action.

Those Whom Allah Does Not Love

Just as the Qur'an identifies the qualities that earn Allah's love, it also warns against characteristics that incur His displeasure.

Among those whom Allah does not love are:

- the transgressors,
- those who spread corruption on the earth,
- those who persist in usury,
- those who reject obedience to Allah and His Messenger,
- the wrongdoers,
- the arrogant and boastful,
- those who betray trust,
- those who openly proclaim evil without justification,
- the corrupters,
- the wasteful,

- the treacherous,
- the arrogant,
- and those who betray Allah and His Messenger.

By presenting both categories side by side, the Qur'an gives believers a clear moral compass. It does not merely command righteousness in general terms; rather, it defines the qualities that lead to Allah's pleasure and those that lead to His displeasure. The believer's task is therefore to cultivate the attributes beloved to Allah while diligently avoiding those that distance him from His mercy.

Second: Rejecting the Belief that Reading and Reflecting upon Revelation Is Reserved for Scholars Alone

Another major cause of the corruption of earlier revelations was the claim, promoted by certain religious authorities, that the understanding and interpretation of divine revelation belonged exclusively to them. Ordinary people were discouraged, or even forbidden, from reading the revealed scriptures for themselves. As a result, revelation gradually became separated from the people it was meant to guide, allowing human interpretations and personal interests to overshadow the original message.

The Qur'an warns against this abuse of religious authority, condemning those who altered or concealed Allah's revelation for worldly gain:

قال تعالى: ﴿فَوَيْلٌ لِلَّذِينَ يَكْتُبُونَ الْكِتَابَ بِأَيْدِيهِمْ ثُمَّ يَقُولُونَ هَذَا مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ لِيَشْتَرُوا بِهِ ثَمَنًا قَلِيلًا فَوَيْلٌ لَهُمْ مِمَّا كَتَبَتْ أَيْدِيهِمْ وَوَيْلٌ لَهُمْ مِمَّا يَكْسِبُونَ﴾ (البقرة: ٧٩)

"So woe to those who write the Book with their own hands and then say, 'This is from Allah,' in order to exchange it for a small price. Woe to them for what their hands have written, and woe to them for what they earn." (Al-Baqarah 2:79)

Islam came to restore revelation to its rightful place, as guidance for all humanity. The Qur'an repeatedly invites every believer to read, reflect, and benefit from its guidance according to his or her capacity, while referring matters requiring specialized knowledge to those qualified in the Islamic sciences.

Allah emphasizes the accessibility of the Qur'an by declaring:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلَقَدْ يَسَّرْنَا الْقُرْآنَ لِلذِّكْرِ فَهَلْ مِنْ مُدْرِكٍ﴾ (القمر: ١٧)

"And We have certainly made the Qur'an easy for remembrance; so is there anyone who will take heed?" (Al-Qamar 54:17)

This divine invitation would have little meaning if the Qur'an were intended to remain inaccessible except through a privileged class of interpreters. Rather, Allah made His Book understandable to the extent necessary for guidance, while leaving certain areas of detailed interpretation and legal deduction to those equipped with

the necessary knowledge.

At the same time, the Qur'an teaches that benefiting from revelation depends not only upon intellectual ability but also upon the condition of the heart. One of the greatest obstacles to understanding the Qur'an is not a lack of intelligence, but a heart hardened by sin, prejudice, or the pursuit of personal desires.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَفَلَا يَتَذَكَّرُونَ الْقُرْآنَ أَمْ عَلَىٰ قُلُوبٍ أَقْفَالُهَا﴾ (محمد: ٢٤)

“Do they not then reflect upon the Qur'an, or are there locks upon their hearts?” (Muḥammad 47:24)

Allah says regarding the Children of Israel:

قال تعالى: ﴿فَبِمَا نَقْضِهِمْ مِيثَاقَهُمْ لَعَنَّاهُمْ وَجَعَلْنَا قُلُوبَهُمْ قَاسِيَةً يُحَرِّفُونَ الْكَلِمَ عَن مَّوَاضِعِهِ ۖ وَنَسُوا حَظًّا مِّمَّا ذُكِّرُوا بِهِ ۚ﴾ (المائدة: ١٣)

"...But because they broke their covenant, We cursed them and made their hearts hard. They distort words from their proper places and forgot a portion of what they had been reminded of..." (Al-Ma'idah 5:13)

Likewise, Allah teaches that ultimate success belongs to those who come before Him with a sound heart:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَوْمَ لَا يَنْفَعُ مَالٌ وَلَا بَنُونَ (٨٨) إِلَّا مَنْ أَتَى اللَّهَ بِقَلْبٍ سَلِيمٍ (٨٩)﴾
(الشعراء: ٨٨، ٨٩)

"The Day when neither wealth nor children will benefit anyone, except one who comes to Allah with a sound heart."
(*Al-Shu'ara* 26:88–89)

These verses remind us that understanding the Qur'an is not merely an intellectual exercise. It is also a spiritual journey. The more sincere a believer is in seeking the truth, the more receptive his heart becomes to Allah's guidance. Conversely, when a person's heart is dominated by pride, prejudice, blind partisanship, or an unquestioning attachment to inherited customs, these become veils that obscure the guidance of the Qur'an.

For this reason, Tadabbur requires more than careful reading. It requires sincerity, humility, and a genuine willingness to submit to whatever guidance Allah reveals.

The Proper Role of Scholars in Understanding Revelation

Recognizing that every Muslim is encouraged to read and reflect upon the Qur'an does not diminish the importance of scholars. On the contrary, Islam holds knowledge and those who possess it in the highest esteem. The Qur'an repeatedly honors people of knowledge and encourages believers to seek learning throughout their lives.

At the same time, the Qur'an carefully defines the role of

scholars. One verse frequently cited in this context is Allah's command:

قال تعالى: ﴿فَسْأَلُوا أَهْلَ الذِّكْرِ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ﴾ (النحل: ٤٣) (الأنبياء: ٧)

"So, ask the people of knowledge if you do not know."

(*Al-Nahl* 16:43; *Al-Anbiya* 21:7)

However, it is important to observe the context of these verses. They occur within the discussion on the nature of previous messengers and affirm that those who possess historical knowledge should be consulted to confirm their human nature. They do not suggest that ordinary believers are prohibited from reading or reflecting upon revelation themselves. Rather, they establish the principle that when a matter exceeds one's knowledge, one should seek guidance from those qualified to explain it.

When the Qur'an speaks of the excellence of scholars, and that they are the only ones who have true reverenace awe of Allah.

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى اللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ الْعُلَمَاءُ﴾ (فاطر: ٢٨)

"Only those of His servants who possess knowledge truly stand in awe of Allah." (*Faṭīr* 35:28)

The immediate context of this verse points to those who study and understand the natural world, fields such as climatology, botany, geology, biology, zoology, and related sciences. Through

their study of Allah's creation, they come to recognize His wisdom, power, and majesty more deeply, and it is this knowledge that gives rise to true reverential awe (khashyah) of Allah.

These verses reveal an important reality. The more one learns about the universe and reflects upon its remarkable order, the more one appreciates the greatness, wisdom, and majesty of its Creator.

For this reason, the Prophet ﷺ greatly emphasized the pursuit of knowledge. He said:

"Whoever follows a path in pursuit of knowledge, Allah will make easy for him a path to Paradise. The angels lower their wings in approval of the seeker of knowledge. Everyone in the heavens and on the earth, even the fish in the depths of the sea, seeks forgiveness for the scholar. The superiority of the scholar over the devoted worshipper is like the superiority of the full moon over all the stars. Indeed, the scholars are the heirs of the prophets. The prophets did not leave behind dinars or dirhams; rather, they left knowledge. Whoever acquires it has obtained a great share."

The Prophet ﷺ deliberately used the indefinite word **"knowledge"** (*'ilm*), without restricting it to one particular discipline. Many scholars have therefore understood this encouragement to include every branch of beneficial knowledge that enables human beings to recognize Allah's signs, serve His creation, and fulfill their responsibilities on earth.

Accordingly, the Qur'an presents several complementary paths through which believers deepen their knowledge of Allah.

1. Reflecting upon Allah's Creation

Allah has made the universe itself a vast collection of signs pointing to His existence, power, wisdom, and mercy. The study of nature, the human body, the heavens, and the intricate laws governing creation enables thoughtful people to recognize the greatness of their Creator. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ فِي خَلْقِ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلَافِ اللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهَارِ وَالْفَلَكَ الَّتِي تَجْرِي فِي الْبَحْرِ بِمَا يَنْفَعُ النَّاسَ وَمَا أَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مِنْ مَّاءٍ فَأَحْيَا بِهِ الْأَرْضَ بَعْدَ مَوْتِهَا وَبَثَّ فِيهَا مِنْ كُلِّ دَابَّةٍ وَتَصْرِيفِ الرِّيْحِ وَالسَّحَابِ الْمُسَخَّرِ بَيْنَ السَّمَاءِ وَالْأَرْضِ لَآيَاتٍ لِقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ﴾ (البقرة: ١٦٤)

"Indeed, in the creation of the heavens and the earth, the alternation of night and day, the ships that sail through the sea with what benefits mankind, the water Allah sends down from the sky giving life to the earth after its death, the creatures He has dispersed throughout it, the changing of the winds, and the clouds suspended between heaven and earth are signs for people who use their reason." (Al-Baqarah 2:164)

Scientific investigation, when pursued with sincerity and humility, therefore becomes another avenue through which

believers witness the majesty of Allah's creation and deepen their faith.

2. Studying the Qur'an and Reflecting upon Its Guidance

While the study of Allah's creation deepens our awareness of His power and wisdom, the Qur'an itself remains the primary source of divine guidance. Through its narratives, parables, commandments, moral teachings, and comprehensive worldview, believers gain a deeper understanding of Allah's justice, mercy, wisdom, and purpose for human life. Allah describes the Qur'an as:

قال تعالى: ﴿ذَٰلِكَ الْكِتَابُ لَا رَيْبَ فِيهِ هُدًى لِّلْمُتَّقِينَ﴾ (البقرة: ٢)

"This is the Book about which there is no doubt, a guidance for those who are mindful of Allah." (Al-Baqarah 2:2)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿كِتَابٌ أَنزَلْنَاهُ إِلَيْكَ مُبَارَكٌ لِّيَدَّبَّرُوا آيَاتِهِ وَلِيَتَذَكَّرَ أُولُوا الْأَلْبَابِ﴾

(ص: ٢٩)

"This is a blessed Book which We have revealed to you so that they may reflect upon its verses and that those endowed with understanding may take heed." (Sad 38:29)

Furthermore, Allah reminds humanity that the Qur'an is the light through which people are guided from darkness into light:

قَالَ تَعَالَى: ﴿كَثِيرٌ قَدْ جَاءَكُمْ مِنَ اللَّهِ نُورٌ وَكِتَابٌ مُبِينٌ (١٥) يَهْدِي بِهِ اللَّهُ
مَنِ اتَّبَعَ رِضْوَانَهُ سُبُلَ السَّلَامِ وَيُخْرِجُهُم مِّنَ الظُّلُمَاتِ إِلَى النُّورِ بِإِذْنِهِ وَيَهْدِيهِمْ إِلَى
صِرَاطٍ مُسْتَقِيمٍ (١٦)﴾ (المائدة: ١٥-١٦)

"There has certainly come to you from Allah a light and a clear Book, by which Allah guides those who seek His pleasure to the ways of peace, brings them out from darkness into light by His permission, and guides them to a straight path." (Al-Ma'idah 5:15–16)

The study of the Qur'an therefore differs fundamentally from the study of any other book. It is not merely an intellectual exercise, nor simply an academic discipline. It is an act of worship through which the believer listens to the words of his Creator, allowing them to shape his beliefs, refine his character, and direct every aspect of his life.

For this reason, Tadabbur occupies a central place in the believer's pursuit of knowledge. The more deeply one reflects upon the Qur'an, the more clearly one perceives the coherence of its message and the perfection of Allah's guidance.

3. Reflecting upon Allah's Beautiful Names and Perfect Attributes

Allah did not reveal His Names merely to be memorized; He revealed them so that His servants might know Him, love Him,

worship Him, and call upon Him with understanding and certainty.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلِلَّهِ الْأَسْمَاءُ الْحُسْنَىٰ فَادْعُوهُ بِهَا﴾ (الأعراف: ١٨٠)

"To Allah belong the Most Beautiful Names, so call upon Him by them." (Al-A'raf 7:180)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿هُوَ اللَّهُ الَّذِي لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ عِلْمُ الْغَيْبِ وَالشَّهَادَةِ هُوَ الرَّحْمَنُ الرَّحِيمُ﴾ (الحشر: ٢٢)

"He is Allah, there is no deity except Him, the Knower of the unseen and the seen. He is the Rahman, the Most Merciful." (Al-Hashr 59:22)

The passage continues by mentioning many of Allah's Beautiful Names and concludes:

قال تعالى: ﴿لَهُ الْأَسْمَاءُ الْحُسْنَىٰ يُسَبِّحُ لَهُ مَا فِي السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَهُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ﴾ (الحشر: ٢٤)

"...To Him belong the Most Beautiful Names. Whatever is in the heavens and the earth glorifies Him. He is the Almighty, the All-Wise." (Al-Hashr 59:24)

Through reflecting upon these Names and Attributes, the believer develops a more complete and balanced understanding of his Lord. He comes to know Allah not only as the Creator and Sustainer, but also as the Most Merciful, the All-Wise, the Oft-Forgiving, the All-Knowing, the Most Just, and the One worthy of complete trust, love, and worship.

A Note on Allah's Attributes

Throughout Islamic history, some Muslims became preoccupied with theological disputes concerning Allah's Attributes. In their sincere desire to avoid likening Allah to His creation, some denied or reinterpreted certain attributes that Allah explicitly affirmed for Himself in the Qur'an.

The Qur'an itself, however, establishes the correct balance. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿لَيْسَ كَمِثْلِهِ شَيْءٌ وَهُوَ السَّمِيعُ الْبَصِيرُ﴾ (الشورى: ١١)

"There is nothing whatsoever like Him, and He is the All-Hearing, the All-Seeing." (Al-Shura 42:11)

This verse combines two complementary principles: it categorically denies any resemblance between Allah and His creation while affirming the attributes by which He has described Himself. Accordingly, Muslims affirm Allah's Names and Attributes as they appear in the Qur'an and the authentic Sunnah, without likening them to creation, without denying them, without

distorting their meanings, and without inquiring into their modality.

The primary purpose of studying Allah's Attributes is therefore not speculative theological debate, but increasing one's knowledge of Allah, strengthening faith, and deepening one's love, trust, and worship of Him.

Following the Evidence Rather than Blind Imitation

Allah commands believers to know Him through His revelation and through reflecting upon His creation. This does not mean disregarding the scholarship of those who have devoted their lives to understanding the Qur'an and the Sunnah. Rather, it means that accepting an opinion is not based merely upon the status of the one expressing it, but upon the strength of its evidence. This principle is of great importance for two reasons.

First: The Proof Lies in Revelation, Not in Individuals

In Islam, ultimate authority belongs to Allah and His Messenger ﷺ. Every opinion, regardless of its source, is accepted or rejected according to its conformity with the Qur'an and the authentic Sunnah.

For this reason, Islamic law does not permit unquestioning obedience to any individual. Blindly following another person without evidence may gradually lead a person away from the guidance of revelation.

The Prophet ﷺ himself explained this principle while

commenting on Allah's statement:

قال تعالى: ﴿اتَّخَذُوا أَحْبَارَهُمْ وَرُهْبَنَهُمْ أَرْبَابًا مِّن دُونِ اللَّهِ﴾ (التوبة: ٣١)

"They took their rabbis and monks as lords besides Allah..." (*Al-Tawbah* 9:31)

When Adi ibn Hatim remarked, "We did not worship them,"

the Prophet ﷺ replied:

"Did they not make lawful for you what Allah had forbidden, and you accepted it as lawful? And did they not forbid what Allah had made lawful, and you accepted it as forbidden?"

When Adi answered, "Yes," the Prophet ﷺ said:

"That was your worship of them."

This profound explanation demonstrates that religious authority must never supersede the authority of divine revelation.

Absolute obedience belongs only to Allah and His Messenger ﷺ. Allah repeatedly commands:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَأَطِيعُوا اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ﴾ (آل عمران: ١٣٢)

"Obey Allah and the Messenger." (*Al Imran* 3:132)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَأَطِيعُوا اللَّهَ وَأَطِيعُوا الرَّسُولَ وَاحْذَرُوا فَإِنْ تَوَلَّيْتُمْ فَأَعْلَمُوا أَنَّمَا عَلَى رَسُولِنَا الْبَلَاغُ الْمُبِينُ﴾ (المائدة: ٩٢)

"Obey Allah and obey the Messenger, and beware! But if you turn away, then know that upon Our Messenger is only the clear conveyance of the message." (Al-Ma'idah 5:92)

And He says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَأَطِيعُوا اللَّهَ وَرَسُولَهُ وَلَا تَنَازَعُوا فَتَفْشَلُوا وَتَذْهَبَ رِيحُكُمْ﴾ (الأنفال: ٤٦)

"Obey Allah and His Messenger, and do not dispute with one another lest you lose courage and your strength depart." (Al-Anfal 8:46)

Yet, even in the pledge of allegiance given to the Prophet صلی اللہ علیہ وسلم, obedience was conditioned by what is **right and proper (al-ma'ruf)**. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلَا يَعْصِيَنَّكَ فِي مَعْرُوفٍ﴾ (المتحنة: ١٢)

"...that they will not disobey you in what is right..." (Al-Mumtahanah 60:12)

This condition teaches an enduring principle: obedience in Islam is always connected to obedience to Allah and His revelation.

The Early Imams Warned Against Blind Imitation

The danger of blind imitation deeply concerned the leading scholars of the early generations. Although they devoted their lives to understanding Islam, they consistently warned their students never to follow them blindly.

Al-Rabi' ibn Sulayman narrated that Imām al-Shafi compared the person who gathers knowledge indiscriminately to someone collecting firewood at night:

"He gathers a bundle of wood, unaware that a snake may be hidden within it."

Likewise, Imam Malik emphasized that judgments of lawful and unlawful ultimately belong to Allah and His Messenger alone. He discouraged people from speaking carelessly in Allah's name and preferred expressions such as, *"We dislike this,"* or, *"We consider this preferable,"* whenever definitive evidence was lacking. The humility of the four great Imams is beautifully summarized in the well-known verses of Shaykh Muḥammad ibn Saʿīd ibn Safar al-Madani: **Abu Ḥanifah said:**

It is not permissible for anyone who has accepted Islam

To adopt my opinion until he knows the evidence upon which it is based.

Malik said, pointing toward the Prophet's grave:

Every person's words may be accepted or rejected—except those of the occupant of this grave.

Al-Shafiؒ said:

If you find my opinion contradicting an authentic hadith, then set my opinion aside.

Aḥmad ibn Ḥanbal said:

Do not imitate me, nor Mqlik, nor al-Shafi, nor al-Thawri. Rather, take from the sources from which they took.

These statements reveal the remarkable humility of the great Imams. Their objective was never to create personal schools demanding unquestioning loyalty, but to guide Muslims toward a deeper understanding of Allah's revelation.

Second: Every Person Will Stand Before Allah Alone

A second reason for avoiding blind imitation is that every individual will stand before Allah alone on the Day of Judgment. No scholar, teacher, or religious leader will bear responsibility for another person's choices.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَقَالَ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا لِلَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اتَّبِعُوا سَبِيلَنَا وَلْنَحْمِلْ خَطَايَكُمْ وَمَا هُمْ بِحَامِلِينَ مِنْ خَطَايَهُمْ مِنْ شَيْءٍ إِنَّهُمْ لَكَاذِبُونَ﴾ (العنكبوت: ١٢)

"Those who disbelieve say to those who believe, 'Follow our way, and we will carry your sins.' But they will not carry any of their sins. Indeed, they are liars." (Al-'Ankabut 29:12–13)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلَقَدْ جِئْتُمُونَا فُرَادَىٰ كَمَا خَلَقْنَاكُمْ أَوَّلَ مَرَّةٍ﴾ (الأنعام: ٩٤)

"And you have come to Us alone, just as We created you the first time..." (Al-An'am 6:94)

And He says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَكُلَّ إِنسَانٍ أَلْزَمْنَاهُ طَلَبَهُ فِي عُنُقِهِ﴾ (الإسراء)

"We have fastened every person's destiny to his own neck..." (Al-Isra 17:13)

Finally, Allah declares:

قال تعالى: ﴿بَلِ الْإِنْسَانُ عَلَىٰ نَفْسِهِ بَصِيرَةٌ﴾ (القيامة: ١٤)

"Rather, man will be a witness against himself." (Al-Qiyamah 75:14)

These verses emphasize a fundamental principle of Islam: faith, understanding, and obedience are ultimately personal responsibilities. Every individual will answer before Allah for what he believed, how he sought the truth, and how faithfully he followed His guidance.

For this reason, Islam closes every door that could lead to the corruption of revelation or the distortion of the believer's relationship with his Lord. There is no intermediary between the servant and Allah in worship or supplication, no priesthood that monopolizes access to revelation, and no human authority whose opinions override the Qur'an and the authentic Sunnah.

At the same time, Islam honors scholars as inheritors of the prophets, encourages believers to seek knowledge from them, and commands consultation whenever specialized understanding is required. In this balanced framework, revelation remains protected, scholarship fulfills its proper role, and every believer bears personal responsibility before Allah for responding to His guidance.

Chapter 3: The Qur'an is Made Easy

One of the distinguishing characteristics of the Noble Qur'an is that Allah Himself describes it as a Book made easy for remembrance, reflection, and guidance. This divine declaration establishes a fundamental principle that shapes the believer's relationship with the Qur'an: while some aspects of its interpretation require specialized knowledge, its essential guidance has been made accessible to every sincere seeker.

Allah repeats this remarkable declaration four times in Surat al-Qamar:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلَقَدْ يَسَّرْنَا الْقُرْآنَ لِلذِّكْرِ فَهَلْ مِنْ مُدَكِّرٍ﴾ (القمر: ١٧)

"And We have certainly made the Qur'an easy for remembrance; so is there anyone who will take heed?" (Al-Qamar 54:17)

The same verse is repeated again in verses 22, 32, and 40, emphasizing its importance.

The repetition is itself significant. Rarely does the Qur'an repeat an identical statement four times within a single chapter. This repetition leaves no doubt that Allah intends His servants to approach His Book with confidence rather than hesitation. He has not revealed a book that only a select few may benefit from; He has revealed guidance for all humanity.

The expression **"made easy for remembrance"** encompasses far more than the memorization of words. It includes ease in recitation, ease in remembering its guidance, and ease in benefiting from its teachings. The Qur'an addresses the human heart in language that is clear, persuasive, and transformative, enabling sincere believers to understand its central message regardless of their educational background.

This does not imply that every verse is equally simple or that every aspect of Qur'anic interpretation requires no scholarship. The Qur'an itself acknowledges that some verses require deeper knowledge and careful explanation. Nevertheless, its primary guidance, the truths necessary for faith, worship, righteous character, and salvation, is presented with clarity so that every believer may benefit from it according to his or her capacity.

This understanding removes one of the greatest psychological barriers that prevents many Muslims from engaging directly with the Qur'an. Some imagine that unless they have mastered Arabic, studied the classical sciences, or attained the rank of scholars, meaningful Tadabbur is beyond their reach. The Qur'an itself refutes this assumption by repeatedly inviting all people to reflect upon its verses.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَفَلَا يَتَدَبَّرُونَ الْقُرْآنَ أَمْ عَلَىٰ قُلُوبٍ أَقْفَالُهَا﴾ (محمد: ٢٤)

"Do they not then reflect upon the Qur'an? Or are there

locks upon their hearts?" (*Muhammad* 47:24)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَفَلَا يَتَدَبَّرُونَ الْقُرْآنَ وَلَوْ كَانَ مِنْ عِنْدِ غَيْرِ اللَّهِ لَوَجَدُوا فِيهِ
اٰخْتِلَافًا كَثِيرًا﴾ (النساء: ٨٢)

"Do they not then reflect upon the Qur'an? Had it been from anyone other than Allah, they would have found within it many inconsistencies." (*Al-Nisa* 4:82)

These verses do not address scholars alone. They address humanity. The invitation to Tadabbur is universal because the Qur'an was revealed as guidance for all people.

The ease promised by Allah, however, is inseparable from sincerity. A heart that approaches the Qur'an seeking guidance will find guidance, while a heart clouded by arrogance, prejudice, or the persistent rejection of truth may fail to perceive what is otherwise clear.

For this reason, Allah frequently links guidance with faith and God-consciousness (*taqwa*). The obstacle is rarely the Qur'an itself; more often, it is the condition of the reader's heart.

The believer should therefore approach the Qur'an with humility, seeking guidance rather than merely information. Tadabbur is not an exercise in intellectual curiosity alone; it is an

act of worship through which one listens attentively to the words of Allah, allowing them to illuminate the heart, reform one's character, and guide one's life.

When Allah declares that He has made the Qur'an easy, the believer should accept this promise with confidence. He should neither underestimate the depth of the Qur'an nor exaggerate its difficulty. Between these two extremes lies the balanced Qur'anic approach: continual reflection, lifelong learning, consultation with qualified scholars when needed, and complete trust that Allah has made His guidance accessible to every sincere servant.

The Qur'an therefore remains a living book. Every reading reveals new insights, every reflection deepens understanding, and every sincere engagement strengthens one's relationship with Allah. This continual renewal is one of the miracles of the Qur'an and one of the greatest blessings granted to those who devote themselves to its Tadabbur.

Chapter 4: The Muhkamat and the Mutashabihat

To benefit fully from the Noble Qur'an, every Muslim should understand Allah's own classification of its verses. Allah, the Exalted, has divided the verses of the Qur'an into two categories: **Muhkamat (Definitive Verses)** and **Mutashabihat (Allegorical or Ambiguous Verses)**. Recognizing the distinction between these two categories is essential for sound understanding, proper Tadabbur, and protection from misunderstanding the Book of Allah. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿هُوَ الَّذِي أَنْزَلَ عَلَيْكَ الْكِتَابَ مِنْهُ آيَاتٌ مُحْكَمَاتٌ هُنَّ أُمُّ الْكِتَابِ وَأُخَرُ مُتَشَابِهَاتٌ فَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ فِي قُلُوبِهِمْ زَيْغٌ فَيَتَّبِعُونَ مَا تَشَابَهَ مِنْهُ ابْتِغَاءَ الْفِتْنَةِ وَابْتِغَاءَ تَأْوِيلِهِ ۚ وَمَا يَعْلَمُ تَأْوِيلَهُ إِلَّا اللَّهُ ۗ وَالرَّاسِخُونَ فِي الْعِلْمِ يَقُولُونَ ءَامَنَّا بِهِ ۚ كُلٌّ مِنْ عِنْدِ رَبِّنَا وَمَا يَذَّكَّرُ إِلَّا أُولُو الْأَلْبَابِ﴾ (آل عمران: ٧)

"He is the One who has sent down to you the Book. In it are verses that are definitive (Muhkamat); they are the foundation of the Book. Others are Mutashabihat. As for those in whose hearts is deviation, they follow that which is Mutashabih, seeking discord and seeking its interpretation. But no one knows its ultimate interpretation except Allah. And those firmly grounded in knowledge say, 'We believe in it; all of it is from our Lord.' Yet none take heed except those endowed

with understanding." (*Al Imran 3:7*)

This noble verse establishes a fundamental principle for understanding the Qur'an. Not all verses are of the same nature. Some are clear, decisive, and serve as the foundation upon which the religion is built, while others require careful reflection and must always be understood in light of the definitive verses.

To benefit properly from the Qur'an, every Muslim should know what Allah has required him to understand and act upon. This begins with recognizing the distinction between these two categories of verses.

Allah has divided the verses of the Qur'an into two types:

1. **Muhkamat (Definitive Verses):** These are the clear and decisive verses whose meanings are evident. They establish the foundations of faith, define the essential principles of worship, provide the basic framework of Islamic law, and present the moral and spiritual guidance upon which the religion rests.

2. **Mutashabihat (Mutashabih Verses):** These are verses whose meanings may not be immediately apparent or whose full implications may not be readily understood, even by scholars. Their interpretation requires careful study and must always remain consistent with the guidance established by the Muhkamat.

The Qur'an itself describes the Muhkamat as "**the foundation of the Book**" (**Umm al-Kitab**). This description is profoundly significant. Just as a building depends upon a firm foundation, every correct understanding of the Qur'an must rest

upon these definitive verses. Whenever uncertainty arises regarding the meaning of a Mutashabih verse, it should be understood in light of the Muhkamat rather than independently of them.

This Qur'anic methodology protects believers from misunderstanding revelation and from building beliefs or legal rulings upon verses that are capable of more than one interpretation while neglecting the clear principles established elsewhere in the Qur'an.

For this reason, those whose hearts sincerely seek guidance begin with the Muhkamat, allowing them to illuminate the rest of the Qur'an. Those, however, whose hearts incline toward deviation reverse this process. They isolate the Mutashabihat from their Qur'anic context, pursue speculative interpretations, and neglect the clear guidance that Allah has established as the foundation of His Book.

The believers, on the other hand, adopt a different attitude. They recognize that the entire Qur'an comes from Allah, believe in all of it, and approach its verses with humility, seeking guidance rather than controversy. Whenever they encounter a verse whose meaning is not immediately apparent, they return it to the clear and definitive teachings of the Muhkamat, confident that the Qur'an explains itself and that its guidance is internally consistent.

This balanced approach preserves both certainty and humility. It enables believers to benefit from the clarity of the Muhkamat while acknowledging that some aspects of Allah's

revelation require deeper knowledge and continued reflection.

The Qur'an does not present the existence of the Mutashabihat as a deficiency or a source of confusion. Rather, they form part of Allah's wisdom in revealing His Book. Together, the Muhkamat and the Mutashabihat constitute a complete and harmonious revelation, each serving a distinct purpose within Allah's divine plan.

The Muhkamat provide certainty. They establish the foundations of faith, define the essential acts of worship, set forth the principles of lawful and unlawful, and present the moral values upon which the Muslim's life is built. Because they are clear and decisive, they leave no room for uncertainty regarding the fundamental teachings of Islam.

The Mutashabihat, on the other hand, invite reflection, contemplation, and intellectual effort. They encourage believers to deepen their understanding of the Qur'an, to compare its verses, and to appreciate the remarkable harmony of Allah's revelation. Their presence also distinguishes those who sincerely seek guidance from those who seek confusion and controversy.

For this reason, Allah immediately describes the differing attitudes of two groups of people after mentioning the Muhkamat and the Mutashabihat.

The first group consists of those whose hearts have deviated from the truth:

قال تعالى: ﴿مُتَشَبِّهَاتٌ فَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ فِي قُلُوبِهِمْ زَيْغٌ فَيَتَّبِعُونَ مَا تَشَبَّهَ مِنْهُ ابْتِغَاءَ
الْفِتْنَةِ وَابْتِغَاءَ تَأْوِيلِهِ﴾ (آل عمران: ٧)

"As for those in whose hearts is deviation, they pursue that which is Mutashabih, seeking discord and seeking its interpretation." (Al Imran 3:7)

Rather than beginning with the clear and definitive teachings of the Qur'an, they focus on verses that may admit more than one understanding. They isolate such verses from their broader Qur'anic context and attempt to build beliefs or arguments upon them while neglecting the Muhkamat that constitute the foundation of the Book.

The second group is described as **those firmly grounded in knowledge**. Their response is entirely different:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَالرَّاسِخُونَ فِي الْعِلْمِ يَقُولُونَ ءَامَنَّا بِهِ كُلٌّ مِنْ عِنْدِ رَبِّنَا﴾ (آل عمران: ٧)

"Those firmly grounded in knowledge say, 'We believe in it; all of it is from our Lord.'" (Al Imran 3:7)

Their certainty does not arise from claiming to know everything. Rather, it arises from their complete trust that the entire Qur'an is the word of Allah and that no verse contradicts another. Whenever they encounter a verse whose meaning is not immediately clear, they interpret it in light of the Muhkamat, confident that Allah's revelation is perfectly consistent.

This Qur'anic methodology protects believers from many forms of misunderstanding. It teaches them that the proper approach to the Qur'an is not to begin with the exceptional or the ambiguous, but with what Allah Himself has made clear. Once the foundations are firmly established, the remaining verses find their proper place within the overall message of the Qur'an.

Accordingly, the Muhkamat serve as the criterion by which every interpretation is evaluated. Any understanding of a Mutashabih verse that contradicts the clear teachings of the Muhkamat must be rejected, for Allah's revelation cannot contradict itself.

This principle also demonstrates the remarkable coherence of the Qur'an. Its verses complement one another, explain one another, and together present a unified message. No verse should ever be understood in isolation from the rest of the Qur'an.

For this reason, one of the most important principles of Tadabbur is that **the Qur'an explains the Qur'an**. The believer does not seek the meaning of a verse independently of the Book as a whole, but studies it within the framework established by Allah Himself.

The Muhkamat therefore provide the key by which the believer safely navigates the Qur'an, while the Mutashabihat encourage continued reflection, humility, and lifelong learning. Together they lead the sincere believer to a deeper appreciation of Allah's wisdom and a more comprehensive understanding of His guidance.

The Practical Benefit of Distinguishing Between the Muhkamat and the Mutashabihat

Understanding the distinction between the Muhkamat and the Mutashabihat is not merely a theoretical discussion in the sciences of the Qur'an. Rather, it is one of the most important principles that safeguards the believer's understanding of Allah's Book and enables him to benefit from its guidance correctly.

When the believer recognizes that the Muhkamat constitute the foundation of the Qur'an, he naturally begins his journey of Tadabbur with the verses whose meanings are clear, decisive, and directly applicable. These verses establish the essential beliefs of Islam, define the principles of worship, clarify the foundations of lawful and unlawful, and set forth the moral values by which a Muslim lives.

Once these foundations become firmly established, the believer approaches the Mutashabihat with care. He understands them in the light of the Muhkamat, never allowing an interpretation of a Mutashabih verse to contradict the clear teachings that Allah has made the foundation of His Book.

This Qur'anic methodology also protects the believer from being distracted by matters that Allah has not made essential for guidance. Throughout history, many debates have centered upon questions whose answers neither increase faith nor improve one's relationship with Allah. Such discussions often consume time and effort while yielding little practical benefit.

The Qur'an directs the believer's attention instead to what reforms the heart, purifies the soul, strengthens faith, and leads to righteous action. Its primary concern is not to satisfy every intellectual curiosity, but to guide mankind to the Straight Path.

For this reason, the believer should never allow the Mutashabihat to distract him from the clear guidance of the Muhkamat. The definitive verses are sufficient to establish sound belief, righteous conduct, and the path to salvation. The Mutashabihat, meanwhile, remind us of the limits of human knowledge and teach us humility before the infinite wisdom of Allah.

This balance between certainty and humility is one of the distinguishing characteristics of the Qur'anic methodology. It gives the believer confidence in what Allah has made clear while teaching him restraint regarding matters whose full reality Allah has reserved for Himself.

Accordingly, the proper attitude of the believer is beautifully summarized in the words of those whom Allah praises:

قال تعالى: ﴿كُلُّ مِّنْ عِندِ رَبِّنَا﴾ (آل عمران: ٧)

"We believe in it; all of it is from our Lord." (Al Imran 3:7)

These words reflect complete submission to Allah's revelation. They combine firm conviction regarding the clear teachings of the Qur'an with humility concerning matters that

require deeper knowledge or whose ultimate reality remains known only to Allah.

The student of the Qur'an should therefore make the Muhkamat his constant reference point. They provide the principles by which every verse is understood, every interpretation is evaluated, and every aspect of the religion is measured. Whenever uncertainty arises, the believer returns to the Muhkamat, confident that Allah's revelation is perfectly coherent and internally consistent.

This principle will accompany us throughout the remainder of this book. As we study the Qur'an through the lens of its key terms and concepts, we should focus on the Muhkamat as the foundation upon which sound Tadabbur is built.

The Consequences of Restricting Reflection upon the Qur'an

Despite the Qur'an's repeated invitation for all believers to reflect upon its verses, some people continue to insist that understanding the Qur'an is the exclusive responsibility of those who have received formal training in the traditional religious sciences. According to this view, meaningful reflection upon the Qur'an should be limited to graduates of religious institutions. This, however, is not a position adopted by the Qur'an, nor is it the position of the scholars of Islam.

This narrow understanding has led to two major problems.

First, it has excluded specialists in the natural and social sciences, scientists, economists, engineers, physicians, geologists, biologists, mathematicians, and other experts, from contemplating the Qur'an within their own fields of expertise. It assumes that they have nothing to contribute because they are not specialists in the traditional Islamic sciences, even though the Qur'an repeatedly invites mankind to reflect upon the signs of Allah throughout creation and to contemplate the remarkable order and wisdom of the universe.

Second, it has confined the study and interpretation of the Qur'an to a limited range of academic disciplines, preventing the Ummah from benefiting from the diverse forms of knowledge that Allah has bestowed upon humanity. As a result, many contemporary manifestations of the Qur'an's guidance and many aspects of its enduring relevance to modern civilization remain unexplored.

One consequence of this restricted approach is that discussions of the Qur'an's miraculous nature are often confined almost exclusively to its linguistic eloquence. While the Qur'an's unmatched eloquence is undoubtedly one of its greatest miracles, it is by no means its only one. The Qur'an also contains profound guidance concerning the natural world, human society, moral development, civilization, and countless other fields that invite continuous reflection as human knowledge advances.

Historically, the Islamic civilization flourished when Muslims viewed all beneficial knowledge as a means of

understanding Allah's signs and fulfilling humanity's responsibility as His vicegerents on earth. During the Islamic Golden Age, scholars excelled not only in the religious sciences but also in medicine, astronomy, mathematics, engineering, chemistry, geography, agriculture, and many other disciplines. Their scientific achievements were inspired by a worldview that regarded the study of creation as another path to knowing the Creator.

Today, however, much of the Muslim world struggles to maintain leadership in many of the very fields in which it once excelled. The Qur'an has not changed. What has changed is the extent to which Muslims engage with it as a comprehensive guide for life and civilization. Restoring the Qur'an to its central place in every field of beneficial knowledge is therefore essential for the intellectual and civilizational renewal of the Ummah.

Part Two: The Quranic Method of Tadabbur

If Tadabbur is a divine command and one of the principal objectives of the Qur'an, then practicing it correctly requires understanding its foundations, becoming familiar with its tools, and recognizing both the factors that facilitate it and the obstacles that prevent one from attaining its fruits.

The purpose of this part is not to introduce complicated rules or philosophical terminology. Rather, it seeks to present practical keys that help the reader approach the Qur'an with greater understanding and benefit more fully from its guidance.

These principles are not intended to make Tadabbur difficult or to restrict it to specialists. Instead, they serve as guiding principles that help the believer reflect upon the Qur'an correctly, so that its meanings become clearer, its guidance more evident, and its transformative effect more deeply rooted in the heart and in daily life.

The chapters that follow introduce these principles in a simple and practical manner, enabling every sincere reader to strengthen his or her relationship with the Book of Allah while remaining within the sound methodology established by the Qur'an and explained by the scholars.

Chapter 1: Conditions of Tadabbur

Before discussing the conditions of Tadabbur, it is important to distinguish between Tafsir and Tadabbur.

Although the two are closely related, they are not identical.

Tafsir is the scholarly discipline concerned with explaining the meanings of the Qur'an. It examines the meanings of words, the circumstances of revelation, linguistic usage, legal rulings, and other aspects that help determine Allah's intended meaning. Because of its specialized nature, Tafsir belongs primarily to qualified scholars.

Tadabbur, by contrast, is the believer's thoughtful reflection upon the Qur'an. It seeks to understand its guidance, allow its verses to influence the heart, and translate their message into faith, character, and righteous action. Every Muslim is encouraged to practice Tadabbur, although the depth of understanding naturally varies according to one's knowledge and strength of faith.

For Tadabbur to bear its intended fruit in the heart of the reader, there is a number of conditions and etiquettes. Underlying all of them, however, is one essential quality: **Taqwa**.

Taqwa is one of the Qur'an's most fundamental concepts and will be examined in detail later in this book. For now, it is sufficient to recognize that Allah presents Taqwa as the key to receiving His guidance and increasing in knowledge. At the very beginning of the Qur'an, He describes it as:

قال تعالى: ﴿ذَٰلِكَ الْكِتَابُ لَا رَيْبَ فِيهِ هُدًى لِّلْمُتَّقِينَ﴾ (البقرة: ٢)

"This is the Book about which there is no doubt, a guidance for those who have Taqwa." (Al-Baqarah 2:2)

Later, after commanding the believers to have Taqwa, Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ اللَّهُ وَاللَّهُ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمٌ﴾ (البقرة: ٢٨٢)

"...And have Taqwa of Allah, and Allah will teach you. Allah is Knowing of all things." (Al-Baqarah 2:282)

These two verses establish a profound Qur'anic principle: **Taqwa prepares the heart to receive guidance, and guidance, in turn, leads to greater knowledge and understanding.** Thus, while the conditions discussed below help cultivate meaningful Tadabbur, they all flourish in the heart of one who seeks Allah with sincerity and Taqwa.

Among the most important of these conditions are the following:

1. Sincerity of Intention and Seeking Guidance

The reader should approach the Qur'an with a sincere intention to seek Allah's guidance and to act upon what he or she learns.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ هَذَا الْقُرْآنَ يَهْدِي لِلَّتِي هِيَ أَقْوَمُ وَيُبَشِّرُ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ الَّذِينَ يَعْمَلُونَ الصَّالِحَاتِ أَنَّ لَهُمْ أَجْرًا كَبِيرًا﴾ (الإسراء: ٩)

"Indeed, this Qur'an guides to that which is most upright and gives glad tidings to the believers who do righteous deeds that they will have a great reward." (Al-Isra 17:9)

The primary purpose of the Qur'an is guidance. Its verses were not revealed merely to be recited, but to be understood, reflected upon, and translated into righteous belief, noble character, and righteous deeds. Whenever a believer opens the Qur'an with a sincere desire to receive Allah's guidance, the heart becomes more receptive to its message, and Tadabbur becomes more meaningful and transformative.

A sincere intention also requires humility before the words of Allah. The reader approaches the Qur'an not to confirm preconceived opinions or defend personal viewpoints, but to seek the truth and willingly submit to it. Such sincerity opens the heart to the Qur'an's guidance and enables its teachings to shape one's thoughts, character, and conduct.

2. Presence of Heart and Humility

The reader should free the mind from distractions and approach the Qur'an with a heart that is present, attentive, and

humble, recognizing that these are the very words of Allah addressed personally to His servants.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَذِكْرٍ لِّمَن كَانَ لَهُ قَلْبٌ أَوْ أَلْقَى السَّمْعَ وَهُوَ شَهِيدٌ﴾ (ق: ٣٧)

"Indeed, in that is a reminder for whoever has a heart, or who listens attentively while being fully present." (Qaf 50:37)

True Tadabbur requires more than moving the eyes across the page or reciting words with the tongue. It requires the heart to listen, the mind to reflect, and the soul to respond. When the heart is present, the Qur'an ceases to be merely a text that is read; it becomes a living message that speaks directly to the believer.

3. Purity of Body and Heart

Purity has both an outward and an inward dimension. Outward purity includes physical cleanliness and observing the proper etiquette of handling the Quran. Inward purity is attained through repentance, seeking Allah's forgiveness, and cleansing the heart from sins that may veil it from understanding His words.

The most important purity for Tadabbur is the purity of the heart. Sins, arrogance, heedlessness, and attachment to desires can prevent the heart from receiving the guidance of the Qur'an. Therefore, the reader should approach the Book of Allah with

repentance, humility, and a sincere desire to be purified by its guidance.

4. Seeking Refuge in Allah and Beginning with the Basmalah

In obedience to Allah's command, the reader should begin by seeking refuge in Allah from Satan, who strives to distract the mind from reflection and to prevent the heart from benefiting from the Qur'an.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿فَإِذَا قَرَأْتَ الْقُرْآنَ فَاسْتَعِذْ بِاللَّهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ﴾ (النحل: ٩٨)

"So when you recite the Qur'an, seek refuge in Allah from Satan, the expelled." (Al-Naḥl 16:98)

After seeking refuge in Allah, the believer begins with:

"In the Name of Allah, Al Rahman, the Most Merciful."

By beginning in this way, the reader acknowledges complete dependence upon Allah, seeks His help, and prepares the heart to receive His guidance with sincerity and humility.

5. Looking Beyond the Surface Meaning

The reader should not stop at the immediate or general meaning of a verse. Rather, he or she should strive to reflect upon its deeper guidance, lessons, and practical implications.

Tadabbur begins when the reader asks not only, "**What does this verse say?**" but also, "**What does Allah want me to learn from it, and how should it change my life?**"

Chapter 2: The Tools of Tadabbur

Practical and Spiritual Tools

1. Tartil: Organizing the Verses by Topic for Reflection

After preparing the heart to receive the guidance of the Qur'an, the next essential step in the methodology of understanding is **tartil**. Here, tartil means collecting together all the verses related to a single subject and arranging them in a way that reveals their complete and integrated message.

The Noble Qur'an was not revealed as a topical book in which every subject is gathered in one place. Rather, it was revealed gradually over a period of twenty-three years, accompanying events, answering questions, and nurturing the Muslim community stage by stage. Consequently, verses dealing with the same subject are distributed throughout different surahs, with each passage contributing a new dimension or perspective. Allah alludes to this wisdom when He says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَقَالَ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا لَوْلَا نُزِّلَ عَلَيْهِ الْقُرْآنُ جُمْلَةً وَاحِدَةً ۖ كَذَٰلِكَ لِنُثَبِّتَ بِهِ ۖ فُؤَادَكَ ۖ وَرَتَّلْنَاهُ تَرْتِيلًا ۖ﴾ (الفرقان: ٣٢)

"Those who disbelieve say, 'Why was the Qur'an not revealed to him all at once?' It was revealed in this way so that We might strengthen your heart with it, and We have recited it in a measured manner (rattalnahu tartila)." (Al-Furqan 25:32)

This verse makes it clear that the Qur'an was not sent down as a single revelation, but according to a divine wisdom that takes into account the realities of life, gradual spiritual development, and progressive legislation. If revelation itself was revealed gradually for this wisdom, then understanding its subjects requires collecting together all the verses related to each topic in order to appreciate the complete picture intended by the Qur'an.

For this reason, this book adopts the method of thematic collection of verses before beginning the process of tadabbur. Limiting oneself to a single verse often leads to an incomplete understanding or neglects qualifications, exceptions, or details mentioned elsewhere in the Qur'an. This approach is also supported by Allah's description of the Qur'an as:

قال تعالى: ﴿...كُتِبَ أَحْكَمَتْ أَيْتُهُ...﴾ (هود: ١)

"...a Book whose verses have been perfected..." (*Hud* 11:1)

Although the Qur'an is one Book, it contains integrated thematic systems whose meanings become complete only when their verses are brought together and considered collectively.

This understanding is also consistent with Allah's command:

قال تعالى: ﴿...وَرَتِّلِ الْقُرْآنَ تَرْتِيلاً﴾ (المزمل: ٤)

"...and recite the Qur'an with tartil." (Al-Muzzammil 73:4)

The linguistic root of *tartil* conveys the meanings of order, harmony, and arrangement. Arabs would say that pearls are *murattal* when they are strung together in an orderly sequence, and an army is *murattal* when its ranks are well organized.

Accordingly, the command to recite the Qur'an with tartil should not be understood as referring only to beautiful pronunciation and proper tajwid. Rather, it also points to the necessity of approaching the Qur'an as a perfectly structured revelation whose verses on each subject are brought together so that their relationships and meanings become clear. In this sense, tartil becomes the foundational step upon which this book builds its methodology of tadabbur, for reflection on any Qur'anic subject cannot be complete until all of its relevant verses are gathered and studied as one integrated unit rather than as isolated texts.

2. Engaging with the Verses

Interaction with the Qur'an includes seeking Allah's forgiveness when passing by verses of warning and punishment, glorifying Him when reading verses of His transcendence, and asking Him for His bounty when reading verses describing Paradise and mercy. The reader should constantly ask: *What does this verse want from me? Where do I stand with respect to what it describes? Do I possess this quality, or do I fall short of it?*

An Important Guideline

Commendable tadabbur is that which increases a person's reverence for Allah, strengthens faith, and inspires righteous deeds. On the other hand, reflection that leads to deriving legal rulings without the necessary qualifications, indulging in speculative discussions about matters of the unseen without knowledge, or distorting the meanings of the verses by ignoring their linguistic and legislative context is blameworthy. Such an approach amounts to speaking about Allah without knowledge.

Chapter 3: Types of Tadabbur

Having established the foundations of Tadabbur, an important question naturally arises:

How does a person practice Tadabbur of the Qur'an?

To answer this question, it is helpful to distinguish between two principal types of Tadabbur: **spiritual Tadabbur** and **intellectual Tadabbur**.

Spiritual Tadabbur speaks to the heart and the soul, while **intellectual Tadabbur** engages the mind.

There is also a third type, **linguistic Tadabbur**, which seeks to uncover the Qur'an's rhetorical and linguistic miracle. Since this form of Tadabbur is generally not accessible to most Muslims whose native language is not Arabic, it falls outside the scope of this book.

1. Spiritual Tadabbur

Spiritual Tadabbur is simple and accessible. Every believer can practice it by concentrating on what he or she is reciting and transforming the meanings of the verses into sincere supplication and intimate conversation with Allah, the Exalted. For example:

- When reading verses that describe the people of Paradise or the reward prepared for the righteous, pause and ask Allah to make you among them. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَالسَّابِقُونَ السَّابِقُونَ (١٠) أُولَٰئِكَ الْمُقَرَّبُونَ (١١) فِي جَنَّاتِ النَّعِيمِ (١٢) ثَلَاثَةٌ مِّنَ الْأَوَّلِينَ (١٣) وَقَلِيلٌ مِّنَ الْآخِرِينَ (١٤) عَلَىٰ سُرُرٍ مَّوْضُونَةٍ (١٥) مُّتَّكِئِينَ عَلَيْهَا مُتَقَابِلِينَ (١٦) يَطُوفُ عَلَيْهِمْ وِلْدَانٌ مُّخْلَّدُونَ (١٧) بِأَكْوَابٍ وَأَبَارِيقَ وَكَأْسٍ مِّن مَّعِينٍ (١٨) لَا يَصَدَّعُونَ عَنْهَا وَلَا يُنْزِفُونَ (١٩) وَفَكَهْمَةٌ مِّمَّا يَخْيَرُونَ (٢٠) وَلَحْمِ طَيْرٍ مِّمَّا يَشْتَهُونَ (٢١) وَحُورٌ عِينٌ (٢٢) كَأَمْثَلِ اللَّوْلِيِّ الْمَكْنُونِ (٢٣) جَزَاءً بِمَا كَانُوا يَعْمَلُونَ (٢٤)﴾ (الواقعة: ١٠-٢٤)

"And the forerunners, the forerunners, those are the ones brought near to Allah, in the Gardens of Bliss. A multitude from the former generations and a few from the later generations, on adorned couches, reclining upon them, facing one another. There will circulate among them immortal youths with cups, pitchers, and a drink flowing from a spring, from which they will neither suffer headache nor intoxication, and with fruits of whatever they choose, and the meat of birds that they desire. And there will be companions with beautiful, wide eyes, like protected pearls, as a reward for what they used to do." (*Al-Waqi'ah* 56:10–24)

- Likewise, when reading verses describing the people of Hell or the qualities of the disbelievers, pause and ask Allah to protect you from those characteristics and from their fate. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَأَصْحَابُ الشِّمَالِ مَا أَصْحَابُ الشِّمَالِ (٤١) فِي سُمُومٍ وَحَمِيمٍ (٤٢) وَظِلٍّ مِّنْ يَّحْمُومٍ (٤٣) لَا بَارِدٍ وَلَا كَرِيمٍ (٤٤)﴾ (الواقعة: ٤١-٤٤)

"And the companions of the left—what are the companions of the left? They will be amid scorching wind and scalding water, and the shade of black smoke, neither cool nor refreshing." (Al-Waqi'ah 56:41–44)

As one continues in this manner, every passage of the Qur'an becomes an opportunity for continuous supplication. This is among the greatest forms of worship. The believer moves beyond merely reciting the words to living with their meanings. Whenever the Qur'an gives glad tidings, he asks Allah to grant him that blessing. Whenever it warns of punishment, he seeks Allah's protection. Whenever it praises the righteous, he asks Allah to make him among them. Whenever it condemns blameworthy qualities, he asks Allah to purify him from them.

In this way, the Qur'an becomes constantly present in the believer's heart, influencing his thoughts, decisions, and conduct. Its effect is no longer confined to the moments of recitation but extends to every aspect of daily life.

This understanding is supported by the statement of the Prophet ﷺ narrated by al-Nu'man ibn Bashir:

"Supplication is worship." The Prophet ﷺ then recited the words of Allah:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَقَالَ رَبُّكُمْ ادْعُونِي أَسْتَجِبْ لَكُمْ إِنَّ الَّذِينَ يَسْتَكْبِرُونَ عَنْ عِبَادَتِي سَيَدْخُلُونَ جَهَنَّمَ دَاخِرِينَ﴾ (غافر: ٦٠)

"Your Lord says: 'Call upon Me; I will answer you. Indeed, those who are too proud to worship Me will enter Hell in humiliation.'" (Ghafir 40:60)

Spiritual Tadabbur therefore transforms Qur'anic recitation into an ongoing dialogue between the servant and his Lord. Every verse becomes an opportunity to remember Allah, renew one's faith, strengthen one's hope, increase one's reverence, and draw nearer to Him through sincere reflection and heartfelt supplication.

Another aspect of spiritual Tadabbur is to pause whenever one encounters a verse that mentions one of Allah's blessings, allowing the heart to respond with gratitude and praise. In this way, the believer transforms the recitation of the Qur'an into an act of worship that fills the heart with thankfulness and appreciation for Allah's countless favors.

Among these blessings are:

- 1. The blessings of the universe and creation.**
- 2. The blessing of guidance to Islam.**

For example, Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ فِي خَلْقِ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلَافِ اللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهَارِ لَآيَاتٍ لِّأُولِي الْأَلْبَابِ (١٩٠) الَّذِينَ يَذْكُرُونَ اللَّهَ قِيَمًا وَقُعُودًا وَعَلَىٰ جُنُوبِهِمْ وَيَتَفَكَّرُونَ فِي خَلْقِ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ رَبَّنَا مَا خَلَقْتَ هَذَا بَطْلًا سُبْحَنَكَ فَقِنَا عَذَابَ النَّارِ (١٩١)﴾ (آل عمران: ١٩٠-١٩١)

"Indeed, in the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the alternation of night and day, there are surely signs for people of understanding, those who remember Allah while standing, sitting, and lying on their sides, and who reflect upon the creation of the heavens and the earth, saying: 'Our Lord, You have not created this in vain. Glory be to You! So protect us from the punishment of the Fire.'" (Al Imran 3:190–191)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿هُوَ الَّذِي خَلَقَ لَكُمْ مَا فِي الْأَرْضِ جَمِيعًا ثُمَّ أَسْتَوَىٰ إِلَى السَّمَاءِ فَسَوَّاهُنَّ سَبْعَ سَمَوَاتٍ وَهُوَ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمٌ﴾ (البقرة: ٢٩)

"It is He who created for you all that is on the earth; then He turned to the heaven and fashioned them into seven heavens. And He is All-Knowing of everything." (Al-Baqarah 2:29)

Likewise, Allah reminds us of His countless signs throughout creation:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ فِي اخْتِلَافِ اللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهَارِ وَمَا خَلَقَ اللَّهُ فِي السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَّقُونَ﴾ (يونس: ٦)

"Indeed, in the alternation of the night and the day, and in what Allah has created in the heavens and the earth, are signs for people who are mindful of Him." (Yunus 10:6)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَسَخَّرَ لَكُمُ اللَّيْلَ وَالنَّهَارَ وَالشَّمْسَ وَالْقَمَرَ وَالنَّجْمُ مُسَخَّرَاتٌ بِأَمْرِهِ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ﴾ (النحل ١٢)

"And He has subjected for you the night and the day, the sun and the moon; and the stars are subjected by His command. Indeed, in that are signs for people who reason."

(Al-Nahl 16:12)

And He says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَلَمْ تَرَ أَنَّ اللَّهَ سَخَّرَ لَكُم مَّا فِي السَّمَوَاتِ وَمَا فِي الْأَرْضِ وَأَسْبَغَ عَلَيْكُمْ نِعَمَهُ ظَاهِرَةً وَبَاطِنَةً﴾ (لقمان: ٢٠)

"Have you not seen that Allah has subjected to your service whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on the earth, and has lavished upon you His blessings, both apparent and

hidden?" (*Luqman 31:20*)

As believers reflect upon these verses, they should allow their hearts to fill with gratitude for Allah's immeasurable blessings. Such reflection transforms recitation into praise, remembrance, and sincere appreciation of the Creator's generosity.

2. Intellectual Tadabbur

Unlike spiritual Tadabbur, which every believer can practice immediately, intellectual Tadabbur requires deliberate reading, careful observation, and thoughtful analysis.

One of the most important aspects of intellectual Tadabbur is understanding Qur'anic terms according to how the Qur'an itself defines and uses them, rather than according to their common linguistic meanings or the technical definitions developed in later disciplines.

This principle forms the foundation of the remaining chapters of this book. The reader will learn a Qur'an-centered methodology for deriving the meanings of key Qur'anic terms by collecting and examining all the relevant verses so that the Qur'an may explain its own terminology.

Chapter 4. Determining Meanings of Qur'anic Key Terms

Every academic discipline develops its own specialized vocabulary. Before studying any field, students must first understand the precise meanings that its terminology carries within that discipline.

There are three principal ways to determine the meaning of a technical term in any field of knowledge:

1. **The definition given by specialists** in that field, explaining the meaning of the term and how it is used. For example, the word "cell" has different meanings depending on the field in which it is used:

- In biology, a cell is the basic structural unit of life.
- In law enforcement, a cell is a secure room in which prisoners are confined.
- In electricity, a cell is a source of electrical energy, such as a battery.
- In telecommunications, a cell is a geographic area served by a cellular network.

In the case of Qur'anic terminology, however, the highest authority for defining any Qur'anic term is Allah Himself, who defines His terminology through the Qur'an.

2. **The general usage of the term** throughout the foundational texts of that discipline, from which its essential meaning can be derived.

3. **The context** in which the term appears, since context often clarifies which meaning is intended. Naturally, this meaning must remain within the range established by the recognized linguistic definitions of the word.

The Noble Qur'an is its own primary reference. Since it is the Word of Allah, it is the most authoritative source for understanding the meanings of its own terms within their Qur'anic context.

There are many key Qur'anic terms whose meanings must be understood according to the Qur'an's own usage and context.

Among them are:

- "Awliya of Allah" (أولياء الله)
- "Taqwa" and those who have "Taqwa" (تقوى و متقون)
- "Ihsan" and Muhsineen (احسان و محسنون)
- "Eman" and those who have "Eman" (إيمان و مؤمنون)
- "Ibad Al-Rahman" (عباد الرحمن)
- "Ibadah" (عبادة)
- Al-Rahman (الرحمان)
- "Hidayah" (هداية) Guidance, "Dalal" (ضلال) misguidance
- "Ilm" (علم) knowledge
- "Zann" (ظن) (assumption), "Shakk" (شك) (doubt)
- Haneef (حنيف) in reference to Prophet Ibrahim (peace be upon him).

Each of these terms carries a precise Qur'anic meaning that

may differ from its common linguistic usage or from the meanings assigned to it by later theological, legal, or cultural developments. One of the primary objectives of this book is to study these key terms through the Qur'an itself, allowing the Qur'an to define its own vocabulary and thereby provide a more accurate understanding of its guidance.

PART 3: The Quranic Meaning of Key Terms

1. The Awliya of Allah (أولياء الله)

If I were to ask you, "**Are you one of the Awliya of Allah?**" your immediate answer would probably be "**No.**"

The likely reason is that many Muslims have inherited an inaccurate understanding of what the Qur'an means by a **Wali of Allah**. For many people, the term evokes the image of a saintly figure with extraordinary spiritual powers, a distinctive appearance, or miraculous abilities. Others imagine a person surrounded by an aura of holiness and separated from ordinary believers. Neither the Qur'an nor the Sunnah supports such images. Even the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ did not possess an outward appearance that distinguished him from his Companions. Abu Dharr and Abu Hurayrah رضي الله عنهما narrated:

روى أبو داود في سننه عن أبي ذرٍّ وأبي هريرة رضي الله عنهما قالاً: ((كان رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم يجلس بين ظهري أصحابه فيجيء الغريب فلا يدري أيُّهم هو حتى يسأل...))

"The Messenger of Allah ﷺ used to sit among his Companions, and when a stranger came, he would not know which one was the Messenger until he asked." (*Reported by Abu Dawud.*)

This demonstrates that closeness to Allah is not recognized by outward appearance, clothing, or social status. Rather, it is known through faith, righteousness, and devotion to Allah.

Fortunately, Allah Himself defines who His Awliya are in the Qur'an. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَلَا إِنَّ أَوْلِيَاءَ اللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ (٦٢) الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا وَكَانُوا يَتَّقُونَ (٦٣) لَهُمُ الْبُشْرَىٰ فِي الْحَيَاةِ الدُّنْيَا وَفِي الْآخِرَةِ لَا تَبْدِيلَ لِكَلِمَاتِ اللَّهِ ذَٰلِكَ هُوَ الْفَوْزُ الْعَظِيمُ (٦٤)﴾ (يونس: ٦٢-٦٤)

"Indeed, the Awliya of Allah shall have no fear, nor shall they grieve, those who believe and have Taqwa. For them are glad tidings in the life of this world and in the Hereafter. There is no changing the Words of Allah. That is the supreme success." (Yunus 10:62–64)

According to this Qur'anic definition, every believer is a wali of Allah in proportion to the strength of his iman and taqwa. This honor is not reserved for a select spiritual elite, nor is it limited to scholars, ascetics, or individuals granted a particular religious status. Rather, it is a rank open to every believer, who may grow in closeness to Allah through sincere faith and conscious obedience to Him.

The worldly benefits of attaining the rank of the awliya' of Allah are immense. In the well-known hadith qudsi narrated by al-Bukhari, Allah says:

"Whoever shows enmity toward a Wali of Mine, I have declared war upon him. My servant draws near to Me by

nothing more beloved to Me than what I have made obligatory upon him. Then My servant continues to draw near to Me through voluntary acts of worship until I love him. When I love him, I become his hearing with which he hears, his sight with which he sees, his hand with which he strikes, and his foot with which he walks. If he asks Me, I will surely give him, and if he seeks My protection, I will surely protect him. Never do I hesitate in anything as I hesitate in taking the soul of My believing servant: he dislikes death, and I dislike causing him distress." (*Sahih al-Bukhari*.)

Since **Iman** and **Taqwa** are the two defining qualities of the Awliya' of Allah, it is essential to understand how the Qur'an itself defines the **believers (mu'minun)** and the **God-conscious (muttaqun)**. It is equally important to understand what Allah has made obligatory upon those who possess true iman and taqwa, for these obligations constitute the foundation upon which closeness to Allah is built.

The comprehensive Qur'anic definitions of **Iman**, **Taqwa**, and their practical obligations will therefore be developed in the following sections.

Note

The Arabic term **wali** (ولي) is used in the Qur'an in reference both to **Allah** and to **one of His believing servants**. Its precise meaning depends on whom it refers to.

When the term refers to **Allah**, it describes Him as the Guardian, Protector, Patron, and Helper of His servants. For example:

قال تعالى: ﴿اللَّهُ وَلِيُّ الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا يُخْرِجُهُم مِّنَ الظُّلُمَاتِ إِلَى النُّورِ﴾ (البقرة: ٢٥٧)

"Allah is the Wali of those who believe; He brings them out of darkness into light." (Al-Baqarah 2:257)

Similarly, Prophet Yusuf (Joseph) said:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَنْتَ وَلِيَّ فِي الدُّنْيَا وَالْآخِرَةِ﴾ (يوسف: ١٠١)

"You are my Wali in this world and the Hereafter."
(Yusuf 12:101)

Likewise, Allah says to His Messenger ﷺ:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ وَلِيََّ اللَّهِ الَّذِي نَزَلَ الْكِتَابَ وَهُوَ يَتَوَلَّى الصَّالِحِينَ﴾ (الأعراف: ١٩٦)

"Indeed, my Wali is Allah, who has sent down the Book, and He protects the righteous." (al-Araf 7:196)

In these contexts, one may naturally say: **"Allah is my Wali,"**

meaning:

"Allah is my Guardian, Protector, and Patron."

When the term refers to a **believer**, however, the relationship is reversed. A **Wali of Allah** is someone who enjoys Allah's guardianship, protection, friendship, and special care.

Thus, when one says: "**He is a Wali of Allah,**"

the meaning is:

"He is one of those who are under Allah's guardianship, protection, and special care."

For this reason, throughout this book we retain the expression **Wali of Allah** rather than translating it with a single English word. No single equivalent, such as *friend*, *saint*, or *ally*, captures the full richness of the Qur'anic concept. Retaining the Arabic term preserves its breadth while allowing its meaning to be understood through the Qur'an itself.

2. Taqwa (تقوى) and Mutaqun (متقون)

Taqwa is one of the central concepts of Islam. Allah made it the objective of worship and the ultimate purpose toward which acts of devotion are directed. He says:

قَالَ تَعَالَى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ اعْبُدُوا رَبَّكُمُ الَّذِي خَلَقَكُمْ وَالَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ﴾ (البقرة: ٢١)

"O mankind, worship your Lord, who created you and those before you, so that you may attain Taqwa." (Al-Baqarah 2:21)

Allah also made Taqwa the essential condition for benefiting from the guidance of the Noble Qur'an. At the very beginning of Surah Al-Baqarah He says:

قَالَ تَعَالَى: ﴿ذَٰلِكَ الْكِتَابُ لَا رَيْبَ فِيهِ هُدًى لِّلْمُتَّقِينَ﴾ (البقرة: ٢)

"This is the Book in which there is no doubt, a guidance for the Muttaqun." (Al-Baqarah 2:2)

Likewise, Allah established Taqwa as the criterion by which human beings are distinguished in His sight:

قَالَ تَعَالَى: ﴿إِنَّ أَكْرَمَكُمْ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ أَتْقَاكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلِيمٌ خَبِيرٌ﴾ (الحجرات: ١٣)

"Indeed, the most honored of you in the sight of Allah is the one who possesses the greatest Taqwa." (Al-Hujurat 49:13)

These verses demonstrate that Taqwa is not merely one virtue among many. Rather, it is the foundation upon which the believer's relationship with Allah is built, the key to receiving divine guidance, and the measure of true excellence before Allah.

The Dimensions of Taqwa

The Qur'an presents Taqwa as possessing two inseparable dimensions:

- 1. The inward dimension.**
- 2. The outward dimension.**

The Inward Dimension

The inward dimension of Taqwa resides within the heart. It is known only to Allah and consists of loving Him, revering Him, feeling a sense of modesty before Him, and maintaining continual awareness of His presence. It is the believer's constant realization that Allah, the Ever-Living, the Self-Sustaining, is always with him, always observing him, and fully aware of everything he does.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَهُوَ مَعَكُمْ أَيْنَ مَا كُنْتُمْ وَاللَّهُ بِمَا تَعْمَلُونَ بَصِيرٌ﴾ [الحديد: ٤]

"And He is with you wherever you may be. And Allah sees all that you do." (Al-Hadid 57:4)

This inward awareness is the driving force behind every outward manifestation of Taqwa. If Taqwa is compared to a tree, the inward dimension is its root, while the outward dimension is its fruit.

The Outward Dimension

The outward dimension of Taqwa is visible to people. It appears in a person's conduct, speech, character, and behavior. While the inward dimension forms the foundation, the outward dimension represents its practical expression in everyday life.

The stronger a person's inward awareness of Allah becomes, the more evident its effects appear in his outward conduct, until he ultimately reaches the level of **Ihsan**, the highest manifestation of spiritual excellence.

Means of Strengthening Taqwa

The Noble Qur'an teaches the believer practical ways of nurturing and strengthening Taqwa. Among the most important are the following.

1. Reflecting upon Allah's Creation

Contemplating Allah's creation deepens one's awareness of His greatness, power, mercy, and wisdom. Such reflection naturally strengthens reverence for Allah and increases Taqwa.

2. Reflecting upon the History of Earlier Nations

The Qur'an repeatedly recounts the stories of earlier prophets and nations, not merely as historical accounts, but as lessons that strengthen faith, cultivate patience, and teach complete trust in Allah's decree.

Allah says:

قَالَ تَعَالَى: ﴿وَكُلًّا نَقُصُّ عَلَيْكَ مِنْ أَنْبَاءِ الرُّسُلِ مَا نُثَبِّتُ بِهِ فُؤَادَكَ﴾ (هود: ١٢٠)

"We relate to you the stories of the messengers by which We strengthen your heart. In them have come to you the truth, an admonition, and a reminder for the believers." (Hud 11:120)

Likewise, Allah says:

قَالَ تَعَالَى: ﴿إِنَّ فِي خَلْقِ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلَافِ اللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهَارِ لَآيَاتٍ لِأُولِي الْأَلْبَابِ﴾ (١٩٠) الَّذِينَ يَذْكُرُونَ اللَّهَ قِيَمًا وَقُعُودًا وَعَلَىٰ جُنُوبِهِمْ وَيَتَفَكَّرُونَ فِي خَلْقِ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ رَبَّنَا مَا خَلَقْتَ هَذَا بَطْلًا سُبْحَنَكَ فَقِنَا عَذَابَ النَّارِ
(١٩١) ﴿(آل عمران: ١٩٠-١٩١)﴾

"Indeed, in the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the alternation of the night and the day, are signs for people of understanding—those who remember Allah while standing, sitting, and lying on their sides, and who reflect upon the creation of the heavens and the earth, saying, 'Our Lord, You

have not created this in vain. Glory be to You! So protect us from the punishment of the Fire." (Al 'Imran 3:190–191)

Reflection upon Allah's signs in creation and reflection upon His guidance in history work together to deepen the believer's awareness of Allah, thereby strengthening Taqwa.

The Qur'anic Definition of Taqwa

If one were to ask most Muslims, including many students of Islamic knowledge, to define Taqwa, the answer would often focus primarily on inward feelings, such as fearing Allah or revering Him. Sometimes the well-known saying attributed to 'Ali ibn Abi Talib (may Allah be pleased with him) is quoted:

"Taqwa is to fear the Majestic, act according to the Revelation, be content with little, and prepare for the Day of Departure."

While this statement may capture some aspects of Taqwa, it falls far short than the comprehensive definition that Allah Himself provides in the Qur'an.

Given the central importance of Taqwa in both this life and the Hereafter, it is essential that we understand it as the Qur'an defines it. Rather than presenting an abstract definition, the Qur'an describes the characteristics of the **Muttaqun**, allowing their defining qualities collectively to reveal the meaning of Taqwa.

Immediately after declaring that the Qur'an is "**a guidance for the Muttaqun,**" Allah begins describing who they are:

قال تعالى: ﴿الَّذِينَ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِالْغَيْبِ وَيُقِيمُونَ الصَّلَاةَ وَمِمَّا رَزَقْنَاهُمْ يُنْفِقُونَ (۳)
وَالَّذِينَ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِمَا أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْكَ وَمَا أُنْزِلَ مِنْ قَبْلِكَ وَبِالْآخِرَةِ هُمْ يُوقِنُونَ (۴)﴾
(البقرة: ۳-۴)

"Those who believe in the unseen, establish prayer, spend from what We have provided them, believe in what has been revealed to you and what was revealed before you, and have certainty regarding the Hereafter." (Al-Baqarah 2:3-4)

These verses introduce the first five defining characteristics of the Muttaqun:

1. They believe in the unseen.
2. They establish prayer.
3. They spend from what Allah has provided them.
4. They believe in all of Allah's revealed scriptures.
5. They possess certainty concerning the Hereafter.

These verses lay the foundation of the Qur'anic definition of Taqwa. Elsewhere in the Qur'an, Allah expands this description through additional passages that present a fuller portrait of those who possess Taqwa.

The Qur'an Expands Its Definition of Taqwa

The five characteristics mentioned in the opening verses of Surah Al-Baqarah introduce the Qur'anic concept of Taqwa, but they do not constitute its complete definition. Elsewhere in the Qur'an, Allah expands this description through additional passages that present a fuller portrait of the Muttaqun.

Among the most comprehensive of these is His statement:

قال تعالى: ﴿لَيْسَ الْبِرَّ أَنْ تُوَلُّوا وُجُوهَكُمْ قِبَلَ الْمَشْرِقِ وَالْمَغْرِبِ وَلَكِنَّ الْبِرَّ مَنْ ءَامَنَ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَالْمَلَائِكَةِ وَالْكِتَابِ وَالنَّبِيِّينَ وَءَاتَى الْمَالَ عَلَى حُبِّهِ ذَوِي الْقُرْبَىٰ وَالْيَتَامَىٰ وَالْمَسْكِينِ وَابْنَ السَّبِيلِ وَالسَّائِلِينَ وَفِي الرِّقَابِ وَأَقَامَ الصَّلَاةَ وَءَاتَى الزَّكَاةَ وَالْمُوفُونَ بِعَهْدِهِمْ إِذَا عَاهَدُوا وَالصَّابِرِينَ فِي الْبَأْسَاءِ وَالضَّرَاءِ وَحِينَ الْبَأْسِ أُولَئِكَ الَّذِينَ صَدَقُوا وَأُولَئِكَ هُمُ الْمُتَّقُونَ﴾ (البقرة: ١٧٧)

"Righteousness is not that you turn your faces toward the east or the west. Rather, righteousness belongs to one who believes in Allah, the Last Day, the angels, the Book, and the prophets; who gives wealth, despite loving it, to relatives, orphans, the needy, the traveler, those who ask, and for freeing slaves; who establishes prayer and gives zakah; who fulfills their promises whenever they make them; and who remains patient in hardship, adversity, and times of conflict. Those are

the ones who have been truthful, and those are the Muttaqun."
(*Al-Baqarah* 2:177)

Notice how the verse concludes by declaring: **"Those are the Muttaqun."**

Allah Himself identifies these qualities as the defining characteristics of those who possess Taqwa.

Likewise, Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَسَارِعُوا إِلَىٰ مَغْفِرَةٍ مِّن رَّبِّكُمْ وَجَنَّةٍ عَرْضُهَا السَّمَاوَاتُ
وَالْأَرْضُ أُعِدَّتْ لِلْمُتَّقِينَ (١٣٣) الَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ فِي السَّرَّاءِ وَالضَّرَّاءِ وَالْكِبَاطِينِ
الْغَيْظِ وَالْعَافِينَ عَنِ النَّاسِ ۗ وَاللَّهُ يُحِبُّ الْمُحْسِنِينَ (١٣٤) وَالَّذِينَ إِذَا فَعَلُوا فَحِشَةً أَوْ
ظَلَمُوا أَنفُسَهُمْ ذَكَرُوا اللَّهَ فَاسْتَغْفَرُوا لِذُنُوبِهِمْ وَمَن يَغْفِرِ الذُّنُوبَ إِلَّا اللَّهُ وَلَمْ يُصِرُّوا عَلَىٰ
مَا فَعَلُوا وَهُمْ يَعْلَمُونَ (١٣٥)﴾ (آل عمران: ١٣٣-١٣٥)

"Race toward forgiveness from your Lord and a Garden whose width is that of the heavens and the earth, prepared for the Muttaqun—those who spend in prosperity and adversity, restrain their anger, forgive people—and Allah loves the Muhsinin; and those who, when they commit an indecency or wrong themselves, remember Allah, seek forgiveness for their sins—and who forgives sins except Allah?—and do not knowingly persist in what they have done." (*Al 'Imran* 3:133–135)

Again, Allah first mentions the Muttaqun and immediately follows this by describing their distinguishing qualities.

Also, Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ الْمُتَّقِينَ فِي جَنَّاتٍ وَعُيُونٍ (١٥) ءَاخِذِينَ مَا ءَاتَاهُمْ رَبُّهُمْ إِنَّهُمْ كَانُوا قَبْلَ ذَلِكَ مُحْسِنِينَ (١٦) كَانُوا قَلِيلًا مِّنَ اللَّيْلِ مَا يَهْجَعُونَ (١٧) وَبِالْأَسْحَارِ هُمْ يَسْتَغْفِرُونَ (١٨) وَفِي أَمْوَالِهِمْ حَقٌّ لِّلسَّائِلِ وَالْمَحْرُومِ (١٩)﴾ (الذاريات: ١٥-١٩)

"Indeed, the Muttaqun will be among gardens and springs. They used to sleep but little during the night, and before dawn they would seek forgiveness. And in their wealth there was a recognized right for the one who asked and the one who was deprived." (Al-Dhariyat 51:15–19)

These verses add further characteristics of the Muttaqun, including devotion during the night, continual repentance, and generosity toward those in need.

In addition to these passages, Allah links Taqwa to fasting:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا كُتِبَ عَلَيْكُمُ الصِّيَامُ كَمَا كُتِبَ عَلَى الَّذِينَ مِن قَبْلِكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ﴾ (البقرة: ١٨٣)

"O you who believe! Fasting has been prescribed for you as it was prescribed for those before you, so that you may attain Taqwa." (Al-Baqarah 2:183)

He also links it to Hajj:

قال تعالى: ﴿الْحَجُّ أَشْهُرٌ مَّعْلُومَةٌ ۖ فَمَنْ فَرَضَ فِيهِنَّ الْحَجَّ فَلَا رَفَثَ وَلَا فُسُوقَ ۚ وَلَا جِدَالَ فِي الْحَجِّ ۚ وَمَا تَفْعَلُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ يَعْلَمْهُ اللَّهُ ۚ وَتَزَوَّدُوا فَإِنَّ خَيْرَ الزَّادِ التَّقْوَىٰ ۚ وَاتَّقُونِ يَا أُولِيَ الْأَلْبَابِ ۚ﴾ (البقرة: ١٩٧)

"Hajj is during well-known months. Whoever undertakes Hajj during them must refrain from marital relations, sinful conduct, and disputing during Hajj. Whatever good you do, Allah knows it. And take provisions, but indeed the best provision is Taqwa. So have Taqwa of Me, O people of understanding." (Al-Baqarah 2:197)

When all of these passages are studied together, they reveal the Qur'an's comprehensive definition of Taqwa. And the characteristics of the Muttaqun . These characteristics fall into two complementary categories.

The Root of Taqwa

The foundational characteristic is **sound faith**. The Muttaqun believe with certainty in: Allah, the unseen, the Last Day, the angels, the revealed Books, and the Messengers. This inward conviction constitutes the root from which every other

characteristic grows. Without sincere faith, the remaining qualities become merely outward actions lacking their spiritual foundation.

The Fruits of Taqwa

The remaining characteristics are the visible fruits of this inward faith.

1. They establish the acts of worship prescribed by Allah.

These include prayer, fasting, and Hajj, through which the believer continually strengthens his relationship with Allah.

2. They devote part of the night to worship.

Their relationship with Allah extends far beyond fulfilling obligatory acts of worship.

3. They spend generously for the sake of Allah.

Whether in prosperity or adversity, they recognize that their wealth is a trust from Allah and that those in need have a rightful share in it.

4. They remain faithful to their promises.

Integrity and trustworthiness characterize all their dealings with others.

5. They remain patient and steadfast.

Hardship, poverty, suffering, and trials strengthen rather than weaken their reliance upon Allah.

6. They restrain their anger.

They refuse to allow emotion to govern their conduct and instead exercise self-control even when provoked.

7. They forgive others.

Their concern extends beyond justice to excellence of character. They pardon others hoping for Allah's forgiveness.

8. They continually seek Allah's forgiveness.

Whenever they commit a sin or wrong themselves, they immediately remember Allah, repent sincerely, and do not knowingly persist in their wrongdoing.

The distinguishing feature of the Muttaqun is therefore not that they never sin, but that they refuse to remain in sin once they recognize it.

An Important Observation

One important conclusion emerges from Allah's own description of the Muttaqun.

None of the Qur'anic passages that define Taqwa identifies **fear** as its defining characteristic. Instead, Allah repeatedly associates Taqwa with:

- sound faith,
- sincere worship,
- generosity,
- truthfulness,
- patience,
- forgiveness,
- repentance,
- and noble character.

Indeed, how could Taqwa simply mean fear when Allah says concerning His Awliya:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَلَا إِنَّ أَوْلِيَاءَ اللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ (٦٢) الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا وَكَانُوا يَتَّقُونَ (٦٣)﴾ (يونس: ٦٢-٦٣)

"Indeed, the Awliya' of Allah shall have no fear, nor shall they grieve, those who believe and have Taqwa." (Yunus 10:62–63)

This does not mean that reverential fear of Allah has no place in the believer's heart. Rather, it means that fear alone does not define Taqwa. The Qur'anic concept is far broader and more comprehensive. It encompasses the believer's faith, worship, character, and continual striving to live in a manner pleasing to Allah.

The Three Pillars of Taqwa

The characteristics of the Muttaqun described throughout the Qur'an lead us to Allah's own definition of Taqwa. Collectively, they reveal that Taqwa rests upon three inseparable pillars:

- 1. The Pillars of Iman**
- 2. The Pillars of Islam**
- 3. Noble Moral Character**

These three pillars encompass the believer's inner convictions, outward acts of worship, and daily conduct.

The moral qualities that repeatedly characterize the Muttaqun include:

- Generosity through both obligatory charity (*zakah*) and voluntary charity (*sadaqah*).
- Truthfulness and honesty in all dealings.
- Patience and steadfastness during trials and hardships.
- Restraining anger and exercising forbearance.
- Forgiving others.
- Continual repentance and seeking Allah's forgiveness without persisting in sin.

Together, these qualities summarize the essence of Islam as a complete way of life. Whoever strives to embody them fulfills, by Allah's permission, the promise He has made to the Muttaqun.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ اللَّهُ وَاللَّهُ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمٌ﴾ (البقرة: ٢٨٢)

"Have Taqwa of Allah, and Allah will teach you. And Allah is All-Knowing of everything." (Al-Baqarah 2:282)

This verse highlights one of the most profound distinctions between the first generation of Muslims and many Muslims today. The earliest Muslims regarded the Qur'an as the primary source of knowledge, understanding, and guidance. Today, however, many people rely first upon the opinions and interpretations of others before returning to the Qur'an itself.

The danger of reducing Taqwa merely to fear is that some believers may become so anxious about misunderstanding the Qur'an that they refrain from engaging with it directly and instead depend entirely upon the explanations of others.

The Qur'anic concept of Taqwa, however, produces a very different attitude. It combines reverence with hope. It motivates the believer to seek Allah's pleasure while trusting His guidance and mercy.

This balance is beautifully illustrated at the conclusion of Surah Al-Baqarah, the very surah that begins by introducing Taqwa as the essential condition for benefiting from the Qur'an. After presenting Allah's guidance, the surah ends with the believers' humble supplication:

قال تعالى: ﴿رَبَّنَا لَا تُؤَاخِذْنَا إِنْ نَسِينَا أَوْ أَخْطَأْنَا رَبَّنَا وَلَا تَحْمِلْ عَلَيْنَا إِكْرًا كَمَا حَمَلْتَهُ عَلَى الَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِنَا رَبَّنَا وَلَا تُحَمِّلْنَا مَا لَا طَاقَةَ لَنَا بِهِ ۖ وَاعْفُ عَنَّا وَاعْفِرْ لَنَا وَارْحَمْنَا أَنْتَ مَوْلَانَا فَانصُرْنَا عَلَى الْقَوْمِ الْكَافِرِينَ﴾ (البقرة: ٢٨٦)

"Our Lord! Do not hold us accountable if we forget or make a mistake. Our Lord! Do not place upon us a burden like that which You placed upon those before us. Our Lord! Do not burden us with what we have no strength to bear. Pardon us, forgive us, and have mercy upon us. You are our Protector, so grant us victory over the disbelieving people." (Al-Baqarah 2:286)

The believer therefore approaches the Qur'an with humility rather than fear, recognizing that sincere effort may sometimes be accompanied by human error. Allah's mercy is greater than our shortcomings, and He responds to those who seek His guidance with sincerity.

The Worldly Benefits of Taqwa

The benefits of Taqwa are immense in both this life and the Hereafter. The higher a believer ascends in the degrees of Taqwa, the greater the blessings that Allah bestows upon him.

Among these benefits are the following.

1. Taqwa Opens the Way Out of Hardship

Taqwa enables the believer to navigate life's difficulties with confidence, knowing that every trial is under Allah's control.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَمَنْ يَتَّقِ اللَّهَ يَجْعَلْ لَهُ مَخْرَجًا﴾ (الطلاق: ٢)

"Whoever has Taqwa of Allah, He will make for him a way out." (*Al-Talaq* 65:2)

The believer therefore understands that solutions often come from directions beyond human expectation.

2. Taqwa Brings Provision from Unexpected Sources

Continuing with the previous verse, Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَيَرْزُقْهُ مِنْ حَيْثُ لَا يَحْتَسِبُ﴾ (الطلاق: ٣)

"And He will provide for him from where he could never imagine." (*Al-Talaq* 65:3)

The promise of provision mentioned in this verse extends beyond material wealth. Allah opens doors that the believer could neither foresee nor create by his own efforts.

This promise teaches the believer to place his full trust in Allah rather than becoming consumed by anxiety over worldly means.

3. Taqwa Grants Sound Judgment

One of the greatest gifts bestowed upon the Muttaqun is *furqan*, the ability to distinguish truth from falsehood and right from wrong.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا إِن سَأَلُوا اللَّهَ يَجْعَلْ لَكُمْ فُرْقَانًا وَيُكَفِّرَ عَنْكُمْ سَيِّئَاتِكُمْ وَيَغْفِرْ لَكُمْ وَاللَّهُ ذُو الْفَضْلِ الْعَظِيمِ﴾ (الأنفال: ٢٩)

"O you who believe! If you have Taqwa of Allah, He will grant you a criterion (*furqan*), remove your sins from you, and forgive you. And Allah is the Possessor of immense bounty."
(*Al-Anfal* 8:29)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَءَامِنُوا بِرَسُولِهِ يُؤْتِكُمْ كِفْلَيْنِ مِنْ رَحْمَتِهِ وَيَجْعَلْ لَكُمْ نُورًا تَمْشُونَ بِهِ وَيَغْفِرْ لَكُمْ وَاللَّهُ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ﴾ (الحديد: ٢٨)

"O you who believe! Have Taqwa of Allah and believe in His Messenger. He will grant you a double share of His mercy, provide you with a light by which you shall walk, and forgive you. Allah is All-Forgiving, Most Merciful." (*Al-Hadid* 57:28)

Taqwa therefore produces an inner light that continually guides the believer toward what is true, beneficial, and pleasing to Allah.

4. Taqwa Becomes a Cause for Protecting One's Children

The blessings of Taqwa are not confined to the individual. They extend to future generations.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلْيَخْشَ الَّذِينَ لَوْ تَرَكَوا مِنْ خَلْفِهِمْ ذُرِّيَّةً ضِعَافًا خَافُوا عَلَيْهِمْ فَلْيَتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَلْيَقُولُوا قَوْلًا سَدِيدًا﴾ (النساء: ٩)

"Let those fear for their own children, were they to leave behind weak offspring. So let them have Taqwa of Allah and speak words that are just." (Al-Nisa' 4:9)

This verse teaches that the greatest inheritance parents can leave their children is not wealth alone but a life built upon Taqwa, through which they place themselves and their families under Allah's care.

Measuring One's Level of Taqwa

One of the most effective ways to assess your level of Taqwa is to examine your daily words and actions and ask yourself a simple but revealing question:

Would I feel embarrassed to say or do this if I were standing before someone for whom I have the greatest respect and admiration?

Consider the following examples.

- If you became angry with someone and spoke harshly, would you have behaved in the same way had that person occupied a position of great honor, or if someone you deeply respected had been present?
- If you were given an opportunity to betray a trust or act dishonestly without being discovered, would you behave differently if someone whose opinion you valued will be made aware?

Consider another example.

- Suppose your employer or the director of your company scheduled an appointment with you. Would you arrive late, or would you make every effort to arrive early, well prepared, and dressed appropriately out of respect for the meeting?
- Now compare that with the way you respond when Allah calls you to the Friday prayer. Does your preparation reflect the same degree of honor, reverence, and respect?

If the answer is no, why do we not show Allah the same reverence that we readily show other human beings?

The answer often lies in heedlessness. We sometimes act as though Allah were unaware of what we do, despite knowing that He is constantly watching us and that nothing escapes His sight or hearing. Such forgetfulness reflects a weakness in the heart's Taqwa.

The remedy is immediate repentance and seeking Allah's forgiveness whenever we become aware of our shortcomings, just as we would hasten to apologize after making a mistake before someone whose respect we cherish.

The level of Taqwa within the heart is directly proportional to the believer's awareness that Allah continually observes him and knows every thought, word, and deed. As this awareness grows stronger, it naturally perfects one's speech, actions, and character, and its effects become increasingly evident in every aspect of life.

In this sense, the outward conduct of a believer is the visible expression of the condition of the heart. When the heart is filled with faith and Taqwa, the whole person resembles a flourishing tree with deep roots, abundant branches, and plentiful fruit. But when the heart is deprived of faith and Taqwa, the person resembles a withered tree whose branches dry up, whose leaves fall, and whose fruit disappears. Such a tree can only be restored when it is once again nourished by the light of faith and sincere devotion to Allah.

Taqwa and Ihsan

Ihsan represents the highest outward manifestation of Taqwa and its ultimate fruit. For this reason, the Qur'an repeatedly associates the **Muttaqun** with the **Muhsinin**. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَالَّذِي جَاءَ بِالصِّدْقِ وَصَدَّقَ بِهِ ۖ أُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْمُتَّقُونَ (٣٣) لَهُمْ مَا يَشَاءُونَ عِنْدَ رَبِّهِمْ ۚ ذَٰلِكَ جَزَاءُ الْمُحْسِنِينَ (٣٤)﴾ (الزمر: ٣٣-٣٤)

"The one who brings the truth and believes in it, such are the **Muttaqun**. "They shall have whatever they desire with their Lord. Such is the reward of the **Muhsinin**." (*Al-Zumar* 39:33-34)

Likewise, Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ الْمُتَّقِينَ فِي ظِلَالٍ وَعُيُونٍ (٤١) وَفَوَاحٍ مِّمَّا يَشْتَهُونَ (٤٢) كُلُوا وَاشْرَبُوا هَنِيئًا بِمَا كُنْتُمْ تَعْمَلُونَ (٤٣) إِنَّا كَذَٰلِكَ نَجْزِي الْمُحْسِنِينَ (٤٤)﴾ (المرسلات: ٤١-٤٤)

"Indeed, the **Muttaqun** will be amid shade, springs, and whatever fruits they desire. Eat and drink with joy in return for what you used to do. Thus, do We reward the **Muhsinin**." (*Al-Mursalat* 77:41–44)

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ الْمُتَّقِينَ فِي جَنَّاتٍ وَعُيُونٍ (١٥) ءَاخِذِينَ مَا ءَاتَاهُمْ رَبُّهُمْ
إِنَّهُمْ كَانُوا قَبْلَ ذَلِكَ مُحْسِنِينَ (١٦)﴾ (الذَّارِيَّاتِ: ١٥-١٦)

“Indeed, the Muttaqeen will be in gardens and springs, (15) Receiving what their Lord has given them. Indeed, they were before that Mohsinin.” (Al-Dhariyat 51:15-16)

This recurring pattern is highly significant. Allah first describes these believers as the **Muttaqun**, then concludes by identifying their reward as the reward of the **Muhsinin**. This demonstrates that Ihsan is not a separate spiritual category but the highest practical expression of Taqwa.

The Prophet ﷺ explained this relationship in his famous definition of Ihsan:

"Ihsan is to worship Allah as though you see Him; and if you cannot see Him, then know that He surely sees you." (Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim)

Notice that the Prophet ﷺ begins with the same inward awareness that forms the heart of Taqwa: continual consciousness that Allah is always watching His servant. When this awareness becomes firmly rooted in the heart, it naturally gives rise to excellence in worship, sincerity in devotion, integrity in conduct, and beauty of character.

For this reason, Ihsan may be understood as the perfection and completion of the outward manifestation of Taqwa. Every Muhsin is characterized by Taqwa, but Ihsan represents the believer's striving to embody Taqwa with the highest degree of excellence.

For this reason, we shall study **Ihsan** separately later in this book as one of the Qur'an's major key concepts, where its meaning and implications will be explored in greater depth.

Concluding Reflection

The Qur'anic concept of Taqwa is therefore far different than a feeling of fear. It is a comprehensive way of life that begins with faith, grows through continual awareness of Allah, manifests itself in worship and noble character, and reaches its highest expression in Ihsan.

This understanding also explains why Allah made Taqwa the condition for receiving the guidance of the Qur'an. A heart that lives with continual awareness of Allah is prepared to receive His guidance, act upon it, and grow continually in knowledge, wisdom, and closeness to Him. As Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ اللَّهُ﴾ (البقرة: ٢٨٢)

"Have Taqwa of Allah, and Allah will teach you." (Al-Baqarah 2:282)

This verse beautifully summarizes the educational philosophy of the Qur'an: Taqwa is not merely the result of guidance, it is also the key that opens the heart to receive ever greater guidance.

3. Iman (Faith) and the Mu'minun (Believers)

1. The Common Understanding of Iman

Like Taqwa, the concept of **Iman** is often understood in a limited sense. Many Muslims define Iman simply as believing in the six pillars of faith: belief in Allah, His angels, His Books, His Messengers, the Last Day, and the Divine Decree.

While these beliefs unquestionably form the foundation of Iman, the Qur'an presents a much broader and richer understanding. It does not define Iman merely as intellectual acceptance of certain truths. Rather, it portrays Iman as a living reality that transforms the heart, shapes one's character, and governs one's conduct.

For this reason, we must allow the Qur'an itself to define Iman in the same way that it defines Taqwa, not through an abstract theological definition, but by describing the characteristics of the **Mu'minun**, the true believers.

2. The Linguistic Meaning of Iman

The Arabic word **Iman** is derived from the root **a-m-n** (أ م ن), which conveys the meanings of security, safety, trust, reassurance, and freedom from fear. Linguistically, Iman is therefore more than belief. It is a state of inner security and tranquility resulting from complete trust in Allah.

This linguistic meaning is reflected throughout the Qur'an. Genuine faith fills the heart with peace, confidence, and certainty because the believer entrusts himself entirely to Allah.

3. The Qur'anic Definition of Iman

Rather than defining Iman through a brief statement, the Qur'an defines Iman in two ways:

1. Describing the qualities of believers.
2. Direct commands to the believers thru verses that start with "O you who believe".

From the examples of verses that describe the believers are:

قال تعالى: ﴿ءَامَنَ الرَّسُولُ بِمَا أُنزِلَ إِلَيْهِ مِنْ رَبِّهِ ۚ وَالْمُؤْمِنُونَ كُلٌّ ءَامَنَ بِاللَّهِ
وَمَلَائِكَتِهِ وَكُتُبِهِ وَرُسُلِهِ ۚ لَا نُفَرِّقُ بَيْنَ أَحَدٍ مِّنْ رُّسُلِهِ ۚ وَقَالُوا سَمِعْنَا وَأَطَعْنَا ۚ غُفْرَانَكَ
رَبَّنَا وَإِلَيْكَ الْمَصِيرُ﴾ (البقرة: ٢٨٥)

The Messenger has believed in what was revealed to him from his Lord, and the believers as well. All:

1. have believed in Allah and His angels and His books and His messengers.
2. (say): We make no distinction between any of His messengers."
3. say, we hear, and we obey.

4. (Say we seek] Your forgiveness, our Lord, and to You is the [final] destination." (Al-Baqarah 2:285)

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّمَا الْمُؤْمِنُونَ الَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ اللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ وَإِذَا تُلِيَتْ عَلَيْهِمْ
آيَاتُهُ زَادَتْهُمْ إِيمَانًا وَعَلَىٰ رَبِّهِمْ يَتَوَكَّلُونَ (٢) الَّذِينَ يُقِيمُونَ الصَّلَاةَ وَمِمَّا رَزَقْنَاهُمْ يُنْفِقُونَ
(٣) أُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ حَقًّا لَهُمْ دَرَجَاتٌ عِنْدَ رَبِّهِمْ وَمَغْفِرَةٌ وَرِزْقٌ كَرِيمٌ (٤)﴾
(الأنفال: ٢-٤)

“Certainly, the believers are those:

- 1. Whose hearts are filled with awe when Allah is mentioned, and**
- 2. When His revelations are recited to them, it increases their faith and,**
- 3. On their Lord they place their trust.**
- 4. Those who establish prayer and**
- 5. Who spend (in charity) from what We have given them.**

Those are the true believers.” (Al-Anfal 8:2-4)

One of the clearest passages that describe the qualities of believers is found at the beginning of Surah Al-Mu'minun:

قال تعالى: ﴿قَدْ أَفْلَحَ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ (١) الَّذِينَ هُمْ فِي صَلَاتِهِمْ خَاشِعُونَ (٢)
وَالَّذِينَ هُمْ عَنِ اللَّغْوِ مُعْرِضُونَ (٣) وَالَّذِينَ هُمْ لِلزَّكَاةِ فَاعِلُونَ (٤) وَالَّذِينَ هُمْ

لِفُرُوجِهِمْ حَافِظُونَ (٥) إِلَّا عَلَىٰ أَزْوَاجِهِمْ أَوْ مَا مَلَكَتْ أَيْمَانُهُمْ فَإِنَّهُمْ غَيْرُ مَلُومِينَ
 (٦) فَمَنْ أَبْغَىٰ وِرَاءَ ذَٰلِكَ فَأُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْعَادُونَ (٧) وَالَّذِينَ هُمْ لِأَمْنَتِهِمْ وَعَهْدِهِمْ
 رَاعُونَ (٨) وَالَّذِينَ هُمْ عَلَىٰ صَلَوَاتِهِمْ يُحَافِظُونَ ﴿المؤمنون: ١-٩﴾

“The Believers are surely successful.

- 1. Those who are reverent (have Khoshoo) in their prayers.**
- 2. Who turn away from Laghw (vain talk and deeds).**
- 3. Who are active in working for paying the Zakat.**
- 4. Who guard their private parts.** except with their spouses and whomever their right hands may control (in their case) they are free from blame, but those whose desires exceed those limits are transgressors.
- 5. Who faithfully observe their trusts and their covenants.**
- 6. And who carefully maintain their prayers. (Al-Munoon 23:1-9)**

Note: The second trait that assures the success of the believer is turning away from laghw. That refers to any speech, action, or habit that lacks purpose or benefit and distracts from using time in doing good deeds or gaining useful knowledge.

Since the Khoshoo in the prayers is a trait of those who have Taqwa, the attributes of those who have Khoshoo in the prayers should be part of the definition of those who believe. These traits are given in Surat al-Maarij:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ الْإِنْسَانَ خُلِقَ هَلُوعًا (١٩) إِذَا مَسَّهُ الشَّرُّ جَزُوعًا (٢٠) وَإِذَا مَسَّهُ الْخَيْرُ مَنُوعًا (٢١) إِلَّا الْمُصَلِّينَ (٢٢) الَّذِينَ هُمْ عَلَى صَلَاتِهِمْ دَائِمُونَ (٢٣) وَالَّذِينَ فِي أَمْوَالِهِمْ حَقٌّ مَّعْلُومٌ (٢٤) لِلسَّائِلِ وَالْمَحْرُومِ (٢٥) وَالَّذِينَ يُصَدِّقُونَ بَيْنَ الَّذِينَ (٢٦) وَالَّذِينَ هُمْ مِّنْ عَذَابِ رَبِّهِمْ مُّشْفِقُونَ (٢٧) إِنَّ عَذَابَ رَبِّهِمْ غَيْرُ مَأْمُونٍ (٢٨) وَالَّذِينَ هُمْ لِفُرُوجِهِمْ حَافِظُونَ (٢٩) إِلَّا عَلَىٰ أَزْوَاجِهِمْ أَوْ مَا مَلَكَتْ أَيْمَانُهُمْ فَإِنَّهُمْ غَيْرُ مَلُومِينَ (٣٠) فَمَنِ ابْتَغَىٰ وَرَاءَ ذَٰلِكَ فَأُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْعَادُونَ (٣١) وَالَّذِينَ هُمْ لِأَمْتِنَتِهِمْ وَعَهْدِهِمْ رَاعُونَ (٣٢) وَالَّذِينَ هُمْ بِشَهَادَتِهِمْ قَائِمُونَ (٣٣) وَالَّذِينَ هُمْ عَلَىٰ صَلَاتِهِمْ يُحَافِظُونَ (٣٤)﴾ (المعارج: ١٩-٣٤)

Indeed, man was created very impatient; (19) Irritable (discontented) when evil touches him; (20) And miserly when good touches him. (21) Except those who perform prayers. (22) Those who are constant in their prayer (23) And those in whose wealth there us a known right (24) For the one who asks and the one who is deprived. (25) And those who believe in the Day of Judgement. (26) And those who are fearful of the punishment of their Lord (27) Indeed, the punishment of their Lord is not something from which one is safe. (28) And those who guard their private parts (29) Except from their wives or those their right hands possess, for indeed, they are not to be blamed. (30) But whoever seeks beyond that, then they are the transgressors - (31) And those who are to their trusts and

covenants are attentive (32) And those who are upright in their testimonies. (33) And those who [carefully] maintain their prayer. (Al-Maarij 70:19-34)

Based on the above Ayat, the traits of the believers can be summarized as follows:

1. Believe in Allah, His angels, His books, His messengers, and the day of judgment.
2. Make no distinction between any of His messengers.
3. Obey Allah and His messenger
4. Frequent remembrance of Allah and praising the Prophet (PBUH)
5. Frequent in seeking Allah's forgiveness
6. Their hearts are filled with awe when Allah is mentioned
7. Their faith increases when the Quran is recited to them
8. Put their trust in Allah
9. Maintain their prayers and perform them with reverence (Khoshoo)
10. Generous, spend (in charity) and do extra work to qualify to pay Zakah.
11. Avoid and turn away from Laghw (vain talk and deeds).
12. Enjoin what is right and forbid what is wrong
13. Chaste
14. Faithfully observe their trusts and their covenants.
15. Truthful in their testimony
16. Engage in Jihad with their money and lives
17. Support and protect other believers
18. Patient

19. Forgive others

20. Contented

In addition, additional definitions of the believers are identified by reflecting on Allah's direct commend to them thru 89 verses that start with "O you who believe". The first such verse emphasizes the importance of choosing words carefully.

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا لَا تَقُولُوا رَاعِنَا وَقُولُوا انْظُرْنَا وَاسْمَعُوا﴾ (البقرة: ١٠٤)

"O you who believe, do not say Ra'ina but say Unzurna, and listen." (Al-Baqarah 2: 104)

Note: Both "Ra'ina" and "Unzurna" mean "give attention to us." However, "Ra'ina" can be associated with ra'ayah (رعاية), meaning "to give attention," or associated with ra'oonah (رعونة), meaning "impulsiveness or thoughtlessness." Allah instructs believers to be mindful with their words and avoid terms that can carry unintended meanings, potentially causing offense or confusion.

A summary of the commands outlined in the verses starting with "O you who believe" includes the following. However, the reader is encouraged to add to the list through their own intellectual reflection (Tadabbur) of the Quran.

1. Ensure the use of proper and clear language
2. Standing always for justice
3. Refrain from taking the disbelievers as guardians

4. Saving human lives
5. Refraining from backbiting, insulting and be suspicion of others
6. Avoiding the steps of Satan of deceit, sowing conflicts and arrogance
7. Avoiding following one's desires that lead to violation Allah's commands
8. Protecting the wealth of others.
9. Not engaging in Riba
10. Avoiding sins such as consuming alcohol and gambling
11. Remembrance of Allah often
12. Acknowledging Allah's blessings
13. Eating only what is good
14. Maintaining pure body
15. Verifying the information before acting upon them
16. Taking permission for entering other's properties
17. Being alert
18. Imposing retribution for crimes
19. Ensuring the record and witness of legal documents such as will and loan.

Note: Apart from the level of tranquility that comes with faith in the heart, the Qur'an does not elaborate on the specific attributes of Muslims, as Islam and Iman (faith) are essentially the same in a broader sense, as Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿فَأَخْرَجْنَا مَنْ كَانَ فِيهَا مِنَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ (٣٥) فَمَا وَجَدْنَا فِيهَا غَيْرَ بَيْتٍ مِّنَ الْمُسْلِمِينَ (٣٦)﴾ (الذاريات: ٣٥-٣٦)

“So, We brought out whoever was in there of the believers. (35) But We did not find other than a [single] house of Muslims.” (Al-Dhariat 51:35-36)

Moreover, the opposite of both Islam and Eman is the same, Kufr (disbelief or denial of the truth). Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَيَأْمُرُكُمْ بِالْكُفْرِ بَعْدَ إِذْ أَنْتُمْ مُسْلِمُونَ﴾ (آل عمران: ٨٠)

“Would he order you to disbelief after you had been Muslims?” (Al-Emran 3:80)

قال تعالى: ﴿كَيْفَ يَهْدِي اللَّهُ قَوْمًا كَفَرُوا بَعْدَ إِيمَانِهِمْ﴾ (آل عمران: ٨٦)

“How shall Allah guide a people who disbelieved after their belief.” (Al-Emran 3:86)

Shared Characteristics Between the Muttaqun and the Believers

We observe that there are **five common characteristics** shared by those who possess **taqwa** (God-consciousness) and those who possess **iman** (faith):

1. Belief in Allah, the Exalted, His angels, His Books, His messengers, and the Last Day.
2. Maintaining the prescribed prayers.
3. Spending in the cause of Allah.
4. Fulfilling trusts and honoring covenants.
5. Showing patience and pardoning others.

Since being one of the **Awliya' of Allah** requires both **taqwa** and **iman**, no one should be regarded as a Wali of Allah unless he possesses, at the very least, these qualities. Moreover, because **taqwa** and **iman** both have an inward and an outward dimension, we cannot judge others solely by their outward actions. We are not capable of knowing what is firmly established in people's hearts. Allah alone, the Most High, is fully aware of that.

For this reason, we cannot state with certainty that a particular individual is among the Awliya' of Allah. Rather, we should say:

"We consider him, and Allah knows best, to be one of the Awliya' of Allah."

For Allah, Glorified and Exalted, alone knows with certainty who truly belongs to His Awliya'. He alone knows what is hidden within hearts just as He knows outward deeds.

Allah, the Exalted, says:

قال تعالى: ﴿هُوَ أَعْلَمُ بِكُمْ إِذْ أَنشَأَكُم مِّنَ الْأَرْضِ وَإِذْ أَنتُم أَجْنَثٌ فِي بُطُونِ
أُمّهَاتِكُمْ فَلَا تُزَكُّوا أَنفُسَكُمْ ۖ هُوَ أَعْلَمُ بِمَنِ اتَّقَىٰ﴾ (النجم: ٣٢)

"He knows you best, since He produced you from the earth and when you were embryos in your mothers' wombs. So do not claim yourselves to be pure; He knows best who is truly God-conscious." (An-Najm 53:32)

4. The Righteous Slaves of Al-Rahman (Ebad Al-Rahman) (عباد الرحمن)

The traits of the righteous slaves of Allah are summarized in the following verses from Surat Al-Rahman.

قال تعالى: ﴿وَعِبَادُ الرَّحْمَنِ الَّذِينَ يَمْشُونَ عَلَى الْأَرْضِ هَوْنًا وَإِذَا خَاطَبَهُمُ الْجَاهِلُونَ قَالُوا سَلَامًا (٦٣) وَالَّذِينَ يَبِيتُونَ لِرَبِّهِمْ سُجَّدًا وَقِيَمًا (٦٤) وَالَّذِينَ يَقُولُونَ رَبَّنَا اصْرِفْ عَنَّا عَذَابَ جَهَنَّمَ إِنَّ عَذَابَهَا كَانَ غَرَامًا (٦٥) إِنَّهَا سَاءَتْ مُسْتَقَرًّا وَمُقَامًا (٦٦) وَالَّذِينَ إِذَا أَنْفَقُوا لَمْ يُسْرِفُوا وَلَمْ يَقْتُرُوا وَكَانَ بَيْنَ ذَلِكَ قَوَامًا (٦٧) وَالَّذِينَ لَا يَدْعُونَ مَعَ اللَّهِ إِلَهًا آخَرَ وَلَا يَقْتُلُونَ النَّفْسَ الَّتِي حَرَّمَ اللَّهُ إِلَّا بِالْحَقِّ وَلَا يَزْنُونَ وَمَنْ يَفْعَلْ ذَلِكَ يَلْقَ أَثَامًا (٦٨) يُضَاعَفْ لَهُ الْعَذَابُ يَوْمَ الْقِيَمَةِ وَيَخَذُ فِيهِ مَهْنًا (٦٩) إِلَّا مَنْ تَابَ وَآمَنَ وَعَمِلَ صَالِحًا فَأُولَئِكَ يُبَدِّلُ اللَّهُ سَيِّئَاتِهِمْ حَسَنَاتٍ وَكَانَ اللَّهُ غَفُورًا رَحِيمًا (٧٠) وَمَنْ تَابَ وَعَمِلَ صَالِحًا فَإِنَّهُ يَتُوبُ إِلَى اللَّهِ مَتَابًا (٧١) وَالَّذِينَ لَا يَشْهَدُونَ الزُّورَ وَإِذَا مَرُّوا بِاللَّغْوِ مَرُّوا كِرَامًا (٧٢) وَالَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِّرُوا بِآيَاتِ رَبِّهِمْ لَمْ يَخِرُّوا عَلَيْهَا صُمًّا وَعُمْيَانًا (٧٣) وَالَّذِينَ يَقُولُونَ رَبَّنَا هَبْ لَنَا مِنْ أَزْوَاجِنَا وَذُرِّيَّاتِنَا قُرَّةَ أَعْيُنٍ وَاجْعَلْنَا لِلْمُتَّقِينَ إِمَامًا (٧٤) أُولَئِكَ يُجْزَوْنَ الْعُرْفَةَ بِمَا صَبَرُوا وَيُلَقَّوْنَ فِيهَا تَحِيَّةً وَسَلَامًا (٧٥) خَالِدِينَ فِيهَا حَسُنَتْ مُسْتَقَرًّا وَمُقَامًا (٧٦)﴾

(الفرقان: ٦٣-٧٦)

“And the righteous slaves of Al-Rahman are those who:

- 1. walk on the earth humbly, and**
- 2. when the ignorant people address them, they reply peacefully, (63)**
- 3. And those who pass the night Lord prostrating and standing [in prayer] before their Lord. (64)**
- 4. And those who say, "Our Lord, avert from us the punishment of Hell. Indeed, its punishment is a persisting affliction; (65) Indeed, it is evil as a settlement and residence." (66)**
- 5. And those who, when they spend are neither extravagant nor miserly, but are moderate between that. (67)**
- 6. And those who do not invoke any other god with Allah, and**
- 7. Do not kill a person whom Allah has given sanctity, except rightfully, and**
- 8. Do not fornicate; and whoever should do that will face the recompense. (68) The punishment will be doubled for him on the Day of Judgement, and he will abide therein humiliated (69)**
- 9. Except for those who repent, believe and do righteous deeds. For them Allah will replace their evil deeds with good deeds. And Allah is Most-Forgiving, Merciful. (70) And whoever repents and does righteous deeds turns to Allah truly. (71)**
- 10. And those who do not testify to falsehood, and**

11. when they pass near ill speech, they pass by with dignity. (72)

12. And those who, when reminded of the verses of their Lord, do not fall upon them deaf and blind. (73)

13. And those who say, "Our Lord, grant us from our wives and children comfort to our eyes and make us an example for those who have Taqwa. (74)

Those will be awarded the Chamber for what they patiently endured, and they will be received therein with greetings and [words of] peace. (75) Abiding eternally therein. Good is the abode and station. (Al-Furqan 25:63-76)

These Ayat describe the righteous slaves of Al-Rahman as those who are recognized by the following behaviors:

1. They never invoke any other god with Allah
2. They often remember the Hereafter and regularly seek Allah's protection from the Hell fire.
3. They are regular in their night prayers.
4. They are wise in their spending; they are neither extravagant nor miserly
5. They are humble and modest
6. They ignore all bad speeches and if addressed directly by ignorant speech, they respond with peaceful one in content and tone.
7. They respect the sanctity of the human life,
8. They are chaste
9. When they commit sin, they repent and do righteous deeds.

10. They are truthful and never give false testimony.
11. They are not distracted when the Quran is being recited.
12. They are regular in their supplication to Allah to make their wives and children comfort for their eyes and that they be example of those who have Taqwa.

Traits of Believers, Those with Taqwa and the Slaves of Al-Rahman

The following list is a consolidation of the traits of believers, those with Taqwa and the Slaves of Al-Rahman

1. Faith and Belief

- Believe in Allah, His angels, books, messengers, and the Day of Judgment.
- Make no distinction among Allah's messengers.
- Invoke no god besides Allah.

2. Worship and Rituals

- Perform prayer, fasting, Hajj, and engage in frequent remembrance of Allah and the Hereafter.
- Trust in Allah and maintain reverence (Khushoo) in prayer, including night prayers.
- Regularly engage with the Quran, recitation and reflection.
- Frequent remembrance of Allah and praising the Prophet (PBUH)

3. Seeking Forgiveness and Gratitude

- Seek Allah's forgiveness often and acknowledge His blessings.
- Repent sincerely after sinning.

4.Charity and Financial Ethics

- Give charity generously, spend wisely, and avoid extravagance and miserliness.
- Avoid Riba, gambling, and protect others' wealth.

5.Character and Morality

- Speak truthfully, testify honestly, and use respectful language.
- Avoid arrogance, suspicion, backbiting, and insulting others.
- Maintain self-restraint.
- Avoid and turn away from Laghw (vain talk and deeds)

6. Patience, Forgiveness, and Humility

- Exercise patience, forgive others, and maintain contentment.
- Stay humble and respond peacefully to ignorant speech.

7.Community Responsibility and Social Ethics

- Enjoin what is right, forbid wrong, and avoid vain talk.
- Keep trusts and covenants faithfully.
- Seek permission to enter others' property and verify information before acting.

8. Justice and Legal Matters

- Uphold justice
- Maintain proper legal documentation
- Ensure fair retribution for crimes.

9. Unity, Striving, and Support

- Be prepared for Jihad with wealth and lives, supporting fellow believers, and striving to keep unity.
- Honor the sanctity of life.

10. Personal Conduct and Family Life

- Maintain cleanliness, eat lawful food, and restrain anger.
- Respect life, avoid alcohol, and preserve chastity.
- Pray for righteous families and aspire to be models of Taqwa.

These characteristics, taken together, represent the most prominent qualities that define the **believers (mu'minun)**, the **God-conscious (muttaqun)**, and the **servants of Al-Rahman ('Ibad al-Rahman)** in the Qur'anic verses. They combine sound belief, sincere worship, noble character, and righteous conduct, governing a person's relationship with his Lord, with himself, and with the society around him.

Understanding the Relative Importance of Allah's Commands

It is important to recognize that all of Allah's commands are essential, and every sincere believer should strive to implement them all. Nevertheless, these commands differ in their degree of importance and rank. The following verse indicates that everything Allah has revealed is good and beneficial, yet some parts of His revelation are more excellent and carry greater virtue than others, just as some actions are better and more appropriate in certain situations than in others. Allah, the Exalted, says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَاتَّبِعُوا أَحْسَنَ مَا أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْكُمْ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ مِنْ قَبْلِ أَنْ يَأْتِيَكُمُ الْعَذَابُ بَغْتَةً وَأَنْتُمْ لَا تَشْعُرُونَ﴾ (الزمر: ٥٥)

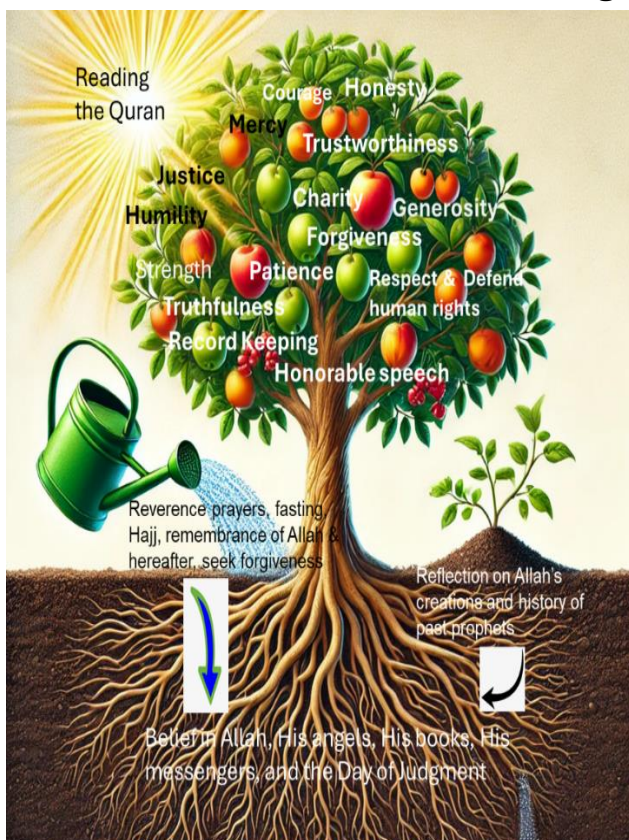
"Follow the best of what has been sent down to you from your Lord before the punishment comes upon you suddenly while you are unaware." (Az-Zumar 39:55)

Note

To facilitate memorization and recall, these qualities, which represent the essence of worship and the defining characteristics of those who have Taqwa, have been summarized in the form of a poem presented in the final chapter of this book. The accompanying illustration will further reinforce their meaning and make them easier to remember.

The illustration below portrays the Muslim as a deeply rooted, firmly established tree bearing the beautiful fruits of noble character.

The Muslim as a Fruit-Bearing Tree



كَلِمَةُ طَيِّبَةٍ كَتَجَرَّةٌ طَيِّبَةٌ أَصْلُهَا ثَابِتٌ وَفَرْعُهَا فِي السَّمَاءِ (٢٤) تُؤْتِي أُكْلَهَا كُلَّ حِينٍ بِإِذْنِ رَبِّهَا

"A good word is like a good tree, its root is firm, and its branches reach the sky, (24) Always yielding its fruit in every season by the will of its Lord." (Ibrahim 14:24-25)

Root: Belief in Allah, His angels, His books, His messengers, and the Day of Judgment.

Water: reverence prayers, fasting, Hajj, remembrance of Allah & the hereafter and seek forgiveness

Sun: Reading the Quran

Food: Reflection in Allah's creations and history of past prophets

Fruits:

Justice, Honesty, and Trustworthiness: Stand for justice, are truthful in any testimony, and faithfully observe trusts and covenants. Verify information before acting upon it and handle legal matters properly.

Generosity and Charity: Be generous, spending in charity (Zakat and beyond) in both prosperity and adversity, while being balanced in their spending—neither extravagant nor miserly.

Good Character: Avoid vain talk, backbiting, and harmful speech.

Respond peacefully to ignorant speech and always use clear, respectful language. Strong, proud and optimistic.

Chastity and Moral Conduct: Be chaste in actions and speech, avoiding sins such as alcohol, gambling, and Riba. Avoid following desires that lead to sinful behavior.

Patience, Forgiveness, and Humility: Be patient in difficulties, forgive others, restrain anger, and be humble and modest in demeanor.

Support and Protection of Believers: Support and protect other believers, prepare and engage in Jihad with money and lives. Refrain from taking disbelievers as guardians in matters of faith.

Respect Human Rights: Respect the sanctity of human life, protect others' wealth, and seek permission before entering others' properties. Avoid the steps of Satan, such as deceit and arrogance, and ensure proper handling of legal and financial matters.

Explanation of the Illustration

Allah, the Exalted, says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَلَمْ تَرَ كَيْفَ ضَرَبَ اللَّهُ مَثَلًا كَلِمَةً طَيِّبَةً كَشَجَرَةٍ طَيِّبَةٍ أَصْلُهَا

ثَابِتٌ وَفَرْعُهَا فِي السَّمَاءِ (٢٤) تُؤْتِي أُكْلَهَا كُلَّ حِينٍ بِإِذْنِ رَبِّهَا وَيَضْرِبُ اللَّهُ

الْأَمْثَالَ لِلنَّاسِ لَعَلَّهُمْ يَتَذَكَّرُونَ (٢٥) ﴿ (إبراهيم: ٢٤-٢٥)

"Have you not considered how Allah presents an example? A good word is like a good tree: its root is firmly established, and its branches reach the sky. It gives its fruit at all times by the permission of its Lord. And Allah presents examples for mankind so that they may reflect." (Ibrahim 14:24–25)

- **The Roots:** Faith in Allah, His angels, His Books, His messengers, the Last Day, and Divine Decree.
- **The Water:** Prayer, fasting, supplication, Hajj, zakah, remembrance of Allah, recitation of His praises, and seeking His forgiveness.
- **The Sun (Light):** Reciting the Qur'an and reflecting upon its meanings.
- **The Food:** Reflecting upon Allah's creation, studying the lives of previous nations, and learning from their experiences.
- **The Fruits:**
 - **Justice and Integrity:** trustworthiness, supporting the truth, honesty in testimony, fulfilling trusts and covenants, verifying information before acting upon it, conducting legal and financial matters responsibly, and maintaining a good reputation among people.
 - **Generosity and Charity:** Be generous with your wealth. Give both the prescribed charity and voluntary charity. Be moderate in your spending—neither extravagant nor miserly—in times of prosperity and hardship alike.
 - **Good Character:** Avoid falsehood, backbiting, and hurtful speech. Respond to the ignorant with dignity and restraint.

Speak with clarity and respect, and let your words be balanced and thoughtful.

- **Trustworthiness and Moral Conduct:** Be trustworthy in your actions and dealings. Avoid sinful behavior such as intoxicants, gambling, usury (riba), and following desires that lead one away from the straight path.
- **Patience, Forgiveness, and Humility:** Be patient in times of hardship, forgive others, suppress anger, be humble in your conduct, and respond to evil with what is better.
- **Supporting the Believers and Protecting Them:** Sacrifice your wealth and yourself in their defense, and do not take the disbelievers as close allies in preference to the believers.
- **Respecting the Rights of Others:** Refrain from shedding blood unlawfully, safeguard people's lives and property, seek permission before entering the homes of others, avoid following the footsteps of Satan, and conduct your legal and financial affairs with wisdom and responsibility.

5. Worship (Ibadah) and the Worshippers

The term **Ibadah (worship)** refers to the relationship between Allah, Glorified and Exalted, as the Lord and Master, and His creation as His servants. It represents the fundamental purpose of human existence.

Allah, the Exalted, says:

قال تعالى: ﴿مَا خَلَقْتُ الْجِنَّ وَالْإِنْسَ إِلَّا لِيَعْبُدُونِ﴾ (الذاريات: ٥٦)

"I did not create jinn and mankind except that they should worship Me." (Adh-Dhariyat 51:56)

One of the most common misconceptions is to limit 'ibadah' (worship) to acts of ritual acts such as prayer, fasting, and pilgrimage. Although these rituals are essential, they were prescribed to enable a person to fulfill his mission in life according to Allah's guidance. The meaning of the 'ibadah' in Islam extends far beyond these rituals. It includes making proper use of the resources Allah has placed at humanity's disposal, in accordance with His commands, to establish justice, remove obstacles that prevent His message from reaching the world, and accomplish everything that Allah loves and approves of.

Thus, worship encompasses every action through which a person fulfills his role as Allah's vicegerent (khalifah) on earth.

This responsibility requires acquiring knowledge to discover and wisely utilize the resources of the natural world for the benefit of humanity, in accordance with Allah's guidance. It also includes combating corruption on earth, striving to reform society, establishing justice, spreading goodness, and conveying Allah's message. Worship therefore includes obedience, responsibility, and sincere servitude to Allah within the framework of His commands.

According to this comprehensive understanding, a person's worldly activities are not separate from worship. Learning, working, producing, reforming society, raising children, and serving people's needs can all become acts of worship when performed with sincere intention and within the limits established by Allah. Islam therefore does not regard worship as confined to specific rituals or limited times, detached from everyday life. Rather, worship is a continuous state of obedience to Allah reflected in every word and action. In this way, worship becomes integrated into the whole of life, making the entire earth a place of worship and purification.

Allah, the Lord of all worlds, has no need of His servants' acts of worship. Rather, it is the servants themselves who need worship. The rituals are prescribed for the benefits of believers to enable them to fulfill his mission in life according to Allah's guidance as will be discussed later.

The relationship between Allah and human beings as His worshippers is the relationship between the One who creates them, provides for them, and suffices them in all their needs, while He

needs none from them. Rather, they are the ones who stand in need of Him all the time. Allah is completely independent of His creation, whereas they are in constant need of Him for their existence, sustenance, and every aspect of their lives.

Allah, the Exalted, says:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ أَنْتُمُ الْفُقَرَاءُ إِلَى اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ هُوَ الْغَنِيُّ الْحَمِيدُ﴾ (فاطر ١٥)

“O people, you are who stand in need of Allah, But Allah is Self-Sufficient, Worthy of all praise.” (Fatir 35:15)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا أَنْفِقُوا مِنْ طَيِّبَاتِ مَا كَسَبْتُمْ وَمِمَّا أَخْرَجْنَا لَكُمْ مِنَ الْأَرْضِ وَلَا تَيَمَّمُوا الْخَبِيثَ مِنْهُ تُنْفِقُونَ وَلَسْتُمْ بِأَخِيذِهِ إِلَّا أَنْ تُغْمِضُوا فِيهِ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ غَنِيٌ حَمِيدٌ﴾ (البقرة: ٢٦٧)

"O you who believe! Spend from the good things that you have earned and from what We have produced for you from the earth. Do not aim for what is inferior in order to spend from it, when you yourselves would not accept it except with reluctance. Know that Allah is Self-Sufficient and Praiseworthy." (Al-Baqarah 2:267)

And He says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلَقَدْ ءَاتَيْنَا لُقْمَانَ الْحِكْمَةَ أَنْ اشْكُرْ لِلَّهِ وَمَنْ يَشْكُرْ فَإِنَّمَا يَشْكُرُ لِنَفْسِهِ ۖ وَمَنْ كَفَرَ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ غَنِيٌ حَمِيدٌ﴾ (لقمان: ١٢)

"We certainly gave Luqman wisdom, saying, 'Give thanks to Allah.' Whoever is grateful is grateful only for his own benefit; and whoever is ungrateful, then indeed Allah is Self-Sufficient and Praiseworthy." (Luqman 31:12)

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنْ تَكْفُرُوا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ غَنِيٌّ عَنْكُمْ وَلَا يَرْضَىٰ لِعِبَادِهِ الْكُفْرَ وَإِنْ تَشْكُرُوا يَرْضَهُ لَكُمْ﴾ (الزمر: ٧)

"If you disbelieve, then indeed Allah has no need of you. Yet He does not approve disbelief for His servants. But if you are grateful, He approves it for you." (Az-Zumar 39:7)

Worship encompasses every outward and inward action and every word that pleases Allah, Glorified and Exalted. Although this definition is comprehensive, it does not specify every required action individually. To understand worship in practical terms, one may look at the conduct of those whom Allah praised, whose actions reflected His pleasure. These are the people who devoted themselves entirely to Allah and sincerely worshipped Him.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ اللَّهَ اشْتَرَىٰ مِنَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ أَنْفُسَهُمْ وَأَمْوَالَهُمْ بِأَنْ لَهُمُ الْجَنَّةُ﴾ (التوبة: ١١١)

"Indeed, Allah has purchased from the believers their lives and their wealth in exchange for Paradise." (At-Tawbah 9:111)

Characteristics of True Worshippers

The essence of worship is manifested through profound love for Allah, Glorified and Exalted, reverence for Him, complete obedience to His commands, and unwavering submission to His will. This obedience is reflected in the qualities and actions of true worshippers described in the previous sections, which may be summarized as follows:

1. Faith and Belief

- a. Believe in Allah, His angels, books, messengers, and the Day of Judgment.
- b. Make no distinction among Allah's messengers.
- c. Invoke no god besides Allah.

2. Worship and Rituals

- a. Perform prayer, fasting, Hajj, and engage in frequent remembrance of Allah and the Hereafter.
- b. Trust in Allah and maintain reverence (Khushoo) in prayer, including night prayers.
- c. Regularly engage with the Quran, recitation and reflection.
- d. Frequent remembrance of Allah and praising the Prophet (PBUH).

3. Seeking Forgiveness and Gratitude

- a. Seek Allah's forgiveness often and acknowledge His blessings.
- b. Repent sincerely after sinning.

4. Charity and Financial Ethics

- a. Give generously in charity, spend wisely, and avoid both extravagance and stinginess."

- b. Avoid Riba, gambling, and protect others' wealth.

5. Character and Morality

- a. Speak truthfully, testify honestly, and use respectful language.
- b. Avoid arrogance, suspicion, backbiting, and insulting others.
- c. Maintain self-restraint. Exercise patience, forgive others, and maintain contentment.
- d. Stay humble and respond peacefully to ignorant speech.
- e. Avoid and turn away from Laghw (vain talk and deeds)

6. Community Responsibility and Social Ethics

- a. Enjoin what is right, forbid wrong, and avoid vain talk.
- b. Keep trusts and covenants faithfully.
- c. Seek permission to enter others' property and verify information before acting.

7. Justice and Legal Matters

- a. Uphold justice, maintain proper legal documentation, and ensure fair retribution for crimes.

8. Unity, Striving, and Support

- a. Be prepared for Jihad with wealth and lives, supporting fellow believers, and striving to keep unity.
- b. Honor the sanctity of life.

9. Personal Conduct and Family Life

- a. Maintain cleanliness, eat lawful food, and restrain anger.
- b. Avoid alcohol and preserve chastity.

These characteristics represent a concise summary of the qualities attributed to the **believers (mu'minun)**, the **God-**

conscious (muttaqun), and the servants of the Most Merciful ('Ibad al-Rahman). They are the practical manifestations of sincere worship founded upon sound faith, righteous conduct toward others, wholehearted adherence to Allah's commands in every aspect of life, and sincere obedience to Him, Glorified and Exalted.

Actions That Nullify Worship

Just as the qualities discussed above embody the essence of true worship, the Qur'an also identifies actions that undermine and invalidate it. Such actions incur divine punishment because they constitute grave sins and immoral deeds (fawahish) that violate Allah's commands and are fundamentally incompatible with sincere worship. Among these actions are:

List of Grave Sins

1. Associating partners with Allah (Shirk)

ج
قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يَغْفِرُ أَنْ يُشْرَكَ بِهِ وَيَغْفِرُ مَا دُونَ ذَلِكَ لِمَنْ يَشَاءُ
وَمَنْ يُشْرِكْ بِاللَّهِ فَقَدْ افْتَرَىٰ إِثْمًا عَظِيمًا﴾ (النساء: ٤٨)

“Indeed, Allah does not forgive association with Him, but He forgives what is less than that for whom He wills.” (Al-Nisa 4:48)

2. Neglecting prayer (Salah)

قال تعالى: ﴿خَلَفَ مِنْ بَعْدِهِمْ خَلْفٌ أَضَاعُوا الصَّلَاةَ وَاتَّبَعُوا الشَّهَوَاتِ فَسُوفَ يَلْقَوْنَ غِيًّا﴾ (مريم: ٥٩)

“But there came after them successors who neglected prayer and pursued desires; so they are going to meet evil.” (Maryam 19:59)

قال تعالى: ﴿مَا سَلَكَكُمْ فِي سَقَرٍ﴾ (٤٢) قَالُوا لَمْ نَكُ مِنَ الْمُصَلِّينَ (٤٣) ﴿المذثر: ٤٢-٤٣﴾

"What put you into Saqar (Hell)?" (42) They will say, "We were not of those who prayed." (Al-Mudathir 74:42-43)

3. Murder (Taking a life unjustly)

قال تعالى: ﴿مَنْ قَتَلَ نَفْسًا بِغَيْرِ نَفْسٍ أَوْ فَسَادٍ فِي الْأَرْضِ فَكَأَنَّمَا قَتَلَ النَّاسَ جَمِيعًا﴾ (المائدة: ٣٢)

“Whoever kills a soul unless for a soul or for corruption [done] in the land—it is as if he had slain mankind entirely.” (Al-Maeda 5:32)

4. Consuming usury (Riba)

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَذَرُوا مَا بَقِيَ مِنَ الرِّبَا إِن كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ﴾ (٢٧٨) فَإِنْ لَمْ تَفْعَلُوا فَأْذَنُوا بِحَرْبٍ مِّنَ اللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ ﴿البقرة: ٢٧٨-٢٧٩﴾

“O you who believe, Have Taqwa of Allah and give up what remains of Riba, if you are indeed believers. (278) If you do not, take notice of war from Allah and His Messenger:” (Al-Baqara 2:278-279)

5. Consuming the wealth of orphans

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ الَّذِينَ يَأْكُلُونَ أَمْوَالَ الْيَتَامَىٰ ظُلْمًا إِنَّمَا يَأْكُلُونَ فِي بُطُونِهِمْ نَارًا وَسَيَصْلَوْنَ سَعِيرًا﴾ (النساء: ١٠)

“Indeed, those who devour the property of orphans unjustly are only consuming into their bellies fire, and they will have to endure a blazing fire.” (Al-Nisa 4:10)

6. Adultery or fornication (Zina)

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلَا تَقْرَبُوا الزِّنَىٰ إِنَّهُ كَانَ فَحِشَةً وَسَاءَ سَبِيلًا﴾ (الإسراء: ٣٢)

“And do not approach unlawful sexual intercourse. Indeed, it is ever an immorality and an evil way.” (Al-Isra 17:32)

7. Slandering chaste women

قال تعالى: ﴿وَالَّذِينَ يَرْمُونَ الْمُحْصَنَاتِ ثُمَّ لَمْ يَأْتُوا بِأَرْبَعَةِ شُهَدَاءَ فَاجْلِدُوهُمْ ثَمَانِينَ جَلْدَةً وَلَا تَقْبَلُوا لَهُمْ شَهَادَةً أَبَدًا وَأُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْفَاسِقُونَ﴾ (النور: ٤)

“And those who launch a charge against chaste women and do not produce four witnesses—flog them with eighty stripes, and ever after refuse to accept from them any testimony - they that are truly evil-doers.” (24:4)

8. Breaking covenants

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ الَّذِينَ يَشْتَرُونَ بِعَهْدِ اللَّهِ وَأَيْمَانِهِمْ ثَمَنًا قَلِيلًا أُولَٰئِكَ لَا خَلَاقَ لَهُمْ فِي الْآخِرَةِ وَلَا يُكَلِّمُهُمُ اللَّهُ وَلَا يَنْظُرُ إِلَيْهِمْ يَوْمَ الْقِيَمَةِ وَلَا يُزَكِّيهِمْ وَلَهُمْ عَذَابٌ أَلِيمٌ﴾ (آل عمران: ٧٧)

“Indeed, those who break the covenant of Allah and their oaths for a small price will have no share in the Hereafter, and Allah will not speak to them or look at them on the Day of Resurrection, nor will He purify them; and they will have a painful punishment.” (Al-Emran 3:77)

9. Drinking alcohol or Gambling

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا إِنَّمَا الْخَمْرُ وَالْمَيْسِرُ وَالْأَنْصَابُ وَالْأَزْلَمُ رِجْسٌ مِّنْ عَمَلِ الشَّيْطَانِ فَاجْتَنِبُوهُ لَعَلَّكُمْ تُفْلِحُونَ (٩٠) إِنَّمَا يُرِيدُ الشَّيْطَانُ أَنْ يُوقِعَ بَيْنَكُمُ الْعَدَاوَةَ وَالْبَغْضَاءَ فِي الْخَمْرِ وَالْمَيْسِرِ وَيَصُدَّكُمْ عَنْ ذِكْرِ اللَّهِ وَعَنِ الصَّلَاةِ فَهَلْ أَنتُم مُّنتَهُونَ (٩١)﴾ (المائدة: ٩٠-٩١)

“O you who believe, intoxicants, gambling, [sacrificing on] stone alters [to other than Allah], and divining arrows are filth from the work of Satan. So, avoid that in order that you may be successful” (5:90) Satan only wants to plant enmity and hatred between you through intoxicants and gambling and to avert you from the remembrance of Allah and from prayer. Would you, then, abstain? (Al-Maeda 5:90-91)

10. Despairing of the mercy of Allah

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّهُ لَا يَأْسُ مِنْ رَّوْحِ اللَّهِ إِلَّا الْقَوْمُ الْكَافِرُونَ﴾ (يوسف: ٨٧)

“Indeed, no one despairs of relief from Allah except the disbelievers.” (Yusuf 12:87)

قال تعالى: ﴿قَالَ وَمَنْ يَقْنُطُ مِنْ رَحْمَةِ رَبِّهِ إِلَّا الضَّالُّونَ﴾ (الحجر: ٥٦)

“And who despairs of the mercy of his Lord except for those astray?” (Al-Hijr 15:56)

11. Undutiful to parents

قال تعالى: ﴿وَبَرًّا بِوَالِدَيْهِ وَلَمْ يَكُنْ جَبَّارًا عَصِيًّا﴾ (مريم: ١٤)

“And dutiful toward his parents. And he was not arrogant, rebellious” (Maryam 19:14)

قال تعالى: ﴿وَوَصَّيْنَا الْإِنْسَانَ بِوَالِدَيْهِ حَمَلَتْهُ أُمُّهُ وَهْنًا عَلَى وَهْنٍ وَفِصْلَهُ فِي عَامَيْنِ أَنْ اشْكُرْ لِي وَلِوَالِدَيْكَ إِلَى الْمَصِيرِ﴾ (١٤) وَإِنْ جَاهَدَاكَ عَلَى أَنْ تُشْرِكَ بِي مَا لَيْسَ لَكَ بِهِ عِلْمٌ فَلَا تُطِعْهُمَا وَصَاحِبَهُمَا فِي الدُّنْيَا مَعْرُوفًا﴾ (لقمان: ١٤-١٥)

And We commanded man goodness towards his parents. His mother carried him, by bearing strain upon strain, and his weaning is in two years. Be grateful to Me and to your parents; to Me is the [final] destination. (14) But if they endeavor to make you associate with Me that of which you have no knowledge, do not obey them but accompany them in [this] world with kindness.” (Luqman 31:14-15)

11. Severing ties of kinship

قال تعالى: ﴿فَهَلْ عَسَيْتُمْ إِنْ تَوَلَّيْتُمْ أَنْ تُفْسِدُوا فِي الْأَرْضِ وَتَقَطَّعُوا أَرْحَامَكُمْ﴾ (٢٢) أُولَئِكَ الَّذِينَ لَعَنَهُ اللَّهُ فَاصْفَهُمْ وَأَعْمَى أَبْصَرَهُمْ﴾ (٢٣)﴾ (محمد: ٢٢-٢٣)

“So, would you perhaps, after having turned away spread corruption on earth and sever ties of your kins? (22)

Such are they whom Allah curses, so He deafened them and blinded their eyes.” (Muhammad 47:22-23)

12. False testimony

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلَا تَكْتُمُوا الشَّهَادَةَ وَمَنْ يَكْتُمْهَا فَإِنَّهُ آثِمٌ قَلْبُهُ﴾ (البقرة: ٢٨٣)

“And do not conceal testimony, for whoever conceals it—his heart is indeed sinful.” (Al-Baqarah 2:283)

13. Fleeing from battle on the day of confrontation

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا إِذَا لَقِيتُمُ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا زَحَفًا فَلَا تُولُوهُمُ الْأَدْبَارَ (١٥) وَمَنْ يُولِهِمْ يُؤَمِّدْ دُبْرَهُ إِلَّا مُتَحَرِّفًا لِّقِتَالٍ أَوْ مُتَحِيزًا إِلَىٰ فِتْنَةٍ فَقَدْ بَاءَ بِغَضَبٍ مِّنَ اللَّهِ وَمَأْوَاهُ جَهَنَّمُ وَبِئْسَ الْمَصِيرُ (١٦)﴾ (الأنفال: ١٥-١٦)

“O you who believe, when you face the disbelievers in a battle, do not turn your backs to them [in flight].” (15) Whoever turns his back to them on such a day, unless swerving [as a strategy] for war or joining [another] company, has certainly earned the wrath from Allah, and his abode is Hell – How evil a destination”. (Al-Anfal 8:15-16)

List of Shameful deeds (Fawahish)

Fawahish encompasses all vile and sinful acts that contradict human nature and Islamic law, whether visible or hidden. These acts are condemned because of their severe harm and their transgression of the rights of Allah and others.

1. Adultery and fornication:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلَا تَقْرَبُوا الزِّنَا إِنَّهُ كَانَ فَاحِشَةً وَسَاءَ سَبِيلًا﴾ (الإسراء: ٣٢)

"And do not approach unlawful sexual intercourse. Indeed, it is ever an immorality and is evil as a way." (Al-Isra 17: 32)

2. homosexuality - The Immorality of the People of Lot:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَلُوطًا إِذْ قَالَ لِقَوْمِهِ أَتَأْتُونَ الْفَاحِشَةَ مَا سَبَقَكُمْ بِهَا مِنْ أَحَدٍ مِّنَ

الْعَالَمِينَ﴾ (الأعراف: ٨٠)

"And [We sent] Lot, when he said to his people, 'Do you commit such immorality as no one has preceded you with from among the worlds?'" (Al-A'raf 7: 80)

1. Speaking About Allah Without Knowledge is a grave immorality.:

قال تعالى: ﴿قُلْ إِنَّمَا حَرَّمَ رَبِّيَ الْفَوَاحِشَ مَا ظَهَرَ مِنْهَا وَمَا بَطَنَ وَالْإِثْمَ وَالْبَغْيَ بِغَيْرِ الْحَقِّ وَأَنْ تُشْرِكُوا بِاللَّهِ مَا لَمْ يُنَزِّلْ بِهِ سُلْطَانًا وَأَنْ تَقُولُوا عَلَى اللَّهِ مَا لَا تَعْلَمُونَ﴾ (الأعراف: ٣٣)

"Say, 'My Lord has only forbidden immoralities—what is apparent of them and what is concealed—and sin, and oppression without right, and that you associate with Allah that for which He has not sent down authority, and that you say about Allah that which you do not know.'" (Al-Araf 7: 33)

Note: To facilitate memorization and recall, this list has been presented in the form of a didactic poem in the final chapter of this book.

Benefits of Rituals

The rituals are prescribed for the benefits of believers to enable a person to fulfill his mission in life according to Allah's guidance.

Prayer strengthens a servant's relationship with his Lord. Fasting develops God-consciousness and self-discipline. Zakah purifies wealth and the soul. Hajj reinforces the meanings of unity and obedience.

The effects of these acts of worship should not end when they are performed. Rather, they should be reflected in a person's character, conduct, and interactions with others, so that the purpose for which they were prescribed may be realized.

Allah, the Exalted, says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَتْلُ مَا أُوحِيَ إِلَيْكَ مِنَ الْكِتَابِ وَأَقِمِ الصَّلَاةَ إِنَّ الصَّلَاةَ تَنْهَى عَنِ الْفَحْشَاءِ وَالْمُنْكَرِ وَلَذِكْرُ اللَّهِ أَكْبَرُ وَاللَّهُ يَعْلَمُ مَا تَصْنَعُونَ﴾ (العنكبوت: ٤٥)

"Recite what has been revealed to you of the Book and establish prayer. Indeed, prayer restrains from immorality and wrongdoing. And the remembrance of Allah is greater. Allah knows what you do." (Al-Ankabut 29:45)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَأَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا كُتِبَ عَلَيْكُمُ الصِّيَامُ كَمَا كُتِبَ عَلَى الَّذِينَ مِن قَبْلِكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ﴾ (البقرة: ١٨٣)

"O you who believe! Fasting has been prescribed for you as it was prescribed for those before you, so that you may attain taqwa." (Al-Baqarah 2:183)

And He says:

قال تعالى: ﴿خُذْ مِنْ أَمْوَالِهِمْ صَدَقَةً تُطَهِّرُهُمْ وَتُزَكِّيهِمْ بِهَا وَصَلِّ عَلَيْهِمْ إِنَّ صَلَاتَكَ سَكَنٌ لَهُمْ وَاللَّهُ سَمِيعٌ عَلِيمٌ﴾ (التوبة: ١٠٣)

"Take charity from their wealth to purify and cleanse them through it, and pray for them. Indeed, your prayer is a source of tranquility for them. Allah is All-Hearing, All-Knowing." (At-Tawbah 9:103)

قال تعالى: ﴿الْحَجُّ أَشْهُرٌ مَّعْلُومَةٌ فَمَن فَرَضَ فِيهِنَّ الْحَجَّ فَلَا رَفَثَ وَلَا فُسُوقَ وَلَا جِدَالَ فِي الْحَجِّ وَمَا تَفْعَلُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ يَعْلَمْهُ اللَّهُ وَتَزَوَّدُوا فَإِنَّ خَيْرَ الزَّادِ التَّقْوَىٰ وَاتَّقُونِ يَا أُولِيَ الْأَلْبَابِ﴾ (البقرة: ١٩٧)

"Hajj is during well-known months. Whoever undertakes Hajj during them must refrain from sexual relations, sinful conduct, and arguments during Hajj. Whatever good you do, Allah knows it. And take provisions, but indeed the best provision is taqwa. So be mindful of Me, O people of understanding." (Al-Baqarah 2:197)

Conclusion

In Islam, worship is not merely a collection of rituals to be performed. Rather, it is a comprehensive way of life that encompasses every attitude and action that pleases Allah, Glorified

and Exalted. The true worshipper is one who combines the observance of prescribed acts of worship with obedience to Allah in every aspect of life, thereby fulfilling the role of His vicegerent (khalifah) on earth, establishing justice, spreading goodness, and carrying out the trust of stewardship in a manner that earns Allah's pleasure.

Thus, the true essence of worship is manifested in sincere faith, righteous deeds, noble character, and steadfast adherence to Allah's commands while avoiding His prohibitions. The more a person embodies these qualities, the closer he comes to the rank of the sincere believers, the God-conscious (muttaqun), and the servants of the Most Merciful (Ibad al-Rahman), who have attained Allah's pleasure, love, and nearness.

6. The Meaning of Al-Rahman (الرحمن)

The name Al-Rahman (الرحمن) appears in the first verse of the Quran, associated with two other names: Allah and Al-Rahim (The Merciful):

قال تعالى: ﴿بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ﴾ (الفاتحة: ١)

“In the name of Allah, Al-Rahman, the Merciful”. (Al-Fatiha 1:1)

It is widely understood that "Allah" is the personal name of the Creator of the universe. This name is unique because it is neither gendered nor pluralized, making it improper to translate. Similarly, "Al-Rahim" is understood as referring to Allah's attribute of mercy, and it is therefore translated as "the Merciful." However, the challenge lies in understanding the meaning of "Al-Rahman" (الرحمان).

While it is recognized that the Quran does not use synonyms, especially within the same verse, as that would contradict the eloquent nature of Arabic and the Quran itself, traditional interpretations often render Al-Rahman as synonymous with Al-Rahim. To resolve this apparent conflict, scholars have suggested that Al-Rahman refers to a broader form of mercy, encompassing all people, whether believers or not, in this life, while Al-Rahim is a mercy specifically reserved for believers in the Hereafter.

However, interpreting Al-Rahman primarily in terms of mercy does not align with how this name is used throughout the Quran. The name Al-Rahman appears 57 times in the Quran, excluding its mention in the Basmalah (except in Surah Al-Fatiha). This name stands out as unique, with no other name of Allah, it is being used interchangeably with the name "Allah". Al-Rahman can even be substituted for Allah in the declaration of faith, as supported by several Quranic verses, including:

قال تعالى: ﴿قُلْ أَدْعُوا اللَّهَ أَوْ ادْعُوا الرَّحْمَنَ أَيًّا مَا تَدْعُوا فَلَهُ الْأَسْمَاءُ الْحُسْنَىٰ﴾ (الإسراء: ١١٠)

"Say: Call upon Allah or call upon Al-Rahman. By whatever name you call upon Him, to Him belong the best names." (Al-Isra 17:110)

In the following two consecutive verses, one verse uses "Allah," while the other uses "Al-Rahman," demonstrating their equivalence:

قال تعالى: ﴿قُلْ أَرَأَيْتُمْ إِنْ أَهْلَكَنِیَ اللَّهُ وَمَنْ مَعِيَ أَوْ رَحِمَنَا فَمَنْ یُجِیرُ الْکَافِرِینَ مِنْ عَذَابِ أَلِیمٍ﴾ (٢٨) قُلْ هُوَ الرَّحْمَنُ ءَامَنَّا بِهِ وَعَلِیْهِ تَوَكَّلْنَا فَسَتَعْلَمُونَ مَنْ هُوَ فِی ضَلَالٍ مُّبِینٍ﴾ (٢٩) (الملك: ٢٨-٢٩)

"Say, 'Tell me, if Allah should destroy me and those with me, or have mercy upon us, who can protect the disbelievers

from a painful punishment?' (28) Say, 'He is Al-Rahman; we have believed in Him, and upon Him we have relied.' So, you will soon come to know who is in open error." (Al-Mulk 67:28-29)”

Similarly, the following two verses in different Surahs illustrate how "Al-Rahman" and "Allah" are used interchangeably:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَوَلَمْ يَرَوْا إِلَى الطَّيْرِ فَوْقَهُمْ صَفَّتٍ وَتَبَيَّنَّ مَا يُمْسِكُهُنَّ إِلَّا الرَّحْمَنُ إِنَّهُ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ بَصِيرٌ﴾ (الملك: ١٩)

“Do they not see the birds above them, spreading and folding their wings? None holds them except Al-Rahman. Surely, He is seeing all things.” (Al-Mulk 67:19)

قال تعالى: ﴿أَلَمْ يَرَوْا إِلَى الطَّيْرِ مُسَخَّرَاتٍ فِي جَوِّ السَّمَاءِ مَا يُمْسِكُهُنَّ إِلَّا اللَّهُ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يُؤْمِنُونَ﴾ (النحل: ٧٩)

“Do they not see the birds controlled in the atmosphere of the sky? None holds them except Allah. Indeed, in that are signs for a people who believe.” (Al-Nahl 16:79)

The Qur'anic Meaning of Al-Rahman

While the meanings of terms like Awliya Allah, Taqwa, Iman, and Ibad Al-Rahman are derived directly from their definitions in the Quran, understanding the name Al-Rahman is based on how it is used throughout the Quran. The simplest way to uncover the meaning of Al-Rahman is to examine what other names can substitute for it in the verses where it appears. Since "Allah" can be substituted in all such verses, it becomes evident that other names with a focus on mercy alone do not fit as well.

Through this exercise, one can conclude that the name Al-Rahman encompasses all of Allah's names and attributes, including His power over creation, authority to punish, dominion over the Hereafter, and more. Thus, Al-Rahman is a unique name that integrates all of Allah's names and attributes into a single term, making it impossible to translate fully into just one word. Its meaning changes depending on the context and the attributes emphasized.

While "Allah" is the personal name of the Creator, and the adjective associated with it is Al-Rahim, meaning "the Merciful," the name Al-Rahman reflects the totality of Allah's attributes. The adjective associated with Al-Rahman is also Al-Rahim, suggesting that even when Allah's name, which already contains the essence of Al-Rahman, is connected to punishment, it inherently carries mercy.

This may explain the significance of the first verse of the Quran, where Allah's personal name and all His attributes are introduced as merciful:

قال تعالى: ﴿بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ﴾ (الفاتحة: ١)

“In the name of Allah, Al-Rahman, the Merciful.” (Al-Fatiha 1:1)

The Qur'anic Use of Al-Rahman

The following verses highlight the different attributes associated with the name Al-Rahman.

1/ Al-Rahman is used in reference to Allah's perfect attributes of creation and control over all that exists. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَتَوَكَّلْ عَلَى الْحَيِّ الَّذِي لَا يَمُوتُ وَسَبِّحْ بِحَمْدِهِ^ج وَكَفَى بِهِ
بِذُنُوبِ عِبَادِهِ خَبِيرًا (٥٨) الَّذِي خَلَقَ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضَ وَمَا بَيْنَهُمَا فِي سِتَّةِ أَيَّامٍ
ثُمَّ اسْتَوَى عَلَى الْعَرْشِ الرَّحْمَنُ فَسَلِّ بِهِ^ج خَبِيرًا (٥٩)﴾ (الفرقان: ٥٨-٥٩)

“And place your trust in the Ever-Living who does not die; and celebrate His praise; and enough is He to be aware of the sins of His slaves. (58) He Who created the heavens and the earth and all that is between in six days, and is firmly established control on the “Arsh” (Throne) (the biggest creation ever), Al-Rahman, so ask about Him someone who knows,” (Al-Furqan 25:58-59)

قال تعالى: ﴿الرَّحْمَنُ عَلَى الْعَرْشِ اسْتَوَى (٥) لَهُ مَا فِي السَّمَوَاتِ وَمَا فِي
الْأَرْضِ وَمَا بَيْنَهُمَا وَمَا تَحْتَ الثَّرَى (٦)﴾ (طه: ٥-٦)

**“Al-Rahman who is in control of the “Arsh” (Throne).
(5) To Him belongs all that in the heavens, all that in the earth**

and whatever is between them and whatever is underneath the soil.” (Taha 20:5-6)

قال تعالى: ﴿الَّذِي خَلَقَ سَبْعَ سَمَاوَاتٍ طِبَاقًا مَّا تَرَى فِي خَلْقِ الرَّحْمَنِ مِن تَفَافُوتٍ فَارْجِعِ الْبَصَرَ هَلْ تَرَى مِن فُطُورٍ﴾ (الملك: ٣)

“He created seven skies, one over the other. You will see nothing out of proportion in the creation of Al-Rahman. So, cast your eye again. Do you see any rifts?” (Al-Mulk 67:3)

Al-Rahman represents Allah’s majestic attributes that reflect threat and punishment, as in the following verses:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا بَتِ إِنِّي أَخَافُ أَن يُمَسِّكَ عَذَابٌ مِّنَ الرَّحْمَنِ فَتَكُونَ لِلشَّيْطَانِ وَلِيًّا﴾ (مريم: ٤٥)

“(Ibrahim said) My dear father, I fear that you will be afflicted by a punishment from Al-Rahman, and you become a companion of Satan.” (Maryam 19:45)

قال تعالى: ﴿قُلْ مَنْ كَانَ فِي الضَّلَالَةِ فَلْيَمْدُدْ لَهُ الرَّحْمَنُ مَدًّا حَتَّىٰ إِذَا رَأَوْا مَا يُوعَدُونَ إِمَّا الْعَذَابَ وَإِمَّا السَّاعَةَ فَسَيَعْلَمُونَ مَنْ هُوَ شَرٌّ مَّكَانًا وَأَضْعَفُ جُندًا﴾ (مريم: ٧٥)

“Say, “Whoever stays straying, Al-Rahman will prolong his span of life until they see what they are being warned of: either the punishment (in this world) or the Hour (Day of

Judgement), then they will know who was worse in position and who is weaker in forces.” (Maryam 19:75)

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّمَا تُنذِرُ مَنِ اتَّبَعَ الذِّكْرَ وَخَشِيَ الرَّحْمَنَ الْغَيْبَ فَبَشِّرْهُ
بِمَغْفِرَةٍ وَأَجْرٍ كَرِيمٍ﴾ (يس: ١١)

“You only warn the one who follows the advice and fears Al-Rahman in secret. So, give him good news of forgiveness and a generous reward.” (Yaseen 36:11)

قال تعالى: ﴿أَتَأْخِذُ مِنْ دُونِهِ ءَالِهَةً إِن يُرِدْنِ الرَّحْمَنُ بِضُرٍّ لَا تُغْنِ عَنِّي
شَفَاعَتُهُمْ شَيْئًا وَلَا يُنْقِذُونِ﴾ (يس: ٢٣)

“Shall I take (other) gods in place of Him. If Al-Rahman intends to do harm to me, their intercession neither help me nor save me?” (Yaseen 36:23)

قال تعالى: ﴿وَمَنْ يَعِشْ عَنْ ذِكْرِ الرَّحْمَنِ نُقَيِّضْ لَهُ شَيْطَانًا فَهُوَ لَهُ قَرِينٌ﴾
(الزخرف: ٣٦)

“Whoever makes himself blind to the remembrance of Al-Rahman, We assign for him a devil who becomes his companion all the time.” (Al-Zughtouf 43:36)

قال تعالى: ﴿قَالَتْ إِنِّي أَعُوذُ بِالرَّحْمَنِ مِنْكَ إِنْ كُنْتَ تَقِيًّا﴾ (مريم: ١٨)

“She (Maryam) said, “I seek refuge with Al-Rahman against you, if you are God-fearing” (Maryam 19:18)

3/ Al-Rahman implies the Controller and the Dominator of the world and the Hereafter as Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَيَوْمَ تَشَقُّ السَّمَاءُ بِالْغَمِّمْ وَنُزِلَ الْمَلَكَةُ تَنْزِيلًا (٢٥) الْمَلَكُ
يَوْمَئِذٍ الْحَقُّ لِلرَّحْمَنِ وَكَانَ يَوْمًا عَلَى الْكَافِرِينَ عَسِيرًا (٢٦)﴾ (الفرقان: ٢٥-٢٦)

“The Day the sky will split open with clouds, and angels will be sent down, descending (in ranks) (25) The kingdom on that day is be the true one, belonging to Al-Rahman: it will be a day of dire difficulty for the disbelievers.” (Al-Furqan 25:25:26)

قال تعالى: ﴿رَبِّ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَمَا بَيْنَهُمَا الرَّحْمَنُ لَا يَمْلِكُونَ مِنْهُ
خِطَابًا (٣٧) يَوْمَ يَقُومُ الرُّوحُ وَالْمَلَكَةُ صَفًّا لَا يَتَكَلَّمُونَ إِلَّا مَنْ أَذِنَ لَهُ الرَّحْمَنُ وَقَالَ
صَوَابًا (٣٨)﴾ [النبا ٣٧-٣٨]

“The Lord of the heavens and the earth and what is between them, Al-Rahman, with Whom none can speak. (37) On the Day when the Spirit (Jibril) and the angels will stand in rows. They will not speak, except for the one who is permitted by Al-Rahman, and speaks aright” (Al-Nabaa 78:37-38)

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ كُلَّ مَنْ فِي السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ إِلَّا آتِيَ الرَّحْمَنِ عَبْدًا﴾ (مریم: ۹۳)

“There is none in the heavens and the earth, but bound to come to Al-Rahman as a slave” (Maryam 19:93)

قال تعالى: ﴿يَوْمَئِذٍ يَتَّبِعُونَ الدَّاعِيَ لَا عِوَجَ لَهُ^ط وَخَشَعَتِ الْأَصْوَاتُ لِلرَّحْمَنِ فَلَا تَسْمَعُ إِلَّا هَمْسًا﴾ (طه: ۱۰۸)

“That day they will follow the caller without any deviation. And the voices will turn low in awe for Al-Rahman. So, nothing will you hear but whispering” (Taha 20:108)

The Divine Name Al-Rahman embraces the fullness of Allah's perfect attributes, making it unique in both its meaning and its comprehensiveness. It reflects His absolute power, majesty, wisdom, and authority, while simultaneously expressing His limitless mercy, compassion, generosity, and care for all creation.

Note: Al-Rahman cannot be fully captured by a single English word. While it is commonly translated as The Most Merciful or The Most Compassionate, the Qur'anic usage of the name reveals a far richer meaning. It denotes the One whose infinite mercy is inseparable from His perfect power, wisdom, justice, and lordship over all creation.

Bismillah

Bismillah is a powerful declaration that marks the start of our actions with divine purpose. It is no coincidence that these blessed words open Allah's final message to humanity, the Quran. We recite *Bismillah* at the start of every chapter of the Quran (except one) as a reminder of this significance.

Moreover, Prophet Noah (Nuh) invoked *Bismillah* when embarking on his monumental journey aboard the ark to save the believers from the flood:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَقَالَ ارْكَبُوا فِيهَا بِسْمِ اللَّهِ مَجْرَاهَا وَمُرْسَاهَا إِنَّ رَبِّي لَغَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ﴾ (هود: ٤١)

“He (Nuh) said, “Board it! In the Name of Allah, it sails and anchors. Surely my Lord is All-Forgiving, Most Merciful.” (Hud 11:41)

Similarly, Prophet Sulaiman (Solomon) began his letter to the Queen of Sheba with *Bismillah*:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّهُ مِنْ سُلَيْمَانَ وَإِنَّهُ بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ (٣٠) أَلَّا تَعْلُوا عَلَيَّ وَأْتُونِي مُسْلِمِينَ﴾ (النمل: ٣٠-٣١)

“It is from Sulaiman, and it is (written) ‘In the name of Allah, Al-Rahman, the Merciful, (30) Do not exalt yourselves

against me but come to me in submission [as Muslims].” (Al-Naml 27:30-31)

The Prophet (PBUH) also emphasized the importance of starting our deeds with the mention of Allah, saying:

حديث أبي هريرة رضي الله عنه قال : قال رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم :
(كُلُّ كَلَامٍ أَوْ أَمْرٍ ذِي بَالٍ لَا يَفْتَحُ بِذِكْرِ اللَّهِ فَهُوَ أَتَمُّ - أَوْ قَالَ : أَقْطَعُ -) رواه الإمام أحمد
في " المسند "

"Every speech or task of importance that does not begin with the mention of Allah is incomplete – or he said: cut off (from blessing)."

The psychological and spiritual impact of beginning with *Bismillah*

Consider the difference between speaking on your own behalf versus speaking on behalf of a king, a president, or a CEO. In the first case, you may feel nervous, striving for approval and recognition. Praise may inflate your ego, while criticism may hurt and demoralize you. In this way, seeking validation can make you a servant to the opinions of others.

However, when you speak or act in the name of Allah, your heart is aligned with divine guidance. You are liberated from fear because you no longer seek applause or fear rejection from people.

Instead, your actions become acts of worship, driven by sincerity and the desire to please Allah alone.

Purification of the Intention

Starting any task with *Bismillah* (in the name of Allah) purifies your intention, ensuring that your effort is sincere and pleasing to Allah. Success is seen as a blessing from Allah, and failure is embraced as a divine test meant to strengthen your faith. This mindset cultivates patience and full reliance on Allah.

When you start any action in the name of Allah, your reward goes beyond worldly gain and becomes both spiritual and eternal. Your focus shifts from solely material outcomes to fulfilling a higher purpose. You hold yourself accountable to divine principles, knowing that Allah judges both your intentions and actions.

Internal Peace

When you start in the name of Allah, you will focus on seeking Allah's pleasure rather than the approval of others, you foster sincerity, and inner peace.

Dhikr Allah

Beginning any task with Bismillah fulfills Allah's command to remain in a constant state of His remembrance (Dhikr Allah) as Allah instructs us:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا اذْكُرُوا اللَّهَ ذِكْرًا كَثِيرًا وَسَبِّحُوهُ بُكْرَةً وَأَصِيلًا﴾ (الأحزاب: ٤١)

“O you who believe, remember Allah with much remembrance and glorify Him morning and evening. (Al-Ahzab 33:41)

Is Dhikr simply the act of repeating Allah’s names and His praises?

While reciting Allah’s names and praises is important practice, true remembrance of Allah (Dhikr) goes beyond mere repetition—it involves a deeper connection and context. In Surah Al-Baqarah, Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿فَإِذَا قَضَيْتُمْ مَنَاسِكَكُمْ فَاذْكُرُوا اللَّهَ كَذِكْرِكُمْ آبَاءَكُمْ أَوْ أَشَدَّ ذِكْرًا﴾ (البقرة: ٢٠٠)

“And when you have completed your rites (of Hajj), then remember Allah as you remember your fathers or with an even greater remembrance.” (Al-Baqara 2:200)

This verse teaches us that remembering Allah should surpass how we recall our fathers. How do we typically remember our fathers? Not by simply repeating their names, but by reflecting on their teachings, recalling their love and sacrifices, and feeling a sense of gratitude toward them. In the same way, true Dhikr of

Allah means reflecting on His guidance, being mindful of His blessings, and expressing our devotion, love, and gratitude. It is an act of the heart and mind, not just the tongue.

Remembrance (Dhikr) and Heedlessness

To achieve a state of continuous *Dhikr Allah*, it is essential to understand its opposite: (غفلة) *ghaflah* (heedlessness). A Muslim is either in a state of Allah's remembrance (*Dhikr Allah*) (ذكر الله) or in a state of heedlessness (*ghaflah*) (غفلة عن الله).

When we are in the state of remembrance of Allah (ذكر الله), we are fully aware that He is seeing everything we do and listening to every word we utter, He is even aware of every inner thought we have. This awareness compels us to uphold the best character and moral conduct. This state of mindfulness aligns with the definition of *Ihsan* given by the Prophet (PBUH):

(أن تعبد الله كأنك تراه فإن لم تكن تراه فإنه يراك)

"[Ihsan] is to worship Allah as though you see Him, and if you cannot see Him, then be certain that He sees you."

Awareness that Allah is constantly watching and listening transforms our actions. It motivates us to do what pleases Him and avoid what displeases Him. In this way, *Dhikr Allah* becomes the manifestation of *Ihsan* (spiritual excellence) and the essence of *Taqwa* (God-consciousness).

Dhikr as a spiritual state

Dhikr Allah is a spiritual state of deep awareness of Allah within the heart and mind. This spiritual state can be cultivated through acts of worship, mainly prayers as Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنِّي أَنَا اللَّهُ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَنَا فَاعْبُدْنِي وَأَقِمِ الصَّلَاةَ لِذِكْرِي﴾ (طه: ١٤)

Indeed, I am Allah; there is no God but Me. So, worship Me and establish prayers for My remembrance. (Taha 20:14)

Prayer as a form of dhikr

Prayer, whether obligatory or voluntary, is a primary means of increasing our remembrance of Allah. It is essential to understand that prayer is not an end in itself but a means to attain the state of continuous *Dhikr Allah*. Unfortunately, some Muslims treat prayer as a mere ritual without allowing it to influence their character or behavior.

True Dhikr requires spiritual awareness and mindful worship, extending beyond verbal repetition to an inner consciousness that shapes our thoughts, words, and actions. Prayer serves as a key tool in strengthening this state, but we must ensure that it enhances our connection with Allah rather than being a mere mechanical routine.

Dhikr is the Aim and prayer is the Mean

Allah has blessed us with prayer as a way to connect with Him, purify our souls, and remain in constant remembrance of

Him. This state of remembrance refines our character and guides our behavior toward righteousness. In Surah Al-Ankabut, Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَتْلُ مَا أُوحِيَ إِلَيْكَ مِنَ الْكِتَابِ وَأَقِمِ الصَّلَاةَ إِنَّ الصَّلَاةَ تَنْهَىٰ عَنِ الْفَحْشَاءِ وَالْمُنْكَرِ وَلَذِكْرُ اللَّهِ أَكْبَرُ وَاللَّهُ يَعْلَمُ مَا تَصْنَعُونَ﴾ (العنكبوت: ٤٥)

“Recite what has been revealed to you of the book and establish the prayer. Indeed, prayers restrain from immorality and wrongdoing. But the remembrance of Allah is greater. And Allah knows whatsoever you do.” (Al-Ankabut 29:45)

This verse highlights that *Dhikr Allah* (the remembrance of Allah) holds a higher purpose than prayer, not because prayer is insignificant, but because it serves as a means to achieve the ultimate goal of fostering an enduring state of *Dhikr Allah*.

To illustrate the distinction between a goal and its means, consider this example: If you advise your child, "Drive slowly to arrive home safely," your primary goal is their safe arrival, while "driving slowly" is the mean to achieve that goal. In the same way, we perform our prayers as a means to foster a continuous remembrance of Allah, one that shapes our thoughts, strengthens our hearts, and guides our actions.

7. Haneef (حنيف)

One of the remarkable features of Islam, setting it apart from previous religions, is its emphasis on ease and the removal of hardship. Numerous Quranic verses and sayings of Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) highlight this principle. Allah states in the Quran:

قال تعالى: ﴿يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ بِكُمُ الْيُسْرَ وَلَا يُرِيدُ بِكُمُ الْعُسْرَ﴾ (البقرة: ١٨٥)

"Allah wants ease for you and does not want to impose hardship on you." (Al Baqarah 2:185)

قال تعالى: ﴿يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ أَنْ يُخَفِّفَ عَنْكُمْ وَخُلِقَ الْإِنْسَانُ ضَعِيفًا﴾ (النساء: ٢٨)

"Allah wants to lighten things for you, for mankind was created weak" (Al-Nisaa 4:28)

قال تعالى: ﴿مَا يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ لِيَجْعَلَ عَلَيْكُمْ مِنْ حَرَجٍ وَلَكِنْ يُرِيدُ لِيُطَهِّرَكُمْ وَلِيُتِمَّ نِعْمَتَهُ عَلَيْكُمْ﴾ (المائدة: ٦)

"Allah does not intend to place any inconvenience on you, but He desires to purify you and complete his favors upon you" (Al-Maeda 5:6)

These verses and others affirm the simplicity and ease embedded in Islam. But how easy is Islam, and what is the basis of

this simplicity? The foundation of Islam lies in the religion of Prophet Ibrahim (Abraham), which Allah commands us to follow:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَقَالُوا كُونُوا هُودًا أَوْ نَصَارَى تَهْتَدُوا قُلْ بَلْ مِلَّةَ إِبْرَاهِيمَ حَنِيفًا ۖ وَمَا كَانَ مِنَ الْمُشْرِكِينَ﴾ (البقرة: ١٣٥)

“They said: Be Jews or Christians and you will be guided. Say: No, but (we follow) the religion of Ibrahim, “Haneef”an”, and he was never of the idolaters.” (Al-Baqarah 2:135)

قال تعالى: ﴿وَمَنْ أَحْسَنُ دِينًا مِمَّنْ أَسْلَمَ وَجْهَهُ لِلَّهِ وَهُوَ مُحْسِنٌ وَاتَّبَعَ مِلَّةَ إِبْرَاهِيمَ حَنِيفًا وَاتَّخَذَ اللَّهُ إِبْرَاهِيمَ خَلِيلًا﴾ (النساء: ١٢٥)

“And who is better in religion than one who submits himself to Allah, does good deeds and follows the religion of Ibrahim, “Haneef”an”! And Allah took Ibrahim as an intimate friend.” (Al-Nisa 4:125)

قال تعالى: ﴿قُلْ إِنِّي هَدَيْتَنِي رَبِّيَ إِلَى صِرَاطٍ مُسْتَقِيمٍ دِينًا قِيَمًا مِلَّةَ إِبْرَاهِيمَ حَنِيفًا وَمَا كَانَ مِنَ الْمُشْرِكِينَ﴾ (الأنعام: ١٦١)

“Say, “Indeed, my Lord has guided me to a straight path - a correct religion - the religion of Ibrahim, “Haneef”an”, and he was not of the idolaters.” (Al-Anaam 6:161)

The defining feature of Prophet Ibrahim's religion is encapsulated in the term Haneef, which serves as the foundation of all divinely revealed religions, including Islam. Linguistically, Haneef conveys the idea of inclining toward something.

The word “Haneef” is generally translated as “upright” and often interpreted to mean "deviating from all false religions". However, this interpretation contradicts the understanding that the true religion is the straight path, while false religions deviate from it. A more accurate interpretation is that Haneef refers to inclining toward the natural disposition (fitrah) Allah has instilled in humanity. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿فَأَقِمْ وَجْهَكَ لِلدِّينِ حَنِيفًا فِطْرَتَ اللَّهِ الَّتِي فَطَرَ النَّاسَ عَلَيْهَا لَا تَبْدِيلَ لِخَلْقِ اللَّهِ ذَٰلِكَ الدِّينُ الْقَيِّمُ وَلَكِنَّ أَكْثَرَ النَّاسِ لَا يَعْلَمُونَ﴾ (الرّوم: ٣٠)

“So, direct your face toward the religion, Haneef’an, Allah’s Fitrah (natural disposition) that He has instilled in mankind. No change should there be in the creation of Allah. That is the correct religion, but most people do not know.” (Al-Rum 30:30)

This verse clarifies that the Haneef religion aligns with the pure, natural disposition inherent in all humans. It restores humanity to the original upright state of their creation, free from distortions caused by false beliefs and practices. Prophet Ibrahim is uniquely described as Haneef because he recognized Allah's

oneness through his innate disposition (fitrah), even before receiving divine revelation.

The religion that aligns with the pure disposition (Fitra) is based on the principles practiced by Prophet Ibrahim. These principles are threefold: belief in Allah, belief in the Day of Judgment, and performing righteous deeds that benefit humanity. These same principles form the core foundation of Islam, as delivered by Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) and all previous messengers, with variations only in some specific rituals. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَمَا تَفَرَّقَ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتَابَ إِلَّا مِنْ بَعْدِ مَا جَاءَتْهُمْ الْبَيِّنَةُ ۚ وَمَا أُمِرُوا إِلَّا لِيَعْبُدُوا اللَّهَ مُخْلِصِينَ لَهُ الدِّينَ حُنَفَاءَ وَيُقِيمُوا الصَّلَاةَ وَيُؤْتُوا الزَّكَاةَ ۚ وَذَٰلِكَ دِينُ الْقِيَمَةِ ۝﴾ (البينة: ٤-٥)

And those who were given the Book did not divide but after the clear proof had come to them. (4) While they were only commanded to worship Allah with sincere devotion, inclining to their Fitra, and to establish prayer and pay Zakah. That is the correct religion. (Al-Bayyina 98:4-5)

Excluding the variations in rituals conveyed by the messengers, the religion based on Fitra consists of the following elements:

1. Believe in Allah and invoke none besides Him. This involves trusting in Allah, seeking His forgiveness often and acknowledging His blessings.

2. Believe in the accountability on the Day of Judgement

3. Doing righteous deeds that can involve:

- Give charity and avoid miserliness.
- Be trustworthy and protect others' wealth.
- Speak truthfully, testify honestly, and use respectful language.
- Honor trusts and covenants faithfully.
- Uphold justice
- Honor the sanctity of life.
- Avoid arrogance and hurting the feelings of others.
- Exercise patience, forgive others, and maintain contentment.
- Stay humble and respond peacefully to ignorant people.
- Enjoin what is right, forbid wrong.
- Maintain cleanliness, eat lawful food.
- Preserve chastity.
- Pray for righteous families and aspire to be a model of Taqwa.

Excluding ritual acts, all the above elements as the foundation of a fitrah-based religion are precisely the same as those defined by Allah for being a righteous Muslim.

Preserving the Simplicity of Islam

Islam is the religion of **fitrah** (the natural disposition). It is the simplest and most natural way of life for human beings, provided they preserve the purity of their innate nature. This is confirmed by the saying of the Prophet ﷺ, narrated by Abu Hurayrah (may Allah be pleased with him):

عن أبي هريرة رضي الله عنه، قال: قال رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم: ما من مولود إلا يولد على الفطرة، فأبواه يهودانه أو ينصرانه أو يمجسانه. (البخاري ومسلم)

"Every child is born upon the fitrah; then his parents make him a Jew, a Christian, or a Magian." (Reported by al-Bukhari, no. 1358, and Muslim, no. 2658.)

To preserve the simplicity of Islam, Allah and His Messenger ﷺ cautioned against excessive questioning about matters of the lawful and the unlawful, since the basic rule is that **everything is permissible unless there is an explicit text prohibiting it.**

Allah, the Exalted, says:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا لَا تَسْأَلُوا عَنْ أَشْيَاءَ إِن تُبَدَّ لَكُمْ تَسْأَلُكُمْ وَإِن تَسْأَلُوا عَنْهَا حِينَ يُنْزِلُ الْقُرْءَانَ تُبَدَّ لَكُمْ عَفَا اللَّهُ عَنْهَا وَاللَّهُ غَفُورٌ حَلِيمٌ﴾ (المائدة: ١٠١)

"O you who believe! Do not ask about matters which, if they were made clear to you, would cause you hardship. But if

you ask about them while the Qur'an is being revealed, they will be made clear to you. Allah has pardoned what is past, and Allah is All-Forgiving, Most Forbearing." *Al-Ma'idah 5:101*

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

(إن أعظم المسلمين في المسلمين جرماً من سأل عن شيء لم يحرم على المسلمين فحرم عليهم من أجل مسألتهم.) ورد في البخاري ومسلم وغيرهم

"Among the Muslims who commit the greatest offense is the one who asks about something that had not been forbidden, but it becomes forbidden because of his questioning." (Reported by al-Bukhari, no. 7289, and Muslim, no. 2358.)

He ﷺ also said:

" ما أحل الله في كتابه فهو حلال وما حرم فهو حرام وما سكت عنه فهو عافية، فاقبلوا من الله عافيته، فإن الله لم يكن لينسى شيئاً " (رواه البزار والطبراني. والحاكم)

"Whatever Allah has made lawful in His Book is lawful, whatever He has made unlawful is unlawful, and whatever He has remained silent about is excused. Therefore, accept from Allah His concession, for Allah does not forget anything." (Reported by al-Bazzar in his Musnad, al-Tabarani, Ahmad, and authenticated by al-Hakim.)

Nafi narrated from Ibn Umar who said:

عن نافع عن ابن عمر قال : (خرج رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم في بعض أسفاره ، فسار ليلاً ، فمر على رجل جالس عند مقراة له ، فقال له عمر : يا صاحب

المقراة ، ولغت السباع الليلة في مقراتك . فقال النبي صلى الله عليه وسلم : يا صاحب المقراة ، لا تخبره ، هذا متكلف (سنن الدارقطني)

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ once went out on one of his journeys and passed by a man sitting beside a **maqrah** (a water basin or reservoir). The man asked:

"O owner of the basin! Do wild animals drink from your basin?"

The Prophet ﷺ replied:

"O owner of the basin, do not answer him. This is unnecessary questioning. The animals drink with what they carry in their stomachs, while what remains after them is pure for us." (Reported by al-Daraqutni in As-Sunan.)

Note: A **maqrah** is a basin or reservoir in which water collects.

8. Knowledge (Ilm), Assumption (Zann), and Doubt (Shakk)

Human understanding exists at different levels:

1. **Knowledge ('ilm):** Knowing something on the basis of clear and objective evidence.
2. **Assumption (zann):** Accepting something as true without objective evidence.
3. **Doubt (shakk):** Hesitating between two equally possible alternatives without objective evidence favoring either one.
4. **Delusion (wahn):** Believing the less probable of two alternatives.
5. **Simple ignorance (al-jahl al-basit):** Being unaware of something.
6. **Compound ignorance (al-jahl al-murakkab):** Holding a false belief while assuming it to be true.

The Qur'an uses the terms **assumption (zann)** and **doubt (shakk)** in a number of contexts. Their precise meanings are determined by the context in which they appear. Although the nuances of these terms may vary from one passage to another, their usage remains consistent with their established meanings in the Arabic language. The following definitions summarize their linguistic meanings:

- **Assumption (zann):** The mind's inclination to accept something as true without decisive evidence.

- **Doubt (shakk):** Hesitation between two possibilities when neither can be judged more likely than the other.

Both terms appear in the following verse:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَمَا قَتَلُوهُ وَمَا صَلَبُوهُ وَلَٰكِن شُبِّهَ لَهُمْ وَإِنَّ الَّذِينَ اخْتَلَفُوا فِيهِ لَفِي شَكٍّ مِّنْهُ مَا لَهُمْ بِهِ مِنْ عِلْمٍ إِلَّا اتِّبَاعَ الظَّنِّ وَمَا قَتَلُوهُ يَقِينًا﴾ (النساء: ١٥٧)

"...They neither killed him nor crucified him, but it was made to appear so to them. Those who differ concerning him are certainly in doubt about it. They have no knowledge of it except the following of assumption. They certainly did not kill him." (*An-Nisa* 4:157)

In this verse, **assumption (zann)** refers to accepting something as true without objective evidence. The Jews claimed that they had killed Jesus (peace be upon him), yet they possessed no objective evidence to support that claim. Their belief therefore amounted to nothing more than an assumption.

Likewise, **doubt (shakk)** refers to rejecting something without objective evidence to establish either position. In the same verse, some people were inclined to reject that Jesus (peace be upon him) had in fact been killed, yet they possessed no evidence to confirm or deny it.

Assumption in the Last Day

In several verses, the Qur'an uses the word **zann** to describe the believers' faith that they will meet Allah on the Day of Resurrection, even though no material evidence can presently verify that event. This demonstrates that the meaning of **zann** depends upon its context.

When **zann** concerns observable, worldly matters, it denotes accepting something without objective evidence. However, when it concerns the unseen (*al-ghayb*), it signifies **firm conviction based upon revelation rather than empirical evidence**.

Accordingly, the most accurate translation in these verses is: The believers are firmly convinced that they will meet their Lord, even though no material evidence presently exists to verify that future event.

قال تعالى: ﴿وَأَسْتَعِينُوا بِالصَّبْرِ وَالصَّلَاةِ وَإِنَّهَا لَكَبِيرَةٌ إِلَّا عَلَى الْخَاشِعِينَ﴾ (٤٥)

الَّذِينَ يَظُنُّونَ أَنَّهُمْ مُلَاقُوا رَبِّهِمْ وَأَنَّهُمْ إِلَىٰ رَبِّهِمْ رَاجِعُونَ (٤٦) ﴿البقرة: ٤٥-٤٦﴾

"Seek help through patience and prayer. Indeed, it is difficult except for the humble, those who have Zann (firmly convinced without material evidence) believe that they will meet their Lord and that to Him they will return." (Al-Baqarah 2:45-46)

Knowledge (Ilm)

Understanding the Qur'anic meanings of **assumption** and **doubt** also helps explain verses in which Allah says that He tests people "**so that He may know.**" Since Allah's knowledge is eternal, perfect, and encompasses everything before it occurs, these verses cannot mean that Allah acquires new knowledge through testing.

Rather, within the Qur'anic usage, **knowledge ('ilm)** refers to **knowledge established by objective evidence**. Allah's tests do not increase His knowledge; instead, they establish objective evidence that manifests the reality of people's faith and actions.

Accordingly, the expression "**that Allah may know**" may be understood as:

"that Allah may establish objective evidence of..."

or

"that Allah may make evident..."

This understanding preserves both the perfection of Allah's eternal knowledge and the purpose of His tests.

Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَمْ حَسِبْتُمْ أَنْ تَدْخُلُوا الْجَنَّةَ وَلَمَّا يَعْلَمِ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ جَاهَدُوا مِنْكُمْ وَيَعْلَمَ الصَّادِقِينَ﴾ (آل عمران: ١٤٢)

"Or do you think that you will enter Paradise before Allah establishes who among you strive in His cause and who are steadfast?" (Al 'Imran 3:142)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿أَمْ حَسِبْتُمْ أَنْ تُتْرَكُوا وَلَمَّا يَعْلَمِ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ جَاهَدُوا مِنْكُمْ وَلَمْ يَتَّخِذُوا مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ وَلَا رَسُولِهِ وَلَا الْمُؤْمِنِينَ وَلِجَنَّةٍ وَاللَّهُ خَبِيرٌ بِمَا تَعْمَلُونَ﴾ (التوبة: ١٦)

"Or do you think that you will be left alone before Allah establishes who among you strive and do not take anyone besides Allah, His Messenger, and the believers as close allies? Allah is fully aware of all that you do." (At-Tawbah 9:16)

And He says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَمَا أَصْبَحُكُمْ يَوْمَ التَّتَيِّ الْجَمْعَانِ فَيَاذَنْ اللَّهُ وَلِيَعْلَمَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ﴾ (١٦٦) وَلِيَعْلَمَ الَّذِينَ نَافَقُوا^ج (آل عمران: ١٦٦-١٦٧)

"What befell you on the day the two armies met was by Allah's permission, so that He might establish who are the true believers and distinguish those who were hypocrites..." (Al 'Imran 3:166–167)

The Testimony of the Human Limbs

Some may ask: **Why does Allah establish material evidence before passing judgment upon people?**

The answer is that Allah's justice, Glorified and Exalted, is not based solely upon His absolute and all-encompassing knowledge. Rather, it is founded upon objective evidence that conclusively establishes the truth. Even when people are presented with a detailed record of their deeds, some may persist in denying them. Therefore, perfect justice requires that a person come to know himself through undeniable evidence. This is why, on the Day of Resurrection, confession will arise from the sinners' own bodies, leaving them with no room for denial. Their own testimony establishes the proof against them. Indeed, confession is among the strongest forms of evidence, and evidence is what distinguishes truth from falsehood.

The Testimony of the Human Limbs on the Day of Resurrection

The matter reaches its climax when Allah, Glorified and Exalted, enables a person's own limbs to testify against him, as described in the following verses:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَيَوْمَ يُحْشَرُ أَعْدَاءُ اللَّهِ إِلَى النَّارِ فَهُمْ يُوزَعُونَ (١٩) حَتَّىٰ إِذَا مَا جَاءُوهَا شَهِدَ عَلَيْهِمْ سَمْعُهُمْ وَأَبْصَرُهُمْ وَجُلُودُهُمْ بِمَا كَانُوا يَعْمَلُونَ (٢٠)﴾ (فصلت: ١٩-٢٠)

"And on the Day when the enemies of Allah are gathered to the Fire, they will be driven onward until, when they reach it, their hearing, their sight, and their skins will testify against them concerning what they used to do." (Fussilat 41:19–20)

The Prophetic Hadith on the Testimony of the Limbs

This understanding is further confirmed by the hadith narrated by Anas ibn Malik (may Allah be pleased with him), recorded in *Sahih Muslim*. It describes a remarkable scene on the Day of Resurrection:

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

عن أنس رضي الله عنه قال: قال رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم من مخاطبة العبد ربه يقول: يارب ألم تجرني من الظلم؟ قال: يقول: بلى قال: فيقول: فإني أجزى على نفسي إلا شاهدا مني قال: فيقول: كفى بنفسك اليوم عليك شهيدا وبالكرام الكاتبين شهودا قال: فيختم على فيه فيقال لأركانہ: انطقي قال: فتتطرق بأعماله ثم يخلى بينه وبين الكلام قال: فيقول: بعدا لكنّ وسحقا فعنكنّ كنت أناضل) رواه مسلم

"A servant will say, 'My Lord, have You not protected me from injustice?' Allah will reply, 'Yes.' The servant will then say, 'I will accept no witness against me except myself.' Allah will say, 'Today you are sufficient as a witness against yourself, and the noble recording angels are also witnesses.' Then his mouth will be sealed, and it will be said to his limbs, 'Speak.' So they will testify concerning his deeds." (Reported by Muslim, no. 2969.)

Conclusion

The Noble Qur'an and the Prophetic Sunnah affirm that Allah's justice is founded upon establishing conclusive evidence and removing every excuse. Although Allah, Glorified and Exalted, has complete knowledge of everything before it occurs, His system of perfect justice ensures that the evidence is made manifest before every individual. In this way, the proof is established against each person through the clearest possible means, making Allah's justice perfect, transparent, and free from any basis for dispute or denial.

9. Guidance (Hidayah) and Misguidance (Dalal)

A correct understanding of the Qur'anic concept of guidance is essential for resolving one of the verses that is frequently quoted at the beginning of Friday sermons:

قال تعالى: ﴿مَنْ يَهْدِ اللَّهُ فَهُوَ الْمُهْتَدِ وَمَنْ يُضِلِّ فَأُولَئِكَ هُمُ الْخَاسِرُونَ﴾

(الأعراف: ١٧٨)

"Whomever Allah guides, none can lead astray; and whomever He allows to stray, they are the true losers." (*Al-A'raf* 7:178)

He also says:

قال تعالى: ﴿مَنْ يَهْدِ اللَّهُ فَهُوَ الْمُهْتَدِ وَمَنْ يُضِلِّ فَلَنْ تَجِدَ لَهُ وَلِيًّا مُرْشِدًا﴾ (الكهف: ١٧)

"Whomever Allah guides is truly guided, but whomever He allows to stray, you will never find for him a guiding protector." (*Al-Kahf* 18:17)

Although every Muslim believes that Allah, Glorified and Exalted, is the One who guides mankind, some people find it difficult to understand how Allah could allow certain people to go astray, and then hold them accountable for their deeds. To resolve this apparent contradiction, it is essential to recognize that the Qur'an describes **three distinct types of guidance** that Allah grants to humanity:

1. **Universal Guidance**
2. **Supportive Guidance of Divine Assistance**
3. **Sustaining Guidance of Steadfastness**

1. **Universal Guidance**

This is the foundational guidance that Allah grants to every human being through two primary means:

- a. Innate nature of creation (Fitrah)
- b. Instructive resources (Through Prophets and Messengers).

a. **Innate Nature of Creation:**

Allah has instilled each human being with an inherent capacity to recognize Him, distinguish between truth and falsehood, and discern right from wrong. This innate sense of guidance is described in Surah Al-Insan (الإنسان):

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّا هَدَيْنَاهُ السَّبِيلَ إِمَّا شَاكِرًا وَإِمَّا كَفُورًا﴾ (الإنسان: ٣)

“We guided him to the path; he will either be grateful or be ungrateful.” (Al-Insan 76:3)

b. **Instructive Guidance Through Messengers**

In addition to this innate guidance, Allah has sent Prophets and messengers to teach and demonstrate His revelations. For

example, the people of Thamud received this guidance through Prophet Saleh:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَأَمَّا ثَمُودُ فَهَدَيْنَاهُمْ فَاسْتَحَبُّوا الْعَمَىٰ عَلَى الْهُدَىٰ فَأَخَذَتْهُمُ صَاعِقَةٌ
الْعَذَابِ الْهُونِ بِمَا كَانُوا يَكْسِبُونَ﴾ (فصلت: ١٧)

“As to the Thamud, We gave them guidance, but they preferred blindness to guidance: so the stunning Punishment of humiliation seized them, because of what they had earned.”
(Fusulat 41:17)

Since Allah has granted humanity free will, individuals have the choice to accept or reject this universal guidance. Those who accept it become eligible for the next two types of guidance.

2. Supportive Guidance of Divine Assistance

Supportive guidance is a special type of guidance granted only to those who have embraced the universal guidance. Those who reject universal guidance are entirely deprived of this supportive assistance. This guidance is necessary for those who have chosen the straight path to help them remain steadfast. The Quran highlights this concept:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَالَّذِينَ اهْتَدَوْا زَادَهُمْ هُدًى وَآتَاهُمْ تَقْوَاهُمْ﴾ (محمد: ١٧)

**“But to those who consent to be guided, He increases their guidance and bestows on them their Taqwa.”
(Muhammad 47:17)**

Similarly, in Surat Maryam:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَيَزِدُّ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ اهْتَدَوْا هُدًى﴾ (مريم: ٧٦)

**“Allah increases guidance for those who are guided”
(Maryam 19:76)**

When Allah speaks of not guiding someone, He specifically refers to this supportive guidance, which is reserved for those who accept universal guidance. Therefore, when we read the verse in Surah Al-Qasas:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّكَ لَا تَهْدِي مَنْ أَحْبَبْتَ وَلَكِنَّ اللَّهَ يَهْدِي مَنْ يَشَاءُ وَهُوَ أَعْلَمُ
بِالْمُهْتَدِينَ﴾ (القصص: ٥٦)

“You will not be able to guide whom you love; but Allah guides whom He wills and He knows best those who accepted guidance. (Al-Qasas 28:56)

We understand that this verse speaks about the second type of guidance, the guidance of support.

3. Sustaining Guidance of Steadfastness

This type of guidance ensures that individuals who continue to follow Allah's guidance remain firm in their faith and steadfast on the straight path. This guidance is essential not only during our lives but also after death and during resurrection. It is necessary for successfully answering the questions in the grave. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿يُثَبِّتُ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا بِالْقَوْلِ الثَّابِتِ فِي الْحَيَاةِ الدُّنْيَا وَفِي الْآخِرَةِ وَيُضِلُّ اللَّهُ الظَّالِمِينَ وَيَفْعَلُ اللَّهُ مَا يَشَاءُ﴾ (إبراهيم: ٢٧)

“Allah reinforces those who believe with the proper response, in this world and in the Hereafter; but Allah misguides the unjust: Allah does whatever He wills”. (Ibrahim 14:27)

This guidance is also needed to project light in front of us as we stay on the path to Paradise. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَوْمَ تَرَى الْمُؤْمِنِينَ وَالْمُؤْمِنَاتِ يَسْعَى نُورُهُمْ بَيْنَ أَيْدِيهِمْ وَبِأَيْمَانِهِمْ بُشْرَاكُمُ الْيَوْمَ جَنَّاتٌ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهَارُ خَالِدِينَ فِيهَا ذَلِكَ هُوَ الْفَوْزُ الْعَظِيمُ﴾ (الحديد: ١٢)

“On that day you will see the believing men and the believing women with their Light shining ahead of them and by their right: (their greeting will be): "Good News for you this Day, gardens beneath which rivers flow to live in forever. Truly, this is the greatest success." (Al-Hadeed 57:12)

Conclusion

If we accept Allah's general guidance, He will provide us with both supporting guidance in this life and sustaining guidance even after our departure from this world. Those who reject the general guidance, Allah will leave them to their own whim.

Resolving the Paradox of Misguidance (ضلال)

Some may still wonder why Allah does not extend supportive guidance to everyone.

Just as Allah has established divine laws (سنن الله) governing the universe, He has also set laws that dictate the consequences of human actions. Among these divine laws is one that determines who will be deprived of special guidance beyond what the messengers have delivered. This law is clearly outlined in the Quran, by describing the behaviors of those who are denied supportive guidance.

Allah states: (وَاللَّهُ لَا يَهْدِي الْقَوْمَ الظَّالِمِينَ) **“Allah does not guide the unjust (wrongdoers)”**.

This declaration appears ten times in the Quran, including in the following verses:

(Al-Baqara 2:258, Al-Imran 3:86, Al-Maeda 5:51, Al-An'am 6:144, At-Tawba 9:19, At-Tawba 9:109, Al-Qasas 28:50, Al-Ahqaf 46:10, As-Saff 61:7, Al-Jumu'ah 62:5).

Injustice is the most frequently mentioned attribute in the Quran as a reason for Allah depriving individuals of supportive guidance. In addition to injustice, the Quran identifies other characteristics that render a person undeserving of Allah's supportive guidance:

Other behaviors that cause a person to be deprived of supporting guidance include:

1. Rebellion (فسق): Allah says:

(وَاللَّهُ لَا يَهْدِي الْقَوْمَ الْفَاسِقِينَ) **"Allah does not guide the rebellious."**

This statement is repeated five times in the Quran: (*Al-Maida* 5:108, *At-Tawba* 9:24, *At-Tawba* 9:80, *As-Saff* 61:5, *Al-Munafiqoon* 63:6).

2. Disbelief (كفر): Allah warns: (وَاللَّهُ لَا يَهْدِي الْقَوْمَ الْكَافِرِينَ) **"Allah does not guide the disbelievers (those who reject faith)."**

This warning is repeated four times in the Quran: (*Al-Baqara* 2:264, *At-Tawba* 9:37, *An-Nahl* 16:107, *Al-Maida* 5:67).

3. Betrayal (خيانة): Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿وَأَنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يَهْدِي الْخَائِنِينَ﴾ (يوسف: ٥٢)

"Indeed, Allah does not guide the snare of the betrayers." (*Yusuf* 12:52)

4. Lying and Disbelief: Allah states:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يَهْدِي مَنْ هُوَ كَاذِبٌ كَفَّارٌ﴾ (الزمر: ٣)

"Indeed, Allah does not guide anyone who is a liar and disbeliever." (*Az-Zumar 39:3*)

5. Extravagance and Lying (إسراف وكذب): Allah declares:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يَهْدِي مَنْ هُوَ مُسْرِفٌ كَذَّابٌ﴾ (غافر: ٢٨)

"Indeed, Allah does not guide the extravagant, the liar."
(*Ghafir 40:28*)

Conclusion

By identifying these attributes, injustice, rebellion, disbelief, betrayal, lying, and extravagance, the Quran explains that Allah's supportive guidance is reserved for those who demonstrate sincerity, humility, and a willingness to follow His universal guidance. Conversely, those who persist in these behaviors render themselves ineligible for further guidance, in accordance with the divine laws that govern human accountability.

10. Love, Fear, Reverential Awe and Hope

The terms “khawf” (fear) and “khashyah” (reverential awe) are often treated as interchangeable, while they present different foundation of worship.

1. Love: The Foundation of the Believer's Relationship with Allah

If we seek the clearest Qur'anic statement describing the relationship between Allah and His believing servants, few verses are more explicit than Allah's words:

قال تعالى: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا مَنْ يَرْتَدَّ مِنْكُمْ عَنْ دِينِهِ فَسَوْفَ يَأْتِي اللَّهَ بِقَوْمٍ يُحِبُّهُمْ وَيُحِبُّونَهُ﴾ (المائدة: ٥٤)

"O you who believe! Whoever among you turns back from his religion, Allah will bring forth a people whom He loves and who love Him..." (Al-Ma'ida 5:54)

This verse is remarkable in both its wording and its order. Allah does not begin by describing the believers' love for Him. Rather, He begins with **His love for them**:

"...whom He loves and who love Him."

This sequence is deeply meaningful. The believer's love for Allah is not an isolated human emotion; it is a response to Allah's mercy, guidance, generosity, and grace. Every blessing the servant

receives is a manifestation of Allah's favor, and recognizing these blessings naturally gives rise to love for the One who bestowed them.

The Qur'an further confirms this relationship when Allah commands His Messenger:

قال تعالى: ﴿قُلْ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ تُحِبُّونَ اللَّهَ فَاتَّبِعُونِي يُحْبِبْكُمُ اللَّهُ وَيَغْفِرْ لَكُمْ ذُنُوبَكُمْ﴾ (آل عمران: ٣١)

"Say, 'If you truly love Allah, then follow me; Allah will love you and forgive your sins.'" (Al-Imran 3:31)

Love is therefore both the beginning and the goal of the believer's journey. Love for Allah is demonstrated through obedience, and obedience is rewarded by Allah's love and forgiveness.

This understanding is reinforced throughout the Qur'an, where Allah repeatedly declares His love for those who embody the qualities He desires:

- those who do good (2:195)
- those who repent (2:222)
- those who purify themselves (2:222)
- those who are patient (3:146)
- those who trust in Him (3:159)
- those who act justly (5:42; 49:9)

The Qur'an therefore presents worship not merely as compliance with commands, but as the natural expression of a loving relationship between the Creator and His servant. The believer does not obey Allah only because he fears punishment or hopes for reward, but because he has come to know Allah's mercy, wisdom, justice, generosity, and perfection. As knowledge of Allah increases, love naturally deepens, and obedience becomes an act of devotion rather than mere obligation.

For this reason, the Qur'an presents **love as the foundation upon which the other actions of the heart are built**, while fear, reverential awe, and hope each play their own complementary role in nurturing and protecting that relationship.

2. Fear: The Guardian of the Heart

Fear also occupies an essential place in the Qur'anic worldview, but its role is different from that of love.

Fear protects the believer from heedlessness, restrains him from sin, and reminds him of the consequences of disobedience. It serves as a spiritual safeguard that keeps the heart alert and the believer conscious of his accountability before Allah.

The Qur'an repeatedly warns against following desires, neglecting Allah's commands, and becoming secure from His judgment. Such warnings are not intended to create despair but to preserve the believer's moral vigilance.

An appropriate analogy is that of a warning system in a vehicle. The warning light is not the destination, nor is it the purpose of the journey. Its function is to alert the driver whenever danger threatens, allowing the journey to continue safely. Likewise, fear protects the believer's relationship with Allah without becoming the relationship itself.

Fear, therefore, is not the foundation of worship but one of the means by which that relationship is preserved.

3. Reverential Awe (Khashyah): The Fruit of Knowing Allah

While the Qur'an speaks frequently about fear, it distinguishes **khashyah** from ordinary fear.

Khashyah is not simply fear of punishment. Rather, it is a profound reverence that arises from truly knowing Allah.

The Qur'an states:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى اللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ الْعُلَمَاءُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَزِيزٌ غَفُورٌ﴾ (فاطر: ٢٨)

"Only those of His servants who possess knowledge truly have reverential awe of Allah." (Fatir 35:28)

Significantly, this verse appears after a passage describing the diversity and magnificence of Allah's creation. The Qur'an teaches that reflection upon the signs of creation deepens one's

knowledge of the Creator, and that this knowledge gives rise to reverential awe.

Khashyah is therefore the natural fruit of recognizing Allah's greatness, majesty, wisdom, and perfection. It inspires obedience not merely because one fears punishment, but because one stands in awe of the One who deserves complete reverence.

For this reason, "**reverential awe**" captures the Qur'anic meaning more accurately than the simple word *fear*. It combines deep respect, humility, admiration, and awareness of Allah's majesty, producing a willing desire to obey Him and avoid anything that displeases Him.

4. Hope: The Motivation to Persevere

The Qur'an likewise gives hope a central place in the believer's life.

Hope is not wishful thinking, nor does it excuse negligence. Rather, it is confidence in Allah's mercy coupled with sincere effort to earn His pleasure. Allah says:

قال تعالى: ﴿إِنَّ الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا وَالَّذِينَ هَاجَرُوا وَجَاهَدُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ أُولَٰئِكَ يَرْجُونَ رَحْمَتَ اللَّهِ﴾^ج (البقرة: ٢١٨)

"Indeed, those who believe, those who emigrated, and those who strive in the cause of Allah, it is they who hope for the mercy of Allah." (Al-Baqarah 2:218)

Notice that the Qur'an joins hope with faith, sacrifice, and striving. Genuine hope motivates action rather than replacing it.

Hope protects the believer from despair after falling into sin. It strengthens perseverance during hardship and reminds him that Allah's mercy is always greater than his shortcomings. It keeps the door of repentance open and encourages continual return to Allah.

5. The Harmony of the Actions of the Heart

The Qur'an does not present these qualities as competing emotions but as complementary dimensions of a healthy relationship with Allah.

Love draws the believer toward Allah.

Reverential awe deepens that love through greater knowledge of His majesty.

Fear protects the heart from straying.

Hope prevents despair and strengthens perseverance.

Together they produce the balanced heart that the Qur'an seeks to cultivate.

Some scholars have beautifully compared this relationship to a bird in flight. Love is the head that guides its direction, while fear and hope are its two wings. Without either wing, the bird cannot remain balanced. Without its head, it loses its destination altogether.

Likewise, the believer advances toward Allah with a heart filled with love, strengthened by reverential awe, protected by fear, and sustained by hope. None of these qualities can replace the others; each fulfills a unique role in perfecting worship and drawing the servant ever closer to his Lord.

Reflection

Before opening the Qur'an, ask yourself:

- Am I approaching the Qur'an out of love for Allah and a desire to hear His words?
- Does my knowledge of Allah increase my reverential awe of Him?
- Does fear keep me away from sin without leading me to despair?
- Does hope in Allah's mercy inspire me to repent, persevere, and strive for greater obedience?

When these qualities come together in their proper balance, the believer approaches the Qur'an with the heart that Allah intended—a heart prepared to receive guidance, grow in faith, and translate His words into righteous action.

Characteristics of Those Whom Allah Loves

1. Faith and Belief

- a. Believe in Allah, His angels, His books, His messengers, and the Day of Judgment.
- b. Make no distinction among Allah's messengers.
- c. Invoke no deity besides Allah.

2. Worship and Devotion

- a. Establish prayer, observe fasting, perform Hajj, and remember Allah and the Hereafter frequently.
- b. Place trust in Allah and maintain humility and reverence (khushoo) in prayer, including the night prayer.
- c. Engage regularly with the Qur'an through both recitation and reflection.

3. Repentance and Gratitude

- a. Seek Allah's forgiveness frequently and acknowledge His blessings.
- b. Repent sincerely after committing sin.

4. Charity and Financial Ethics

- a. Give charity generously, spend with moderation, and avoid both extravagance and miserliness.
- b. Avoid riba and gambling, and safeguard the wealth of others.

5. Character and Morality

- a. Speak truthfully, bear honest witness, and use respectful speech.
- b. Avoid arrogance, suspicion, backbiting, and insulting others.
- c. Exercise self-restraint.

6. Patience, Forgiveness, and Humility

- a. Practice patience, forgive others, and remain content with Allah's decree.
- b. Walk humbly and respond peacefully to ignorant speech.

7. Community Responsibility and Social Ethics

- a. Enjoin what is right, forbid what is wrong, and avoid vain talk.
- b. Fulfill trusts and honor covenants faithfully.
- c. Seek permission before entering others' homes and verify information before acting upon it.

8. Justice and Legal Conduct

- a. Uphold justice and maintain proper legal documentation.
- b. Ensure fair and just retribution for crimes.

9. Striving, Unity, and Mutual Support

- a. Strive in the cause of Allah with wealth and life, support fellow believers, and preserve the unity of the community.
- b. Honor and protect the sanctity of human life.

10. Personal Conduct and Family Life

- a. Maintain cleanliness and consume only lawful (halal) provisions.
- b. Control anger, avoid intoxicants, and preserve chastity.
- c. Pray for righteous spouses and descendants and strive to become an example of taqwa.

List of Major Sins and Shameful Deeds

1. Associating partners with Allah (Shirk)
2. Neglecting prayer (Salah) (
3. Murder (Taking a life unjustly)
4. Consuming usury (Riba)
5. Consuming the wealth of orphans
6. Adultery or fornication (Zina)
7. Slandering chaste women
8. Breaking covenants
9. Drinking alcohol or Gambling
10. Despairing of the mercy of Allah
11. Undutiful to parents
12. Severing ties of kinship
13. False testimony
14. Fleeing from battle
15. Homosexuality - The Immorality of the People of Lot
16. Speaking About Allah Without Knowledge

Part 4: Poems

A Believer's Covenant

Our faith is placed in Allah alone;
His Messenger is our trusted guide.
His Book illumines every path;
His angels watch us from His side.

We spread the message born of peace;
We honor every human soul.
In every word and every deed,
His pleasure is our highest goal.

Our prayers awaken heart and mind;
The Qur'an lights our daily way.
We seek His pardon every dawn
And strive to follow and obey.

Before another's door we pause;
With courtesy we seek to enter.
Justice governs all our dealings;
Truth remains our constant measure.

We guard our tongues from empty speech;
We master anger, pride, and spite.
We cherish life, preserve our trust,
And walk with purity and light.

The orphan finds a friend in us;
The poor receive a generous hand.
We strengthen families with love,
And build the peace that Allah planned.

We neither deal in usury,
Nor profit from another's pain.
Integrity becomes our wealth,
Contentment is our richest gain.

In hardship we remain steadfast;
In mercy we refuse despair.
We honor those who nurtured us,
For Paradise begins with care.

One is our Lord, without a peer—
The Wise, the Merciful, Supreme.
His Messenger showed us the path
Where faith is lived, not merely dreamed.

Prayer remains our firmest pillar;
Justice is our lasting aim.
We stand for truth with patient hearts,
And never bargain with His Name.

Our promises are faithfully kept;
Our trusts are honored to the end.
We turn away from every wrong
And hasten always to amend.

Should we stumble, we rise again,
For wide His mercy ever stays.
His door remains forever open
To hearts returning to His ways.

O Allah, make us among those
Who live by every word You send.
Let love of You fill every heart,
Until we meet You in the end.

Those Who Turned from the Straight Path

And Chose Blindness over Guidance

The tyrant steals beneath the night,
With neither noble guide nor light.

The sinner follows vain desire,
Rejecting truth and duty's call.

The disbeliever turns away
From guidance shining clear as day.

The faithless one betrays his trust
And binds his days with sin and shame.

The liar spreads his slander wide,
Misleading others through his lies.

The wasteful fool misuses well
The blessings granted by his Lord;
He lives in heedlessness and pain,
His gifts neglected and ignored.

O soul, pursue your Lord's good pleasure,
The Lord of all that lives and dies;
And keep yourself forever distant
From every path where wrongdoing lies.

**We ask Allah to protect us from these qualities and to
guide us to the Straight Path.**

Bibliography

A Note on Methodology

The definitions and conceptual framework presented in this book are derived **first and foremost from the Qur'an's own internal usage**. Each key concept has been studied by collecting and examining all relevant Qur'anic verses so that the Qur'an may explain itself.

The primary objective of this work has not been to survey the opinions of later scholars, but to allow the Qur'an to define its own terminology and conceptual framework.

Classical Qur'anic commentaries, Arabic lexicons, and authentic collections of Hadith have been consulted where they clarify linguistic usage, historical context, or prophetic application. These sources have been used to support the study, not to determine its definitions independently of the Qur'an.

Accordingly, the references listed below should be understood as supporting sources that complement, rather than replace, the Qur'an as the primary interpreter of its own message.

Primary Sources

To help you enrich your understanding of the Noble Quran,
and guide you to act according to the teachings of the very words of
Allah.

- **The Noble Qur'an** (Primary source throughout this work.)
- **Sahih al-Bukhari**
(Primary source for authenticated Prophetic traditions.)
- **Sahih Muslim**
(Primary source for authenticated Prophetic traditions.)

Classical Qur'anic Exegesis

- **Al-Tabari**
Jami' al-Bayan fi Ta'wil Ay al-Qur'an
(One of the earliest and most authoritative classical Qur'anic commentaries.)
- **Al-Qurtubi**
Al-Jami' li Ahkam al-Qur'an
(Particularly consulted for legal and linguistic discussions.)
- **Al-Raghib al-Isfahani**
Mufradat Alfaz al-Qur'an
(Primary lexical reference for Qur'anic terminology.)

Qur'anic Studies

- **Al-Zarkashi**
Al-Burhan fi 'Ulum al-Qur'an
(Consulted for principles of Qur'anic sciences and interpretation.)

Creed and Spirituality

- **Ibn Taymiyyah**

Majmu' al-Fatawa

(Consulted on matters of creed and methodology.)

- **Ibn al-Qayyim**

Ighathat al-Lahfan min Masayid al-Shaytan

(Consulted regarding the actions of the heart.)

- **Abd al-Qadir Badran**

Al-Madkhal ila Madhhab al-Imam Ahmad ibn Hanbal

(Consulted on the methodology of the Hanbali school.)

Lexicons

- **Al-Fayruzabadi**

Al-Qamus al-Muhit

(Consulted for classical Arabic vocabulary.)

About the Authors

Dr. Mamdouh M. Salama

Dr. Mamdouh M. Salama is a Life Fellow of the American Society of Mechanical Engineers (ASME) and a retired Senior Engineering Fellow from a major oil company. He earned his B.S. in Mechanical Engineering with highest distinction in Egypt, followed by M.S. and Sc.D. degrees from the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT).

Over his distinguished career, Dr. Salama authored over 150 technical papers, received 25 patents, and edited more than 30 international conference proceedings. He chaired numerous conferences on Offshore and Arctic developments and was the recipient of multiple industry awards.

Beyond engineering, Dr. Mamdouh M. Salama is an active speaker at Islamic centers in the Houston area, where he delivers Friday khutbahs and weekend lectures. He has written articles on Islam for various newspapers and has addressed both Muslim and non-Muslim audiences on Islamic faith, values, and Qur'anic guidance.

He is the author of *Your Reflection in the Mirror of Islam*, which was reviewed and approved by the Al-Azhar Religious Committee for distribution in the West. His book “Guided by Divine Purpose: Your Life in Light of Eternity” has been reviewed by scholars from Al-Azhar University and is currently being published.

Dr. Salama has also authored several other works that are undergoing scholarly review by scholars from Al-Azhar University in preparation for publication, including:

- Jewels of the Quran: Gems of Guidance from the 30 Juz
- The Qur'an: A Blueprint for Civilization and Salvation
- Minds Alive: Teaching Children to Ask: "What Do You See?"
- The Quran: Introduction to its Structure, Strategy, and Study
- The Awliya of Allah in the Light of the Qur'an: Their Qualities as Embodied by the Perfect Example, Prophet Muhammad ﷺ
- From Al-Fatiha to An-Nas: The Central Theme of Every Surah

These works reflect his commitment to making the guidance of the Qur'an and the Prophetic example accessible to contemporary readers, while combining careful study, scholarly review, spiritual reflection, and practical application.

Dr. Ismail Elshirbini

Dr. Ismail Ibrahim Elshirbini Abdelfattah is an Egyptian educator, researcher, and trainer specializing in Curriculum and Instruction, English Language Teaching, and Arabic Teaching for Non-Native Speakers. He holds a Ph.D. in Education from Mansoura University and has served in several academic, educational, and leadership positions at Al-Azhar Al-Sharif.

He has taught at various colleges of Al-Azhar University, supervised educational development projects, contributed to curriculum design, and participated in the preparation of Arabic language programs for international learners. He is also the author and co-author of numerous research papers, educational publications, and training programs in language teaching, educational innovation, and teacher development.

Dr. Elshirbini has received specialized training and international recognition in education and professional development, including participation in the U.S. Teaching Excellence and Achievement (TEA) Program. His academic and professional work focuses on educational reform, language education, teacher training, and fostering creativity and excellence in learning.

Dr. Elshirbini chaired the committees responsible for developing and authoring the Advanced-Level English Language series for Al-Azhar Institutes at the pre-university stage under Al-Azhar Al-Sharif. These series include:

- A glimpse of Revelation I , II and III
- Magic Minds
- Tree Tops
- Gen Z
- Paragons
- Rays of wisdom

Dr. Elshirbini headed the committee responsible for developing and authoring the A Glimpse of Revelation series, which aims to present Islamic values and religious concepts in the English language. He participated in numerous educational, curricular, and developmental projects and committees affiliated with Al-Azhar Al-Sharif.

Dr. Elshirbini represented Al-Azhar Al-Sharif in several international organizations and institutions, including:

- UNESCO (United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization)
- ICESCO (Islamic World Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization)
- ALECSO (Arab League Educational, Cultural and Scientific Organization)

Dr. Elshirbini traveled to the United States on several academic and professional visits and participated in international programs specializing in educational leadership development. He participated in Leadership Development Programs at the University of Central Florida (UCF), Florida, USA.

He has been a regular participant in the IATEFL International Conference in the United Kingdom, attending the conference for more than ten consecutive years.

Dr. Elshirbini actively participates in major English language teaching conferences in Egypt and abroad, including:

- NileTESOL Conference
- ILACE Conference
- Numerous other educational, linguistic, and professional development conferences and seminars.

Dr. Elshirbini possesses extensive expertise in curriculum development and planning, teacher training, educational leadership, English language teaching, and international cooperation in the fields of education and culture.